

Hamlet

William Shakespeare · 1603

Standard Ebooks edition (modern text drawing on the 1604–05 Second Quarto and the 1623 First Folio)

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

21 scene lessons plus 2 seminar day(s), a test day and an essay day: 25 class days of 90 minutes, 5 a week (block schedule), 5 weeks
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC
Cover: Caspar David Friedrich, The Monk by the Sea (1808–1810). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–21), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Hamlet survives in three early texts: the First Quarto (1603), the Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623). The reading text is the Standard Ebooks edition, a conflated modern text divided into the conventional 20 scenes plus the cast list. The year shown is the first printing; the play was probably written about 1599–1601. Cite act, scene and line from this edition.

Content note for teachers: Murder, a ghost, feigned and real madness, suicidal thoughts ('To be, or not to be'), Ophelia's possible suicide, sexual wordplay, and multiple on-stage deaths; Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia and Gertrude deserves critical discussion. See the scene notes and the safe-messaging script.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Scaffolded-support track (grade-9 floor): students work from teacher-selected passages with scaffolds, sentence starters and partial-credit probes. **Weeks:** 5. **Class days:** 25 × 90 minutes (21 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Hamlet suggest about revenge and justice?
- What does Hamlet suggest about action and delay?
- What does Hamlet suggest about appearance and reality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about death and mortality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about corruption and the state?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the play in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.

- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the scene quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily scene quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-book test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Scene lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Dramatis Personae (20-minute preview) and Act I, Scene I Act I, Scene II Act I, Scene III Act I, Scene IV	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*revenge and justice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
2	Act I, Scene V *Socratic seminar on revenge and justice* Act II, Scene I Act II, Scene II Act III, Scene I	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*action and delay* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on revenge and justice • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
3	Act III, Scene II Act III, Scene III Act III, Scene IV Act IV, Scene I Act IV, Scene II (20-minute preview) and Act IV, Scene III	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*appearance and reality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
4	Act IV, Scene IV Act IV, Scene V *Socratic seminar on action and delay* Act IV, Scene VI Act IV, Scene VII	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*death and mortality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on action and delay • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
5	Act V, Scene I Act V, Scene II *Whole-book test (90 minutes)*	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*corruption and the state* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do,	Whole-book test and final essay

	Final paper writing workshop (drafting in class; finish the draft as homework) *Final paper: peer review, revision and submission*		discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Whole-book test (90 minutes) • Final paper writing workshop (drafting in class; finish the draft as homework) • Final paper: peer review, revision and submission • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Hamlet

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about William Shakespeare's life or times connects to revenge and justice in “Hamlet”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (revenge and justice, action and delay, appearance and reality).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623).

Historical and cultural context

Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir.

Publication and reception, then and now

Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play.

Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation.

Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's

(1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play.

Main themes

- revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both?
- action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance?
- appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays.
- death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us.
- corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Why it matters

Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

Spoilers · teacher only

The Ghost says Claudius murdered him and demands revenge. Hamlet feigns madness, rejects Ophelia, and stages a play (The Mousetrap) that confirms Claudius's guilt. He spares Claudius at prayer, then kills Polonius, hidden behind a curtain, by mistake. Claudius sends Hamlet to England to be executed; Hamlet escapes, sending Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths. Ophelia goes mad and drowns. Laertes returns for revenge, and Claudius plots a rigged fencing match with a poisoned blade and poisoned wine. Gertrude drinks the poison; Laertes and Hamlet are both wounded with the poisoned blade; Hamlet kills Claudius and dies in Horatio's arms. Fortinbras of Norway takes the throne.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Content note before we start: Today's introduction briefly mentions suicide. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.*
> *Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.*
> **Prompt:** Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

Key literary terms for the unit.

revenge tragedy (a play driven by a quest for vengeance, ending in many deaths); soliloquy (a speech alone revealing thoughts); aside; foil (a character who highlights another by contrast: Laertes and Fortinbras for Hamlet); feigned madness (pretended insanity, an "antic disposition"); play within a play; regicide (killing a king).

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).

About the author. William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623). The world of the book. Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir. Publication and reception. Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play. Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation. Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's (1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" slowly and put it in my own words: After the Ghost appears and beckons Hamlet away, the guard Marcellus says that something is rotten in the state of Denmark. Next, craft. I notice the image of decay applied to a whole country, as if the kingdom were a body going bad. The strongest word is "rotten": it suggests corruption spreading from inside, which fits a murder hidden at the top of the state. Then, effect. What does Marcellus's line suggest about Denmark at the start of the play? My answer: Marcellus senses that the Ghost means a moral sickness in Denmark's rulers; the image of rot runs through the play, as Claudius's secret crime poisons the court, the family and Hamlet's mind.

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" slowly and put it in my own words: After the Ghost appears and beckons Hamlet away, the guard Marcellus says that something is rotten in the state of Denmark. Next, craft. I notice the image of decay applied to a whole country, as if the kingdom were a body going bad. The strongest word is "rotten": it suggests corruption spreading from inside, which fits a murder hidden at the top of the state. Then, effect. What does Marcellus's line suggest about Denmark at the start of the play? My answer: Marcellus senses that the Ghost means a moral sickness in Denmark's rulers; the image of rot runs through the play, as Claudius's secret crime poisons the court, the family and Hamlet's mind.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play. Themes to track: revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both? action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance? appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays. death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us. corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Hamlet: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Hamlet still matter? Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.
Anchor question: Why might Hamlet still be taught today?
Facilitation: Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Shakespeare wrote Hamlet around 1600, near the end of Queen Elizabeth I's reign, when no one knew who would succeed her, and revenge tragedies were popular on the London stage. How might that context shape a play about a disputed throne and revenge? Answer: Accept answers such as: worry about succession made a stolen crown feel urgent; audiences knew the revenge-play formula and Shakespeare questions it; the play reflects anxiety about legitimate rule.
Exit ticket: Shakespeare wrote Hamlet around 1600, near the end of Queen Elizabeth I's reign, when no one knew who would succeed her, and revenge tragedies were popular on the London stage. How might that context shape a play about a disputed throne and revenge?
Answer: Accept answers such as: worry about succession made a stolen crown feel urgent; audiences knew the revenge-play formula and Shakespeare questions it; the play reflects anxiety about legitimate rule.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Dramatis Personae.

Teacher notes · sources: Folger Shakespeare Library, "Shakespeare's life" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-life/); Shakespeare Birthplace Trust, "William Shakespeare" (https://www.shakespeare.org.uk/explore-shakespeare/shakespedia/william-shakespeare/); Folger Shakespeare Library, "Hamlet" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-works/hamlet/); Royal Shakespeare Company, "Hamlet: about the play" (https://www.rsc.org.uk/hamlet/about-the-play); British Library, "Hamlet: the First Quarto (1603)" (https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/hamlet-first-quarto-1603); Saxo Grammaticus, Gesta Danorum, Book III (Amleth) (https://www.gutenberg.org/); Britannica, "Hamlet" (https://www.britannica.com/topic/Hamlet-by-Shakespeare)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The date (about 1599–1601) is a scholarly inference; Q1 (1603) gives a terminus.
- Gabriel Harvey's note cannot be dated exactly; scholars date it between 1598 and 1601.
- Any link between Hamlet and Shakespeare's son Hamnet (died 1596) is speculation; present it as such if raised.

Critical voice: "If the dramas of Shakespeare were to be characterised, each by the particular excellence which distinguishes it from the rest, we must allow to the tragedy of HAMLET the praise of variety." (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note*

on Hamlet; public domain). Bell-ringer: list the tones you expect from a revenge tragedy; return to the list after Act V. *Objective:* Introduce the play's structure and its mix of tones. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.5

Critical voice: “Hamlet is a name: his speeches and sayings but the idle coinage of the poet's brain. What then, are they not real? They are as real as our own thoughts. Their reality is in the reader's mind. It is WE who are Hamlet. This play has a prophetic truth, which is above that of history.” (William Hazlitt, essayist and critic, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays (1817), "Hamlet", "Hamlet"*; public domain). Discussion: is identifying with Hamlet a help or a trap for analysis? *Objective:* Consider why readers identify with Hamlet. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, SL.11-12.1

Critical voice: “And probably more people have thought _Hamlet_ a work of art because they found it interesting, than have found it interesting because it is a work of art. It is the “Mona Lisa” of literature.” (T. S. Eliot, poet and critic, *"Hamlet and His Problems," The Sacred Wood (1920), "Hamlet and His Problems"*; public domain). Provocation: Eliot thinks Hamlet is an "artistic failure." Keep a running log through the unit: evidence for/against. *Objective:* Evaluate competing judgments of the play's artistic success. *Standards:* Common Core W.11-12.1

Lesson 2: Dramatis Personae

Focus: the court of Denmark

Objective: Students will identify at least 5 characters from the cast list and explain, in one sentence each, how each is related to the play's central family or court.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3

Teacher only · spoilers

The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of Hamlet's father.

Background: Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest.

Significance: The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....*
> **Prompt:** If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
> **Sentence starters:** I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
> **Strong response:** A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

> **8–16 min · Background and context · I do (8 min)**
> Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
> *Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest. The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs. Characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Watch for the Ghost: listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.*

> **16–20 min · Closure · I do (4 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the court of Denmark. Key takeaway: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.*

Total: 20 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.
- **Setting:** "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle.
- **Structure:** Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

Symbols and motifs

- **the Ghost:** listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) Hamlet's divided position.
- “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) Gertrude's two roles.
- “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae) Another prince who has lost a father.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings.
Evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae)
Reasoning: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history

Discussion questions

1. If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.

3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Which characters are listed as courtiers? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.
2. Who is king of Denmark at the start? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
3. What is Hamlet's relation to the king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Nephew
4. Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius's
5. Who is Fortinbras? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Prince of Norway
6. Where is the play set? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Denmark
7. Retell the three most important events of “Dramatis Personae” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of…
8. Who is on stage in “Dramatis Personae”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Dramatis Personae” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. In the passage that begins “Claudius, king of Denmark”, who is speaking or being described, and what do they say or do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Literal paraphrase of the anchor passage.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge.
2. What does “Dramatis Personae” suggest about the court of Denmark? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The list shows three sons with

dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the setting in this scene shape what we understand about the court of Denmark? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Claudius, king of Denmark”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Dramatis Personae”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric;…
7. As the opening scene, what does “Dramatis Personae” set up that the rest of Hamlet will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and

why it begins and ends where it does.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Dramatis Personae”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the court of Denmark. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Dramatis Personae”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has

lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Dramatis Personae” treats the court of Denmark with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the court of Denmark? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Hamlet's relation to the king?

   A. Nephew
   B. Cousin
   C. Son
   D. Brother

   Key: A (Nephew)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia?

   A. Claudius's
   B. Polonius's
   C. Horatio's
   D. Gertrude's

   Key: B (Polonius's)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is the play set?

   A. Denmark
   B. England
   C. Poland
   D. Norway

   Key: A (Denmark)

4. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which characters are listed as courtiers?

   Sample answer: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who is Fortinbras?

   A. An actor
   B. A gravedigger
   C. Prince of Norway
   D. A Danish courtier

   Key: C (Prince of Norway)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who is king of Denmark at the start?

   A. Fortinbras
   B. Old Hamlet
   C. Claudius
   D. Polonius

   Key: C (Claudius)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the _____ king”

   Key: present

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and _____ to Hamlet”

   Key: mother

9. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers?

   Sample answer: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge. The evidence is “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) — Gertrude's two roles. This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

10. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

    A. Appearance and reality

    B. Action and delay

    C. Corruption and the state

    D. Revenge and justice

    Key: C (Corruption and the state)

11. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Another prince who has lost a father. The evidence is “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

12. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest?

    Sample answer: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position. The evidence is “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) — Hamlet's divided position. This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

13. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from the opening of “Dramatis Personae” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

    Sample answer: Near the start, “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) — Hamlet's divided position. Later, “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae) — Another prince who has lost a father. The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? ‘Scene: Denmark’: a single kingdom, a court, a castle.

    A. Irony

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Simile

    D. Setting

    Key: D (Setting)

15. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

    A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

B. Claudius at prayer

C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

D. The court of Denmark

Key: D (The court of Denmark)

16. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] What does this passage most clearly show? "Fortinbras, prince of Norway" (Dramatis Personae)

A. Mood: cold and unease.

B. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

C. Another prince who has lost a father.

D. Acceptance before the duel.

Key: C (Another prince who has lost a father.)

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in "Dramatis Personae"? Hamlet is 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king': his whole conflict in one line.

A. Characterization

B. Theme

C. Personification

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: A (Characterization)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king" (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position. The evidence is "Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king" (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. The words "present" and "nephew" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	4, 6, 1, 7, 2, 8, 3, 5, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Sophomore	8, 3, 1, 5, 2, 6, 4, 7, 9, 11, 10, 13, 12	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 2, 6, 7, 3, 5, 1, 8, 9, 11, 10, 12, 13	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 3, 7, 6, 5, 1, 2, 4, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
AP	8, 2, 3, 1, 5, 7, 6, 4, 9, 11, 14, 10, 12	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 3, synthesis 1
College Freshman	4, 3, 5, 1, 8, 6, 2, 7, 9, 15, 10, 11, 12	recall 8, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
College Sophomore	8, 7, 6, 3, 2, 4, 5, 1, 9, 11, 10, 12, 13	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 2, synthesis 2
College Junior	7, 5, 6, 1, 4, 3, 2, 8, 9, 16, 10, 17, 12	recall 8, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
College Senior	4, 6, 3, 7, 1, 2, 5, 8, 9, 11, 10, 17, 12	recall 8, inference 1, analysis 3, synthesis 1

Graduate / PhD	6, 1, 5, 2, 3, 8, 4, 9, 16, 10, 18, 13, 12	recall 7, inference 2, analysis 1, synthesis 3

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Dramatis Personae,” how does Shakespeare show the court of Denmark? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Dramatis Personae, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the court of Denmark? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Dramatis Personae develops the idea of the court of Denmark. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Dramatis Personae (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Dramatis Personae suggests about the court of Denmark. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Dramatis Personae to complicate the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Dramatis Personae within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the court of Denmark responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Dramatis Personae alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the court of Denmark follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Dramatis Personae and its treatment of

the court of Denmark. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Dramatis Personae as evidence for a larger claim about the court of Denmark in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Dramatis Personae as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the court of Denmark. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Claudius, king of Denmark*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

   A. The duel and the deaths

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. Claudius at prayer

   D. The court of Denmark

SAT key: 1. D (The court of Denmark)

Lesson 3: Act I, Scene I

Focus: the Ghost on the battlements

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in "Act I, Scene I" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: This lesson mentions suicide.
Suggested language:
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.

Background: Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic.

Significance: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: foreknowing — knowing in advance; harrows — distresses deeply; tears at; doomsday — the day of final judgment; eruption — an outbreak of trouble; partisan — a long-handled spear with a broad blade. “eruption”: Origin: Middle French éruption; earlier Latin eruptio.
Words: foreknowing: knowing in advance · harrows: distresses deeply; tears at · doomsday: the day of final judgment · eruption: an outbreak of trouble · partisan: a long-handled spear with a broad blade

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic. The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state. Setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “this relief much thanks: ’tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “Who’s there” slowly and put it in my own words: On a cold, dark night, the sentry Bernardo comes to relieve Francisco and calls out "Who's there?" Next, craft. I notice it is the incoming guard who challenges, the wrong way round, which shows how nervous he is. The strongest word is “there”: the word points into darkness at something unseen, the way the whole play searches for hidden truth. Then, effect. Why does the play open with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard? My answer: The play opens with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard because Denmark is uneasy and no one knows who anyone is; the reversed question sets the mood of fear and the central problem of hidden truth.

> *Who’s there* *(Act I, Scene I, Bernardo)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “Who’s there” slowly and put it in my own words: On a cold, dark night, the sentry Bernardo comes to relieve Francisco and calls out "Who's there?" Next, craft. I notice it is the incoming guard who challenges, the wrong way round, which shows how nervous he is. The strongest word is “there”: the word points into darkness at something unseen, the way the whole play searches for hidden truth. Then, effect. Why does the play open with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard? My answer: The play opens with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard because Denmark is uneasy and no one knows who anyone is; the reversed question sets the mood of fear and the central problem of hidden truth.

40–50 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (10 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

> *This bodes some strange eruption to our state (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

50–55 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (5 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

55–60 min · Discussion · We do (5 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
Facilitation: Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?

60–67 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

67–70 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes the Ghost on the battlements. Key takeaway: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

Total: 70 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."
- **Foreshadowing:** The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state."
- **Structure:** The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask).

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "this relief much thanks: 'tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "Sit down awhile; / And let us once again assail your ears, / That are so fortified against our story / What we have two" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) The first line: a play of questions.
- "tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) Mood: cold and unease.

- "This bodes some strange eruption to our state" (Act I, Scene I, Horatio) Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state.
Evidence: "This bodes some strange eruption to our state" (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)
Reasoning: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
foreknowing (noun)	knowing in advance	*If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!*	
harrows (verb)	distresses deeply; tears at	*Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.*	
doomsday (noun)	the day of final judgment	*Upon whose influence Neptune's empire stands / Was sick almost to doomsday with eclipse:*	
eruption (noun)	an outbreak of trouble	*In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*	"eruption": Origin: Middle French éruption; earlier Latin eruptio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/eruption#Etymology)
partisan (noun)	a long-handled spear with a broad blade	*Shall I strike at it with my partisan?*	
lawless (adjective)	uncontrolled	*Hath in the skirts of Norway here and there / Shark'd up a list of lawless resolutes,*	
martial (adjective)	military; warlike	*Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With martial stalk hath he gone by our watch.*	"martial": Origin: Middle French martial; earlier Latin mārtiālis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/martial#Etymology)
needful (adjective)	necessary	*Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it, As needful in our loves, fitting our duty?*	
warlike (adjective)	ready and armed for fighting	*What art thou that usurp'st this time of night, Together with that fair and warlike form In which the majesty of*	

		buried Denmark Did sometimes march? by heaven I charge thee, speak!	

Discussion questions

1. What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the first line of the play? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: 'Who's there?'
2. Where does the scene take place? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The battlements at Elsinore
3. Whom does the Ghost resemble? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The dead King Hamlet
4. Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
5. What does Fortinbras want? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To recover lands his father lost
6. When does the Ghost vanish? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At cockcrow
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!" What does "foreknowing" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: foreknowing: knowing in advance.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Horatio think the Ghost appears? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It bodes some strange eruption to the state.
2. What does “Act I, Scene I” suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “A mote it is to trouble the mind’s eye.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The…
7. How does “Act I, Scene I” build on “Dramatis Personae”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes a story's opening scene frightening?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Why open with guards rather than royalty? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment about atmosphere and perspective.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost on the battlements. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?",

from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene I” treats the Ghost on the battlements with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: "tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Upon whose influence Neptune's empire stands / Was sick almost to doomsday with eclipse:", what does "doomsday" most nearly mean?
    A. a builder of ships
    B. a border region
    C. the day of final judgment
    D. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang

    Key: C (the day of final judgment)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Hath in the skirts of Norway here and there / Shark'd up a list of _____ resolutes," Word bank: lawless, harrows, doomsday, foreknowing

    Key: lawless
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.", what does "harrows" most nearly mean?
    A. a person who attends a royal court
    B. distresses deeply; tears at
    C. a thief; pickpocket
    D. a solemn declaration

    Key: B (distresses deeply; tears at)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With _____ stalk hath he gone by our watch." Word bank: harrows, doomsday, martial, foreknowing

    Key: martial
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] When does the Ghost vanish?
    A. At noon
    B. When Hamlet arrives

C. At cockcrow

D. At midnight

Key: C (At cockcrow)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does the scene take place?

   A. A graveyard

   B. A ship

   C. The throne room

   D. The battlements at Elsinore

   Key: D (The battlements at Elsinore)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it, As _____ in our loves, fitting our duty?” Word bank: foreknowing, needful, harrows, doomsday

   Key: needful

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.”, what does “eruption” most nearly mean?

   A. sharply cold

   B. an outbreak of trouble

   C. roundabout methods

   D. substitute

   Key: B (an outbreak of trouble)

9. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is the first line of the play?

   Sample answer: 'Who's there?'

10. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The first line: a play of questions. The evidence is “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Mood: cold and unease. The evidence is “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo)

    A. The first line: a play of questions.

    B. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    C. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

    D. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    Key: A (The first line: a play of questions.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Horatio think the Ghost appears?

    Sample answer: It bodes some strange eruption to the state. The evidence is “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio) — Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Appearance and reality

    D. Corruption and the state

    Key: D (Corruption and the state)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.5] Which literary element does this describe in "Act I, Scene I"? The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes 'some strange eruption to our state.'

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Theme

    C. Personification

    D. Tone / mood

    Key: A (Foreshadowing)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The first line: a play of questions. The evidence is "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.".

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!", what does "foreknowing" most nearly mean?

    A. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

    B. knowing in advance

    C. trickery

    D. a person who attends a royal court

    Key: B (knowing in advance)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene I, Horatio: "This bodes some strange _____ to our state"

    Key: eruption

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Fortinbras want?

    A. To marry Ophelia

    B. To become king of England

    C. To join Hamlet

    D. To recover lands his father lost

    Key: D (To recover lands his father lost)

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene I, Francisco: "tis _____ cold, / And I am sick at heart"

    Key: bitter

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene I”? Midnight, cold, on the battlements: 'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart.'

    A. Setting

    B. Alliteration

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Allusion

    Key: A (Setting)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio).

    Sample answer: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.". The evidence is “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio) — Horatio's reading of the Ghost. This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Dramatis Personae to Act I, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Dramatis Personae, the text reads “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” — Hamlet's divided position. In Act I, Scene I, “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo), which shows the first line: a play of questions. Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Horatio's reading of the Ghost. The evidence is “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The words “eruption” and “strange” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Why open with guards rather than royalty?

    Sample answer: A judgment about atmosphere and perspective. The evidence is “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo), which shows the first line: a play of questions. This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.".

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost?

    A. Osric

    B. Horatio

    C. Hamlet

    D. Laertes

    Key: B (Horatio)

27. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Shall I strike at it with my _____?” Word bank: foreknowing, harrows, doomsday, partisan

    Key: partisan

28. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene I”?

    A. The Ghost on the battlements

B. Polonius spies on Laertes

C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

D. Claudius at prayer

Key: A (The Ghost on the battlements)

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Whom does the Ghost resemble?

A. Claudius

B. Fortinbras

C. The dead King Hamlet

D. Polonius

Key: C (The dead King Hamlet)

30. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 19 reveal about the character or situation? “O, farewell, honest soldier: Who hath relieved you?” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 19) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The words “farewell” and “relieved” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 33 shapes its tone: “Peace, break thee off; look, where it comes again!” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words its wording (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 33) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

32. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 48 shapes its tone: “As thou art to thyself: Such was the very armour he had on When he the ambitious Norway combated; So frown’d he once, when, in an angry parle, He smote the sledded Polacks on the ice. ’Tis strange.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “ambitious” and “combated” (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 48) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Mood: cold and unease. The evidence is “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The words “bitter” and “heart” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.".

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 63 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “And then it started like a guilty thing Upon a fearful summons.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 63) develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Its words “started” and “fearful” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern

returns in “I have heard, The cock, that is the trumpet to the morn, Doth with his lofty and shrill-sounding throat Awake the god…” (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 63), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

35. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 64: “It faded on the _____ of the cock.” Word bank: westward, crowing, sensible, rivals
    Key: crowing

36. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco)
    A. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
    B. Mood: cold and unease.
    C. Gertrude on the Player Queen.
    D. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

    Key: B (Mood: cold and unease.)

37. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene I, paragraph 66 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Let’s do’t, I pray; and I this morning know Where we shall find him most conveniently.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 66) develops appearance and reality: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Its words “conveniently” and “morning” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “O, farewell, honest soldier: Who hath relieved you?” (Act I, Scene I, paragraph 19), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

38. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] What does this passage most clearly show? “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)
    A. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.
    B. Hamlet's claim at the grave.
    C. Hamlet's new trust in providence.
    D. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    Key: A (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	3, 17, 18, 19, 8, 6, 2, 4, 20, 10, 13, 12, 14, 21, 22, 23	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	4, 19, 3, 8, 9, 1, 2, 17, 12, 13, 10, 24, 14, 21, 23, 25	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	26, 27, 18, 2, 7, 8, 6, 13, 28, 11, 10, 12, 22, 14, 25, 23	recall 7, inference 5, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Senior	17, 8, 20, 29, 27, 5, 12, 13, 11, 10, 14, 21, 22, 16, 25, 23	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 3
AP	4, 27, 3, 10, 28, 30, 12, 22, 14, 31, 32, 23, 16, 33, 25, 34	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 5
College Freshman	20, 7, 35, 36, 10, 30, 12, 31, 32, 24, 14, 21, 23, 25, 37, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	18, 2, 6, 30, 12, 10, 15, 14, 32, 31, 22, 23, 25, 34, 37, 33	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	27, 8, 2, 28, 12, 30, 31, 22, 14, 32, 33, 25, 16, 23, 37, 34	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 6
College Senior	27, 2, 38, 12, 13, 11, 28, 30, 14, 31, 32, 34, 37, 16, 23, 25	recall 2, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	35, 27, 6, 12, 30, 15, 14, 22, 31, 32, 23, 37, 33, 34, 25, 16	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show the Ghost on the battlements? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost on the battlements? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene I suggests about the Ghost on the battlements. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost on the battlements responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost on the battlements follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene I and its treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost on the battlements in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Upon whose influence Neptune's empire stands / Was sick almost to doomsday with eclipse:*

   As used in the text, what does the word "doomsday" most nearly mean?

   A. the day of final judgment

   B. necessary

   C. military; warlike

   D. ready and armed for fighting

2. *A mote it is to trouble the mind's eye. In the most high and palmy state of Rome, A little ere the mightiest Julius fell, The graves stood tenantless and the sheeted dead Did squeak and gibber in the Roman streets: As stars with trains of fire and dews of blood, Disasters in the sun; and the moist star Upon whose influence Neptune's empire stands Was sick almost to doomsday with eclipse: And even the like precurse of fierce events, As harbingers preceding still the fates And prologue to the omen coming on, Have heaven and earth together demonstrated Unto our climatures and countrymen.— But soft, behold! lo, where it comes again!*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene I"?

   A. Worms and kings

   B. The Ghost on the battlements

   C. The Mousetrap

   D. The closet scene

SAT key: 1. A (the day of final judgment); 2. B (The Ghost on the battlements)

Lesson 4: Act I, Scene II

Focus: Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “It was the moral shock of the sudden ghastly disclosure of his mother's true nature, falling on him when his heart was aching with love, and his body doubtless was weakened by sorrow.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III*; public domain). Close reading of "O, that this too too solid flesh": is the father's death or the mother's remarriage the deeper wound? *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's first soliloquy and the source of his grief. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (suicidal thoughts, incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Hamlet wishes his flesh would melt and regrets that God forbids 'self-slaughter.' Use the safe-messaging script; focus on grief and what Hamlet is reacting to. Hamlet calls the marriage 'incestuous sheets' (the period view of marrying a dead husband's brother). This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…at is your affair in Elsinore? We'll teach you to drink deep ere you depart. My lord, I came to…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What has made Hamlet feel this way?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.

Background: Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university.

Significance: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How long should grief last? Who decides? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenable — kept close; held secret; retrograde — contrary; opposed; yesternight — last night; methinks — it seems to me; countenance — favor and approval. "tenable": Origin: French tenable. "retrograde": Origin: Middle French retrograde; earlier Old French retrograde.
Words: tenable: kept close; held secret · retrograde: contrary; opposed · yesternight: last night · methinks: it seems to me · countenance: favor and approval

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university. The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief. Characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "fie! 'tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "A little more than kin, and less than kind" slowly and put it in my own words: When Claudius calls him "my cousin Hamlet, and my son," Hamlet mutters that they are a little more than kin and less than kind. Next, craft. I notice the wordplay on kin and kind, two words that sound alike but mean family and natural feeling. The strongest word is "kind": it carries two meanings, "loving" and "natural," and Hamlet denies Claudius both. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's first line reveal about how he feels toward Claudius? My answer: Hamlet's first words are a bitter aside; he resents the hasty marriage that made his uncle his stepfather, and his punning shows the sharp wit he will use as a weapon.

> *A little more than kin, and less than kind* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "A little more than kin, and less than kind" slowly and put it in my own words: When Claudius calls him "my cousin Hamlet, and my son," Hamlet mutters that they are a little more than kin and less than kind. Next, craft. I notice the wordplay on kin and kind, two words that sound alike but mean family and natural feeling. The strongest word is "kind": it carries two meanings, "loving" and "natural," and Hamlet denies Claudius both. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's first line reveal about how he feels toward Claudius? My answer: Hamlet's first words are a bitter aside; he resents the hasty marriage that made his uncle his stepfather, and his punning shows the sharp wit he will use as a weapon.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

> *Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not "seems* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides? Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Key takeaway: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
- **Structure:** First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt."

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “fie! ’tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “hear your enemy say so, / Nor shall you do mine ear that violence, / To make it truster of your own report / Against” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.
- “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Appearance versus reality.
- “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) First soliloquy.
- “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet on Gertrude.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs.
Evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history

tenable (adjective)	kept close; held secret	*I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.*	"tenable": Origin: French tenable. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/tenable#Etymology)
retrograde (adjective)	contrary; opposed	*For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.*	"retrograde": Origin: Middle French retrograde; earlier Old French retrograde. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/retrograde#Etymology)
yesternight (noun)	last night	*My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*	
methinks (verb)	it seems to me	*My father!—methinks I see my father.*	
countenance (noun)	favor and approval	*A countenance more in sorrow than in anger.*	
nighted (adjective)	dark as night; here, mourning-black	*Good Hamlet, cast thy nighted colour off, And let thine eye look like a friend on Denmark.*	
instrumental (adjective)	serviceable; useful	*The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more instrumental to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father.*	"instrumental": Origin: Medieval Latin īnstrūmentālis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/instrumental#Etymology)
courtier (noun)	a person who attends a royal court	*For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.*	"courtier": Origin: Anglo-Norman corteour. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/courtier#Etymology)
requite (verb)	repay	*I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.*	
dexterity (noun)	quickness; speed	*O, most wicked speed, to post With such dexterity to incestuous sheets!*	

Discussion questions

1. How long should grief last? Who decides?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the funeral baked meats? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They coldly furnished forth the marriage tables.
2. Whom has Claudius married? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. Where does Hamlet want to go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Wittenberg
4. Where is Laertes allowed to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: France
5. How long after the funeral was the marriage? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Less than two months
6. What does Hamlet wear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Black mourning clothes
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves." What does "tenable" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: tenable: kept close; held secret.

Inferential / analytical

1. How does Claudius try to win Hamlet over? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He calls him his son and heir and urges him to stop mourning.
2. What does “Act I, Scene II” suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. On diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “We doubt it nothing: heartily farewell.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the…
7. How does “Act I, Scene II” build on “Act I, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “How long should grief last? Who decides?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's anger at Gertrude justified? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position

that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene II” treats Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene III” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2,

SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet wear?

   A. A crown

   B. Black mourning clothes

   C. Armour

   D. Rags

   Key: B (Black mourning clothes)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom has Claudius married?

   A. A Norwegian princess

   B. Gertrude

   C. Hamlet's sister

   D. Ophelia

   Key: B (Gertrude)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How long after the funeral was the marriage?

   A. A year

   B. Less than two months

   C. A week

   D. Five years

   Key: B (Less than two months)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does Hamlet want to go?

   A. France

   B. Norway

   C. Wittenberg

   D. England

   Key: C (Wittenberg)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Good Hamlet, cast thy _____ colour off, And let thine eye look like a friend on Denmark.” Word bank: retrograde, yesternight,

tenable, nighted

Key: nighted

6. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say about the funeral baked meats?
   Sample answer: They coldly furnished forth the marriage tables.
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more _____ to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father." Word bank: yesternight, tenable, instrumental, retrograde
   Key: instrumental
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "A _____ more in sorrow than in anger." Word bank: retrograde, countenance, tenable, yesternight
   Key: countenance
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "My father!—methinks I see my father.", what does "methinks" most nearly mean?
   A. seize and hold
   B. it seems to me
   C. sugared; flattering
   D. in a state of gross sin, unprepared

   Key: B (it seems to me)
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is Laertes allowed to go?
    A. France
    B. Wittenberg
    C. Poland
    D. England

    Key: A (France)
11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not 'seems" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Appearance versus reality. The evidence is "Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not 'seems" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] How does Claudius try to win Hamlet over?
    Sample answer: He calls him his son and heir and urges him to stop mourning. The evidence is "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. The evidence is "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Which literary element does this describe in "Act I, Scene II"? Hamlet's first line is a pun: 'A little more than kin, and less than kind.'
    A. Diction / vocabulary
    B. Irony
    C. Foreshadowing
    D. Plot

Key: A (Diction / vocabulary)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Death and mortality

    D. Action and delay

    Key: B (Appearance and reality)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act I, Scene I to Act I, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene I, Bernardo, the text reads “Who’s there”, which shows the first line: a play of questions. In Act I, Scene II, “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene II, Hamlet: “A _____ more than kin, and less than kind”

    Key: little

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest _____, cousin, and our son.”

    Word bank: tenable, courtier, yesternight, retrograde

    Key: courtier

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal’d this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.”, what does “tenable” most nearly mean?

    A. slandered; spoken ill of

    B. not yet having feathers; immature

    C. substitute

    D. kept close; held secret

    Key: D (kept close; held secret)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.”, what does “yesternight” most nearly mean?

    A. last night

    B. a mine of ore

    C. a bird easily caught; a fool

    D. uncontrolled

    Key: A (last night)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt,"

condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!". The evidence is “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) — First soliloquy. This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet's anger at Gertrude justified? Argue.
Sample answer: A reasoned view: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. The evidence is “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!".

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene II”? Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.
A. Theme
B. Personification
C. Symbolism
D. Characterization
Key: D (Characterization)

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: First soliloquy. The evidence is “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “would” and “solid” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act I, Scene II?
A. “How is it that the clouds still hang on you?”
B. “Take thy fair hour, Laertes; time be thine, And thy best graces spend it at thy will!”
C. “But now, my cousin Hamlet, and my son—”
D. “Not so, my lord; I am too much i’ the sun.”
Key: B (“Take thy fair hour, Laertes; time be thine, And thy best graces spend it at thy will!”)

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 59 reveal about the character or situation? “O, yes, my lord; he wore his beaver up.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 59) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “beaver” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 8 reveal about the character or situation? “He hath, my lord, wrung from me my slow leave By laboursome petition, and at last Upon his will I seal’d my hard consent: I do beseech you, give him leave to go.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 8) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “laboursome” and “petition” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “Let not thy mother lose her prayers, Hamlet: I pray thee, stay with us; go not to Wittenberg.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
Sample answer: The words “prayers” and “mother” (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather

than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 45 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “This to me In dreadful secrecy impart they did; And I with them the third night kept the watch: Where, as they had deliver’d, both in time, Form of the thing, each word made true and good, The apparition comes: I knew your father; These…” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 45) develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". Its words “apparition” and “dreadful” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “My lord, upon the platform where we watch’d.” (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 47), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Appearance versus reality. The evidence is “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “seems” and “madam” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!".

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 26 shapes its tone: “Sir, my good friend; I’ll change that name with you: And what make you from Wittenberg, Horatio?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “change” and “friend” (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 26) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 37 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “I saw him once; he was a goodly king.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 37) develops corruption and the state: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". Its words “goodly” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Season your admiration for a while With an attent ear, till I may deliver, Upon the witness of these gentlemen, This…” (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 43), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 51? “As I do live, my _____’d lord, ’tis true; And we did think it writ down in our duty To let you know of it.”

    A. student

    B. honour

    C. depart

    D. clouds

    Key: B (honour)

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider

a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. The evidence is “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “little” and “than” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!".

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene II, paragraph 3 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Therefore our sometime sister, now our queen, The imperial jointress to this warlike state, Have we, as ’twere with a defeated joy— With an auspicious and a dropping eye, With mirth in funeral and with dirge in marriage, In equal scale…” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 3) develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". Its words “auspicious” and “jointress” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Though yet of Hamlet our dear brother’s death The memory be green, and that it us befitted To bear our hearts in grief…” (Act I, Scene II, paragraph 3), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

36. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene II”?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

    C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    D. The court of Denmark

    Key: C (Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 17, 2, 10, 9, 18, 7, 19, 20, 8, 11, 12, 15, 14, 21, 22	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 7, 10, 3, 18, 19, 4, 1, 12, 11, 13, 15, 23, 24, 16, 22	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 3, 6, 4, 7, 25, 12, 26, 11, 27, 21, 28, 23, 15, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 8, 9, 20, 1, 12, 27, 26, 25, 15, 28, 23, 24, 29, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 8, 1, 2, 13, 11, 12, 31, 28, 23, 24, 15, 29, 32, 22, 16	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	8, 17, 33, 27, 26, 12, 25, 31, 28, 14, 15, 24, 34, 32, 30, 29	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 3, 5, 12, 25, 27, 15, 28, 24, 23, 31, 34, 32, 29, 22, 16	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	8, 3, 5, 25, 13, 11, 15, 21, 28, 23, 31, 35, 16, 22, 32, 29	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	4, 8, 5, 26, 25, 27, 36, 31, 21, 15, 28, 29, 16, 32, 22, 35	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	5, 8, 2, 12, 25, 28, 24, 31, 15, 14, 35, 29, 32, 30, 16, 22	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene II suggests about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene II and its treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "yesternight" most nearly mean?

   A. repay

   B. a person who attends a royal court

   C. last night

   D. quickness; speed

2. *We doubt it nothing: heartily farewell. Exeunt Voltimand and Cornelius. And now, Laertes, what's the news with you? You told us of some suit; what is't, Laertes? You cannot speak of reason to the Dane, And lose your voice: what wouldst thou beg, Laertes, That shall not be my offer, not thy asking? The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more instrumental to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father. What wouldst thou have, Laertes?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene II"?

   A. Claudius at prayer

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. The duel and the deaths

   D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

SAT key: 1. C (last night); 2. B (Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief)

Lesson 5: Act I, Scene III

Focus: Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene III” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Polonius is a man bred in courts, exercised in business, stored with observation, confident of his knowledge, proud of his eloquence, and declining into dotage.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, note on Act II, Scene ii*; public domain). Annotate Polonius's advice to Laertes for "proud of his eloquence" and "declining into dotage." Is the advice good even if the man is foolish? *Objective:* Analyze Polonius as father and counselor. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Teacher only · spoilers

Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.

Background: Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state.

Significance: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Should parents choose whom their children date? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because....
Prompt: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenders — offers (of love); primrose — flowery and pleasant (the easy path); dalliance — idle, flirtatious play; unfledged — not yet having feathers; immature; borrower — one who borrows. “dalliance”: Origin: Old French dalier. “borrower”: Origin: an English formation from borrow + -er.
Words: tenders: offers (of love) · primrose: flowery and pleasant (the easy path) · dalliance: idle, flirtatious play · unfledged: not yet having feathers; immature · borrower: one who borrows

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state. The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency. Characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" slowly and put it in my own words: Sending Laertes off to France, Polonius gives a list of maxims, including not to borrow or lend money. Next, craft. I notice the balanced, proverb-like phrase "neither... nor," typical of his tidy, quotable advice. The strongest word is "borrower": it frames life in terms of money and reputation, his main concerns. Then, effect. What does Polonius's advice show about his values? My answer: Polonius cares most about appearances and prudence; his advice sounds wise but is calculating, and his later spying shows the same concern with managing how things look.

> *Neither a borrower nor a lender be* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" slowly and put it in my own words: Sending Laertes off to France, Polonius gives a list of maxims, including not to borrow or lend money. Next, craft. I notice the balanced, proverb-like phrase "neither... nor," typical of his tidy, quotable advice. The strongest word is "borrower": it frames life in terms of money and reputation, his main concerns. Then, effect. What does Polonius's advice show about his values? My answer: Polonius cares most about appearances and prudence; his advice sounds wise but is calculating, and his later spying shows the same concern with managing how things look.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

> *This above all: to thine ownself be true* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date? How much choice does Ophelia have?
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Facilitation: How much choice does Ophelia have?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Key takeaway: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.
- **Conflict:** Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
- **Irony:** Polonius advises honesty while he will spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “what loss your honour may sustain, / If with too credent ear you list his songs, / Or lose your heart, or your chaste” (Act I, Scene III, Laertes).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Polonius's advice.
- “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").
- “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia) Ophelia's obedience.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family.
Evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)
Reasoning: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
tenders (noun)	offers (of love)	*He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.*	
primrose (adjective)		*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the*	

	flowery and pleasant (the easy path)	*steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	
dalliance (noun)	idle, flirtatious play	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"dalliance": Origin: Old French dalier. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/dalliance#Etymology)
unfledged (adjective)	not yet having feathers; immature	*Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.*	
borrower (noun)	one who borrows	*Neither a borrower nor a lender be; For loan oft loses both itself and friend, And borrowing dulls the edge of husbandry.*	"borrower": Origin: an English formation from borrow + -er. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/borrower#Etymology)
importuned (verb)	pressed with requests; courted	*My lord, he hath importuned me with love In honourable fashion.*	"importuned": Origin of "importune": Middle French importuner; earlier Medieval Latin importūnor ("to make oneself troublesome"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/importune#Etymology)
libertine (noun)	a person without moral restraint	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"libertine": Origin: Latin libertinus ("a freedman"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/libertine#Etymology)
ungracious (adjective)	lacking God's grace; wicked	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"ungracious": Origin: an English formation from un- + gracious. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ungracious#Etymology)
pastors (noun)	ministers; preachers	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven;*	

		Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.	

Discussion questions

1. Should parents choose whom their children date?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Polonius say about friends? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Grapple tried friends to your soul with hoops of steel.
2. Where is Laertes going? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: France
3. What does Laertes warn Ophelia about? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's love
4. What does Polonius advise about money? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Neither borrow nor lend
5. What does Polonius order Ophelia to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Stop seeing Hamlet
6. How does Ophelia answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: I shall obey
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me." What does "tenders" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: tenders: offers (of love).

Inferential / analytical

1. What is ironic about Polonius's advice to be true to oneself? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He is a manipulator and spy.
2. What does “Act I, Scene III” suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the conflict in this scene shape what we understand about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.
7. How does “Act I, Scene III” build on “Act I, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Should parents choose whom their children date?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what

characters expect or say and what is true.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene III” treats Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.", what does "tenders" most nearly mean?

   A. following

   B. forgetfulness

   C. offers (of love)

   D. wooden flutes

   Key: C (offers (of love))

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.", what does "unfledged" most nearly mean?

   A. not yet having feathers; immature

   B. drinking and revelry

   C. flirting; trifling

   D. people who carry messages

   Key: A (not yet having feathers; immature)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless _____, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede."

   Word bank: primrose, tenders, libertine, dalliance

   Key: libertine

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, Polonius: "This above all: to thine _____ be true"

   Key: ownself

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Ophelia answer?

   A. She laughs

   B. She refuses

   C. She runs away

   D. I shall obey

   Key: D (I shall obey)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Neither a _____ nor a lender be; For loan oft loses both itself and friend, And borrowing dulls the edge of husbandry." Word bank: dalliance, primrose, borrower, tenders

   Key: borrower

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Polonius advise about money?

   A. Neither borrow nor lend

   B. Gamble wisely

   C. Save everything

   D. Spend freely

   Key: A (Neither borrow nor lend)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Laertes warn Ophelia about?

   A. Hamlet's love

   B. Claudius

   C. Polonius's anger

   D. The Ghost

   Key: A (Hamlet's love)

9. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Polonius say about friends?

   Sample answer: Grapple tried friends to your soul with hoops of steel.

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is Laertes going?

    A. England

    B. France

    C. Wittenberg

    D. Norway

    Key: B (France)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Polonius order Ophelia to do?

    A. Go to France

    B. Spy on Claudius

    C. Marry Hamlet

    D. Stop seeing Hamlet

    Key: D (Stop seeing Hamlet)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene III"?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. The Ghost on the battlements

    D. Claudius at prayer

    Key: A (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What is ironic about Polonius's advice to be true to oneself?

    Sample answer: He is a manipulator and spy. The evidence is "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) — Polonius's advice. This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

    A. Appearance and reality

    B. Action and delay

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Death and mortality

    Key: A (Appearance and reality)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "I shall obey, my lord" (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Ophelia's obedience. The evidence is “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “shall” and “obey” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). The evidence is “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “ownself” and “thine” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.".
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My lord, he hath _____ me with love In honourable fashion.” Word bank: tenders, importuned, primrose, dalliance
    Key: importuned
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But, good my brother, Do not, as some _____ pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff’d and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.”
    Word bank: primrose, ungracious, dalliance, tenders
    Key: ungracious
19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, Polonius: “Neither a _____ nor a lender be”
    Key: borrower
20. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Polonius's advice. The evidence is “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate.
    Sample answer: A reasoned judgment: Polonius's advice. The evidence is “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.".
22. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). The evidence is “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.
23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.
    A. Simile
    B. Personification
    C. Theme
    D. Characterization

    Key: D (Characterization)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) supports it: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.". But “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) complicates it: the line (Polonius's advice) shows the same issue from another side, and its “nor” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. The claim is therefore a strong reading, not a complete one, and a careful answer says where it stops applying.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 20: “If it be so, as so ’tis put on me, And that in way of caution, I must tell you, You do not _____ yourself so clearly As it behoves my daughter and your honour.” Word bank: servants, proclaims, understand, circumstance

    Key: understand

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act I, Scene III?

    A. “Perhaps he loves you now, And now no soil nor cautel doth besmirch The virtue of his will”

    B. “My necessaries are embark’d: farewell: And, sister, as the winds give benefit And convoy is assistant, do not sleep, But let me hear from…”

    C. “For Hamlet and the trifling of his favour, Hold it a fashion and a toy in blood, A violet in the youth of primy nature, Forward, not…”

    D. “Think it no more: For nature, crescent, does not grow alone In thews and bulk, but, as this temple waxes, The inward service of the mind…”

    Key: B (“My necessaries are embark’d: farewell: And, sister, as the winds give benefit And convoy is assistant, do not sleep, But let me hear from…”)

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 13 reveal about the character or situation? “Most humbly do I take my leave, my lord.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 13) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “humbly” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 26 shapes its tone: “Ay, fashion you may call it; go to, go to.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “fashion” (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 26) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 20 shapes its tone: “What is between you? give me up the truth.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “between” (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 20) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 7 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “Then if he says he loves you, It fits your wisdom so far to believe it As he in his particular act and place May give his saying deed; which is no further Than the main

voice of Denmark goes withal." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 7) develops corruption and the state: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Its words "particular" and "believe" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart." (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 8), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act I, Scene II to Act I, Scene III. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene II, Hamlet, the text reads "A little more than kin, and less than kind" — Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. In Act I, Scene III, "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) — Polonius's advice. Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 12? "Beware Of _____ to a quarrel, but being in, Bear't that the opposed may beware of thee."

    A. chariest

    B. understand

    C. servants

    D. entrance

    Key: D (entrance)

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 7? "Then weigh what loss your honour may sustain, If with too credent ear you list his songs, Or lose your heart, or your chaste treasure open To his unmaster'd _____."

    A. safety

    B. understand

    C. unproportion

    D. importunity

    Key: D (importunity)

34. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 7 shapes its tone: "Fear it, Ophelia, fear it, my dear sister, And keep you in the rear of your affection, Out of the shot and danger of desire." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "affection" and "sister" (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 7) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "And these few precepts in thy memory See thou character." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 12) develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Its words "character" and "precepts" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Be thou familiar, but by no means vulgar." (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 12), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Polonius's advice. The evidence is "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This

develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “borrower” and “lender” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.".

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).
    Sample answer: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.". The evidence is “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) — Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 28 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “Look to’t, I charge you: come your ways.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 28) develops corruption and the state: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Its words “charge” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “For Hamlet and the trifling of his favour, Hold it a fashion and a toy in blood, A violet in the youth of primy nature,…” (Act I, Scene III, paragraph 5), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

39. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, paragraph 9: “I stay too long: but here my _____ comes.” Word bank: importunity, circumstance, father, safety
    Key: father

40. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
    A. Setting
    B. Conflict
    C. Metaphor
    D. Plot

    Key: B (Conflict)

41. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] What does this passage most clearly show? “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)
    A. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.
    B. Hamlet sees the Ghost.
    C. The first line: a play of questions.
    D. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    Key: D (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 9, 10, 8, 5, 17, 18, 11, 4, 19, 13, 12, 20, 15, 14, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 10, 7, 17, 3, 4, 8, 19, 20, 13, 22, 14, 15, 23, 21, 24	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2

HS Junior	4, 2, 7, 9, 25, 26, 13, 20, 22, 27, 28, 14, 15, 29, 30, 31	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 17, 32, 33, 12, 27, 26, 22, 13, 15, 29, 14, 34, 35, 36, 24	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 19, 8, 27, 26, 13, 37, 23, 14, 29, 28, 36, 35, 24, 30, 21	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Freshman	25, 17, 2, 26, 27, 13, 12, 29, 14, 28, 15, 34, 30, 35, 38, 24	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	2, 19, 17, 26, 27, 14, 23, 15, 34, 28, 21, 36, 16, 35, 24, 31	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Junior	5, 39, 17, 27, 26, 23, 15, 14, 28, 34, 30, 24, 21, 35, 16, 36	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	2, 6, 17, 26, 14, 29, 40, 28, 34, 16, 30, 24, 36, 38, 31, 21	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 7
Graduate / PhD	10, 6, 17, 41, 34, 23, 14, 28, 29, 30, 38, 35, 24, 36, 31, 21	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 7

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene III suggests about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of

Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene III and its treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dalliance” most nearly mean?

   A. ministers; preachers

   B. idle, flirtatious play

   C. a person without moral restraint

   D. lacking God's grace; wicked

2. *I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart. But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene III”?

   A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   B. The court of Denmark

C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. B (idle, flirtatious play); 2. D (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

Lesson 6: Act I, Scene IV

Focus: Hamlet sees the Ghost

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in “Act I, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (alcohol, suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Claudius's drinking ('takes his rouse', 'keeps wassail', 'drains his draughts of Rhenish') is a custom Hamlet calls 'more honour'd in the breach than the observance'. Name the drinking plainly; discuss how Hamlet ties it to Denmark's reputation. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: This scene describes the king's heavy drinking.
Suggested language: “Why does Hamlet disapprove of the custom?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.

Background: Danish drinking was proverbial in England.

Significance: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What would make you follow a ghost? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... Content note before we start: This scene describes the king's heavy drinking. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What would make you follow a ghost?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: hearsed — placed in a coffin; beckons — signals someone to come; cerements — burial cloths; wassail — drinking and revelry; ordnance — cannons. "cerements": Origin of "cerement": French cirement ("waxing").
Words: hearsed: placed in a coffin · beckons: signals someone to come · cerements: burial cloths · wassail: drinking and revelry · ordnance: cannons

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Danish drinking was proverbial in England. The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption. Setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" slowly and put it in my own words: Waiting on the battlements, Hamlet says the air bites shrewdly and is very cold. Next, craft. I notice the personified air that "bites," which gives the night a hostile edge. The strongest word is "bites": it makes the cold feel like an attack, adding to the tension. Then, effect. Why does Hamlet comment on the cold air before the Ghost appears? My answer: Hamlet comments on the cold air before the Ghost appears to fill the nervous wait; the biting air prepares the audience for something supernatural and threatening to appear.

> *The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" slowly and put it in my own words: Waiting on the battlements, Hamlet says the air bites shrewdly and is very cold. Next, craft. I notice the personified air that "bites," which gives the night a hostile edge. The strongest word is "bites": it makes the cold feel like an attack, adding to the tension. Then, effect. Why does Hamlet comment on the cold air before the Ghost appears? My answer: Hamlet comments on the cold air before the Ghost appears to fill the nervous wait; the biting air prepares the audience for something supernatural and threatening to appear.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* *(Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost? Is the Ghost good or evil?
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost?
Facilitation: Is the Ghost good or evil?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes Hamlet sees the Ghost. Key takeaway: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.
- **Foreshadowing:** Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "in ignorance; but tell / Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, / Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, / Wherein we saw thee" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) Corruption.
- "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Atmosphere.
- "Angels and ministers of grace defend us" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet sees the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state.
Evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)
Reasoning: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
hearsed (adjective)	placed in a coffin	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	
beckons (verb)	signals someone to come	*It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.*	
cerements (noun)	burial cloths	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	“cerements”: Origin of “cerement”: French cirement (“waxing”). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cerement#Etymology)
wassail (noun)	drinking and revelry	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	
ordnance (noun)	cannons	*A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within.*	
swaggering (adjective)	boisterous; reeling	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	
drunkards (noun)	habitual drinkers	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our*	

		achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.	
traduced (adjective)	slandered; spoken ill of	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	
swinish (adjective)	like a pig; gross	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	
nipping (adjective)	sharply cold	*It is a nipping and an eager air.*	

Discussion questions

1. What would make you follow a ghost?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about his life? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He does not set it at a pin's fee.
2. What is Claudius doing below? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Drinking and revelling
3. What does the Ghost do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Beckons Hamlet
4. What do Hamlet's friends fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Ghost may lead him to madness or death
5. Who says something is rotten in Denmark? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Marcellus
6. How cold is it? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Very cold

7. Retell the three most important events of “Act I, Scene IV” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
8. Who is on stage in “Act I, Scene IV”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act I, Scene IV” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…” What does “hearsed” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: hearsed: placed in a coffin.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet criticize the drinking? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It damages Denmark's reputation.
2. What does “Act I, Scene IV” suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Indeed?”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
7. How does “Act I, Scene IV” build on “Act I, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme

link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What would make you follow a ghost?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet brave or reckless? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet sees the Ghost. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait

8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. On setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene IV” treats Hamlet sees the Ghost with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene V” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus: "Something is _____ in the state of Denmark"

   Key: rotten

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.", what does "beckons" most nearly mean?

   A. manure
   B. signals someone to come
   C. a mine of ore
   D. sword-fighting for sport

   Key: B (signals someone to come)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet: "Angels and _____ of grace defend us"

   Key: ministers

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us _____ and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute." Word bank: traduced, cerements, hearsed, beckons

   Key: traduced

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How cold is it?

   A. Mild
   B. Very cold
   C. Warm
   D. Hot

   Key: B (Very cold)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What do Hamlet's friends fear?

   A. Nothing
   B. It is a trick
   C. Claudius will see
   D. The Ghost may lead him to madness or death

Key: D (The Ghost may lead him to madness or death)

7. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say about his life?
   Sample answer: He does not set it at a pin's fee.
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…", what does "cerements" most nearly mean?
   A. a mine of ore
   B. burial cloths
   C. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood
   D. prevented beforehand

   Key: B (burial cloths)
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Claudius doing below?
   A. Praying
   B. Holding council
   C. Drinking and revelling
   D. Sleeping

   Key: C (Drinking and revelling)
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who says something is rotten in Denmark?
    A. Marcellus
    B. Hamlet
    C. Bernardo
    D. Horatio

    Key: A (Marcellus)
11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the _____ up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge." Word bank: cerements, hearsed, beckons, swaggering
    Key: swaggering
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Atmosphere. The evidence is "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Hamlet criticize the drinking?
    Sample answer: It damages Denmark's reputation: Atmosphere. The evidence is "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.
14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "Angels and ministers of grace defend us" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Hamlet sees the Ghost. The evidence is "Angels and ministers of grace defend us" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words "ministers" and "defend" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).
    Sample answer: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.". The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) — Corruption. This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet brave or reckless? Argue.
    Sample answer: A reasoned view: Corruption. The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.".
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A flourish of trumpets, and _____ shot off, within.” Word bank: beckons, cerements, hearsed, ordnance
    Key: ordnance
18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does the Ghost do?
    A. Vanishes immediately
    B. Attacks Marcellus
    C. Speaks to Horatio
    D. Beckons Hamlet

    Key: D (Beckons Hamlet)
19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax’d of other nations: They clepe us _____, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform’d at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.” Word bank: hearsed, cerements, beckons, drunkards
    Key: drunkards
20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…”, what does “hearsed” most nearly mean?
    A. sugared; flattering
    B. magic; here, seductive power
    C. denial
    D. placed in a coffin

    Key: D (placed in a coffin)
21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Corruption. The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.
22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.
    A. Setting
    B. Theme

C. Personification

D. Allusion

Key: A (Setting)

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

A. Action and delay

B. Corruption and the state

C. Revenge and justice

D. Appearance and reality

Key: B (Corruption and the state)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act I, Scene I to Act I, Scene IV. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene I, Bernardo, the text reads "Who's there", which shows the first line: a play of questions. In Act I, Scene IV, "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) — Corruption. Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet: "The air bites _____; it is very cold"

Key: shrewdly

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene IV"?

A. Polonius spies on Laertes

B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

C. The duel and the deaths

D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

Key: D (Hamlet sees the Ghost)

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 11 reveal about the character or situation? "Ay, marry, is't: But to my mind, though I am native here And to the manner born, it is a custom More honour'd in the breach than the observance." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 11) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words "observance" and "though" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 20 shapes its tone: "I do not set my life in a pin's fee; And for my soul, what can it do to that, Being a thing immortal as itself?" Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words "immortal" and "itself" (Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 20) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Corruption. The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words “rotten” and “state” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.".

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Atmosphere. The evidence is “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words “shrewdly” and “bites” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.".

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 28: “Let’s _____; ’tis not fit thus to obey him.” Word bank: questionable, wherefore, season, follow

    Key: follow

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 18? “It will not speak; then I will _____ it.”

    A. artery

    B. wherefore

    C. follow

    D. season

    Key: C (follow)

33. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 8: “I heard it not: then it draws near the _____ Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk.” Word bank: season, follow, questionable, wherefore

    Key: season

34. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Another prince who has lost a father.

    C. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    D. Mood: cold and unease.

    Key: C (Hamlet sees the Ghost.)

35. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.

    A. Personification

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Point of view

    D. Alliteration

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix

Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	3, 17, 18, 5, 19, 7, 6, 11, 20, 12, 21, 13, 22, 23, 14, 24	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	25, 5, 18, 8, 4, 7, 1, 26, 13, 12, 27, 23, 14, 28, 16, 29	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 5, 6, 1, 8, 25, 10, 13, 27, 21, 26, 28, 23, 14, 30, 24	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Senior	31, 8, 17, 32, 33, 6, 13, 12, 27, 21, 28, 22, 23, 14, 24, 16	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
AP	20, 32, 10, 1, 31, 9, 13, 27, 22, 28, 15, 14, 23, 24, 16, 30	recall 6, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Freshman	20, 10, 33, 17, 11, 5, 26, 13, 27, 34, 28, 23, 15, 16, 30, 24	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 3
College Sophomore	5, 32, 18, 17, 7, 31, 27, 13, 21, 22, 28, 14, 23, 24, 16, 30	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
College Junior	6, 32, 33, 7, 18, 3, 13, 27, 26, 23, 28, 14, 30, 16, 24, 29	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Senior	32, 18, 25, 9, 7, 4, 13, 27, 21, 34, 28, 35, 23, 16, 30, 24	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 3
Graduate / PhD	32, 11, 6, 25, 1, 4, 12, 13, 27, 28, 22, 14, 23, 15, 24, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 2

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet sees the Ghost? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene IV suggests about Hamlet sees the Ghost. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet sees the Ghost follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene IV and its treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet sees the Ghost in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "cerements" most nearly mean?

   A. sharply cold

   B. burial cloths

   C. like a pig; gross

   D. slandered; spoken ill of

2. *Indeed? I heard it not: then it draws near the season Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk. A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within. What does this mean, my lord?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene IV"?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

C. Worms and kings

D. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

SAT key: 1. B (burial cloths); 2. A (Hamlet sees the Ghost)

Lesson 7: Act I, Scene V

Focus: the Ghost's revelation

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene V” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “To me it is clear that Shakspeare meant, in the present case, to represent the effects of a great action laid upon a soul unfit for the performance of it. In this view the whole play seems to me to be composed. There is an oak-tree planted in a costly jar, which should have borne only pleasant flowers in its bosom: the roots expand, the jar is shivered.” (Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, poet and playist (spoken by his character Wilhelm), *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship (1795-96), trans. Thomas Carlyle (1824), Book IV, Chapter XIII, Book IV, Ch. XIII*; public domain). Metaphor analysis: what are the oak, the jar, the shivering? Note that the speaker is Goethe's character Wilhelm, not Goethe in his own voice. *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's response to the Ghost's command ("The time is out of joint"). *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (murder (poison), incest and adultery (described)): The Ghost describes his murder by poison poured in his ear and calls Claudius 'that incestuous, that adulterate beast', with images of lust that will 'prey on garbage'. Gloss 'incestuous' as the period view of marriage to a dead husband's brother; keep discussion on betrayal and revenge.
Student preview: A ghost describes being murdered and uses harsh language about his widow's remarriage.
Suggested language: “What does the Ghost ask of Hamlet, and what does he forbid?”

Teacher only · spoilers

The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.

Background: Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared.

Significance: The command of revenge launches the plot.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: A ghost describes being murdered and uses harsh language about his widow's remarriage.
Prompt: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet swears to remember.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: traitorous — treacherous; howsoever — in whatever way; ambiguous — open to more than one meaning; adulterate — adulterous; sulphurous — of sulphur; hellish. "traitorous": Origin: Anglo-Norman traiterous. "howsoever": Origin: an English formation from how + so + ever.
Words: traitorous: treacherous · howsoever: in whatever way · ambiguous: open to more than one meaning · adulterate: adulterous · sulphurous: of sulphur; hellish

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared. The command of revenge launches the plot. Characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" slowly and put it in my own words: The Ghost tells Hamlet to avenge his foul and most unnatural murder. Next, craft. I notice the superlatives "foul" and "most unnatural," which stress how monstrous the crime was. The strongest word is "unnatural": killing a brother breaks the most basic bonds of nature and family. Then, effect. What does the Ghost demand of Hamlet? My answer: The Ghost gives Hamlet his mission: revenge on Claudius; the word "unnatural" frames the crime as a violation of the natural order, which Hamlet must set right.

> *Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder* (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" slowly and put it in my own words: The Ghost tells Hamlet to avenge his foul and most unnatural murder. Next, craft. I notice the superlatives "foul" and "most unnatural," which stress how monstrous the crime was. The strongest word is "unnatural": killing a brother breaks the most basic bonds of nature and family. Then, effect. What does the Ghost demand of Hamlet? My answer: The Ghost gives Hamlet his mission: revenge on Claudius; the word "unnatural" frames the crime as a violation of the natural order, which Hamlet must set right.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

> *Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me* (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Why does Hamlet feign madness?
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet feign madness?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes the Ghost's revelation. Key takeaway: Hamlet swears to remember.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Remember me."
- **Plot:** Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on."

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet swears to remember.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “for luxury and damned incest. / But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, / Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive / Against thy” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) The Ghost's command.
- “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) The Ghost's farewell.
- “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet) Hamlet's reluctance.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it.
Evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)
Reasoning: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
traitorous (adjective)	treacherous	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous*	“traitorous”: Origin: Anglo-Norman traiterous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/traitorous#Etymology)

		queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!	
howsoever (adverb)	in whatever way	*But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.*	"howsoever": Origin: an English formation from how + so + ever. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/howsoever#Etymology)
ambiguous (adjective)	open to more than one meaning	*Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*	
adulterate (adjective)	adulterous	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!*	
sulphurous (adjective)	of sulphur; hellish	*My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and tormenting flames Must render up myself.*	
witchcraft (noun)	magic; here, seductive power	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!*	
tormenting (adjective)	causing great pain	*My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and tormenting flames Must render up myself.*	
whirling (adjective)	wild and confused	*These are but wild and whirling words, my lord.*	
distracted (adjective)	confused; irrational	*Ay, thou poor ghost, while memory holds a seat In this distracted globe.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does the Ghost say Claudius told people? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: That a serpent stung him in his orchard.
2. How was Old Hamlet killed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poison in the ear
3. Who killed him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
4. What must Hamlet not do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Harm his mother
5. What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Remember him and take revenge
6. What does Hamlet say he may put on? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An antic disposition
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous…" What does "traitorous" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: traitorous: treacherous.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet make his friends swear? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: To keep secret what they saw and his plan.
2. What does "Act I, Scene V" suggest about the Ghost's revelation? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The command of revenge launches the plot.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “And therefore as a stranger give it welcome.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene V”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear…
7. How does “Act I, Scene V” build on “Act I, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Should Hamlet trust the Ghost? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned position.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The command of revenge launches the plot.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene V”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost's revelation. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene V”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene V” treats the Ghost's revelation with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act II, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say he may put on?

   A. A disguise as a priest

   B. A crown

   C. Armour

   D. An antic disposition

   Key: D (An antic disposition)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and _____ flames Must render up myself." Word bank: ambiguous, howsoever, traitorous, tormenting

   Key: tormenting

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do?

   A. Pray for him
   B. Marry Ophelia
   C. Remember him and take revenge
   D. Leave Denmark

   Key: C (Remember him and take revenge)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, Hamlet: "The time is out of joint: O _____ spite, / That ever I was born to set it right"

   Key: cursed

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What must Hamlet not do?

   A. Leave Denmark
   B. Pray
   C. Harm his mother
   D. Tell Horatio

   Key: C (Harm his mother)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How was Old Hamlet killed?

   A. Poison in the ear
   B. Stabbed
   C. Drowned
   D. In battle

   Key: A (Poison in the ear)

7. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does the Ghost say Claudius told people?

   Sample answer: That a serpent stung him in his orchard.

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who killed him?

   A. Fortinbras
   B. Gertrude
   C. Polonius
   D. Claudius

   Key: D (Claudius)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "These are but wild and _____ words, my lord." Word bank: howsoever, whirling, traitorous, ambiguous

   Key: whirling

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act I, Scene V?

    A. "Pity me not, but lend thy serious hearing To what I shall unfold."
    B. "I am thy father's spirit, Doom'd for a certain term to walk the night, And for the day confined to fast in fires, Till the foul crimes done…"

C. “Where wilt thou lead me? speak; I’ll go no further.”

D. “So art thou to revenge, when thou shalt hear.”

Key: C (“Where wilt thou lead me? speak; I’ll go no further.”)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Hamlet make his friends swear?
Sample answer: To keep secret what they saw and his plan. The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) — The Ghost's command. This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 46 reveal about the character or situation? “Never make known what you have seen to-night.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 46) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words its wording are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: The Ghost's farewell. The evidence is “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet swears to remember.

A. Action and delay

B. Death and mortality

C. Appearance and reality

D. Revenge and justice

Key: D (Revenge and justice)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 12 shapes its tone: “But that I am forbid To tell the secrets of my prison-house, I could a tale unfold whose lightest word Would harrow up thy soul, freeze thy young blood, Make thy two eyes, like stars, start from their spheres, Thy knotted and combined…” Pick two words and explain their effect.
Sample answer: The words “particular” and “porpentine” (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 12) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet swears to remember. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Should Hamlet trust the Ghost? Argue.
Sample answer: A reasoned position: the Ghost's farewell. The evidence is “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!".

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 17? “Haste me to know’t, that I, with wings as swift As _____ or the thoughts of love, May sweep to my revenge.”

A. father

B. further

C. meditation

D. truepenny

Key: C (meditation)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With _____ of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!” Word bank: ambiguous, witchcraft, howsoever, traitorous
    Key: witchcraft
19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 3: “Where wilt thou lead me? speak; I’ll go no _____.” Word bank: wondrous, revenge, meditation, further
    Key: further
20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, Ghost: “Revenge his foul and most _____ murder”
    Key: unnatural
21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene V”? The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Characterization
    C. Symbolism
    D. Simile

    Key: B (Characterization)
22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 61 shapes its tone: “Well said, old mole! canst work i’ the earth so fast?” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 61) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet swears to remember. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 18 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “I find thee apt; And duller shouldst thou be than the fat weed That roots itself in ease on Lethe wharf, Wouldst thou not stir in this.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 18) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet swears to remember. Its words “shouldst” and “itself” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Now, Hamlet, hear: 'Tis given out that, sleeping in my orchard, A serpent stung me; so the whole ear of Denmark Is by a…” (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 18), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.”, what does “ambiguous” most nearly mean?
    A. knowing in advance
    B. open to more than one meaning
    C. trickery
    D. in a state of gross sin, unprepared

    Key: B (open to more than one meaning)

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My hour is almost come, When I to _____ and tormenting flames Must render up myself.” Word bank: sulphurous, ambiguous, howsoever, traitorous

    Key: sulphurous

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene V”?

    A. The Ghost's revelation

    B. Polonius spies on Laertes

    C. The court of Denmark

    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    Key: A (The Ghost's revelation)

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

    Sample answer: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!". The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) — The Ghost's command. This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from Act I, Scene IV to Act I, Scene V. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus, the text reads “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” — Corruption. In Act I, Scene V, “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) — The Ghost's command. Hamlet swears to remember.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's reluctance. The evidence is “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “cursed” and “joint” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 40 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Why, right; you are i’ the right; And so, without more circumstance at all, I hold it fit that we shake hands and part: You, as your business and desire shall point you; For every man has business and desire, Such as it is; and for mine…” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 40) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet swears to remember. Its words “circumstance” and “business” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “I’m sorry they offend you, heartily; Yes, ’faith heartily.” (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 42), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.”, what does “howsoever” most nearly mean?

    A. a thief; pickpocket

    B. imagination; a figment

C. tricked; deceived

D. in whatever way

Key: D (in whatever way)

32. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene V”? Remember me.

A. Theme

B. Setting

C. Alliteration

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The Ghost's command. The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “unnatural” and “murder” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!".

34. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] What can you infer from this line? “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The Ghost's command. The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The Ghost's farewell. The evidence is “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “remember” and “adieu” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 17, 6, 9, 18, 19, 20, 2, 12, 10, 11, 13, 14, 21, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	7, 24, 1, 18, 25, 9, 12, 13, 10, 11, 26, 27, 14, 22, 23, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 24, 18, 25, 3, 13, 10, 11, 12, 26, 22, 14, 15, 29, 23, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	25, 17, 31, 5, 20, 10, 12, 11, 13, 15, 22, 32, 14, 16, 23, 30	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	25, 3, 19, 11, 10, 13, 12, 22, 15, 32, 14, 30, 16, 23, 33, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 5
College Freshman	18, 3, 25, 11, 26, 10, 12, 13, 29, 22, 15, 14, 30, 23, 16, 28	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	25, 3, 9, 13, 10, 11, 12, 32, 22, 15, 29, 14, 28, 30, 23, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4

College Junior	2, 9, 31, 34, 13, 10, 11, 12, 21, 22, 15, 14, 16, 30, 23, 28	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	18, 2, 17, 10, 13, 11, 29, 22, 15, 32, 14, 16, 28, 33, 30, 23	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	25, 9, 3, 12, 10, 14, 22, 15, 29, 21, 35, 28, 30, 23, 33, 16	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene V,” how does Shakespeare show the Ghost's revelation? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost's revelation? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene V suggests about the Ghost's revelation. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost's revelation responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost's revelation follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene V and its treatment of the Ghost's revelation. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost's revelation in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost's revelation. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “ambiguous” most nearly mean?

   A. wild and confused

   B. confused; irrational

   C. open to more than one meaning

   D. causing great pain

2. *And therefore as a stranger give it welcome. There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, Than are dreamt of in your philosophy. But come; Here, as before, never, so help you mercy, How strange or odd soe’er I bear myself, As I perchance hereafter shall think meet To put an antic disposition on, That you, at such times seeing me, never shall, With arms encumber’d thus, or this headshake, Or by pronouncing of some doubtful phrase, As “Well, well, we know,” or “We could, an if we would,” Or “If we list to speak,” or “There be, an if they might,” Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene V”?

   A. The Ghost's revelation

   B. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   C. The duel and the deaths

   D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

SAT key: 1. C (open to more than one meaning); 2. A (The Ghost's revelation)

Lesson 8: Act II, Scene I

Focus: Polonius spies on Laertes

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Act II, Scene I" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (slang (sexual), alcohol or drugs (mentioned), suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Some lines in this scene carry period sexual slang; the glosses are hedged. Gloss briefly where needed and move on. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…To youth and liberty. As gaming, my lord. Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbi…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Suggested language: "What does this language show about the speaker?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.

Background: Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life.

Significance: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever right to spy on family? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual). If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: indirection.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: windlasses — roundabout methods; indirections — indirect means; brothel — a house of prostitution; fencing — sword-fighting for sport; affrighted — frightened. "indirections": Origin of "indirection": an English formation from indirect + -ion. "affrighted": Origin of "affright": an English formation from a- + fright.
Words: windlasses: roundabout methods · indirections: indirect means · brothel: a house of prostitution · fencing: sword-fighting for sport · affrighted: frightened

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life. Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance. Characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" slowly and put it in my own words: Ophelia tells her father that she has been terribly frightened by Hamlet. Next, craft. I notice the repeated "my lord, my lord," which shows breathless fear. The strongest word is "affrighted": an old, stronger form of "afraid," it shows real shock. Then, effect. Why is Ophelia so frightened? My answer: Ophelia is frightened because Hamlet burst into her room disheveled, pale and silent, staring at her; Polonius takes it as love-madness, while we suspect an act or real distress.

> *O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted* (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" slowly and put it in my own words: Ophelia tells her father that she has been terribly frightened by Hamlet. Next, craft. I notice the repeated "my lord, my lord," which shows breathless fear. The strongest word is "affrighted": an old, stronger form of "afraid," it shows real shock. Then, effect. Why is Ophelia so frightened? My answer: Ophelia is frightened because Hamlet burst into her room disheveled, pale and silent, staring at her; Polonius takes it as love-madness, while we suspect an act or real distress.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

> *By indirections find directions out (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family? Is Polonius wise or foolish?
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Facilitation: Is Polonius wise or foolish?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Polonius spies on Laertes. Key takeaway: indirection.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.
- **Irony:** Polonius uses lies to find truth.
- **Plot:** Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** indirection.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: "meaning: but breathe his faults so quaintly / That they may seem the taints of liberty, / The flash and outbreak of a fiery" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Polonius's method.
- "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) Ophelia's fear.
- "This is the very ecstasy of love" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Polonius's diagnosis.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception.
Evidence: "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)
Reasoning: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
windlasses (noun)	roundabout methods	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	
indirections (noun)	indirect means	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	"indirections": Origin of "indirection": an English formation from indirect + -ion. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/indirection#Etymology)
brothel (noun)	a house of prostitution	*Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*	
fencing (noun)	sword-fighting for sport	*Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.*	
affrighted (verb)	frightened	*O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted!*	"affrighted": Origin of "affright": an English formation from a- + fright. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/affright#Etymology)
ecstasy (noun)	madness; frenzy	*This is the very ecstasy of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures.*	"ecstasy": Origin: Old French estaise; earlier Latin ecstasis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ecstasy#Etymology)
beshrew (verb)	curse (a mild oath)	*I am sorry that with better heed and judgment I had not quoted him: I fear'd he did but trifle, And meant to wreck thee; but, beshrew my jealousy!*	
discretion (noun)	good judgment	*By heaven, it is as proper to our age To cast beyond ourselves in our opinions As it*	"discretion": Origin: Old French discretion; earlier Late Latin discrētiō.

		is common for the younger sort To lack discretion.	(Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/discretion#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever right to spy on family?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How was Hamlet dressed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.
2. Where is Reynaldo sent? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Paris
3. What is Reynaldo told to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Spy on Laertes
4. What frightened Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's strange visit
5. What does Polonius conclude? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet is mad for love
6. Whom will Polonius tell? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
8. Who is on stage in "Act II, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act II, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…" What does "windlasses" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: windlasses: roundabout methods.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Polonius's method ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He uses lies to discover truth.
2. What does “Act II, Scene I” suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. On irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “At “closes in the consequence,””, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
7. How does “Act II, Scene I” build on “Act I, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever right to spy on family?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. On plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned reading.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act II, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Polonius spies on Laertes. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act II, Scene I” treats Polonius spies on Laertes with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act II, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom will Polonius tell?

   A. Laertes

B. Gertrude only

C. The king

D. Horatio

Key: C (The king)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.”, what does “fencing” most nearly mean?

   A. a song; ballad

   B. burial cloths

   C. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

   D. sword-fighting for sport

   Key: D (sword-fighting for sport)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so _____!” Word bank: windlasses, brothel, indirections, affrighted

   Key: affrighted

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Polonius conclude?

   A. Hamlet is ill

   B. Hamlet is faking

   C. Hamlet is spying

   D. Hamlet is mad for love

   Key: D (Hamlet is mad for love)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I am sorry that with better heed and judgment I had not quoted him: I fear’d he did but trifle, And meant to wreck thee; but, _____ my jealousy!” Word bank: windlasses, indirections, beshrew, brothel

   Key: beshrew

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “By heaven, it is as proper to our age To cast beyond ourselves in our opinions As it is common for the younger sort To lack _____.” Word bank: brothel, windlasses, discretion, indirections

   Key: discretion

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene I, Polonius: “This is the very _____ of love”

   Key: ecstasy

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is Reynaldo sent?

   A. London

   B. Wittenberg

   C. Paris

   D. Norway

   Key: C (Paris)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.”, what does “brothel” most nearly mean?

   A. one who challenges others

B. release; acquittal

C. outdo; defy

D. a house of prostitution

Key: D (a house of prostitution)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What frightened Ophelia?

A. Laertes's letter

B. Her father's anger

C. Hamlet's strange visit

D. A ghost

Key: C (Hamlet's strange visit)

11. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How was Hamlet dressed?

Sample answer: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why is Polonius's method ironic?

Sample answer: He uses lies to discover truth. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene I”?

A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

B. Hamlet sees the Ghost

C. Polonius spies on Laertes

D. Claudius at prayer

Key: C (Polonius spies on Laertes)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).

Sample answer: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.". The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Indirection.

A. Appearance and reality

B. Action and delay

C. Death and mortality

D. Revenge and justice

Key: A (Appearance and reality)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act I, Scene III to Act II, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene III, Polonius, the text reads “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” — Polonius's advice. In Act II, Scene I, “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. Indirection.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…”, what does “indirections” most nearly mean?

    A. distresses deeply; tears at

    B. indirect means

    C. graft onto

    D. of sulphur; hellish

    Key: B (indirect means)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Reynaldo told to do?

    A. Fight Laertes

    B. Bring money only

    C. Spy on Laertes

    D. Find Hamlet

    Key: C (Spy on Laertes)

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's fear. The evidence is “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia). This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Polonius's diagnosis. The evidence is “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. The words “ecstasy” and “very” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius uses lies to find truth.

    A. Alliteration

    B. Metaphor

    C. Irony

    D. Tone / mood

    Key: C (Irony)

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue.
    Sample answer: A reasoned reading: Polonius's diagnosis. The evidence is “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.".

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 14? “Be thou a spirit of health or goblin damn’d, Bring with thee airs from heaven or blasts from hell, Be thy intents wicked or charitable, Thou comest in such a _____ shape That I will speak to thee”

    A. follow

    B. questionable

    C. artery

    D. wherefore

Key: B (questionable)

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 44: "Yes, by Saint Patrick, but there is, Horatio, And much _____ too." Word bank: wondrous, offence, revenge, truepenny

    Key: offence

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act I, Scene IV?

    A. "What may this mean, That thou, dead corse, again in complete steel Revisit'st thus the glimpses of the moon, Making night hideous; and we…"

    B. "Be thou a spirit of health or goblin damn'd, Bring with thee airs from heaven or blasts from hell, Be thy intents wicked or charitable,…"

    C. "Ay, marry, is't: But to my mind, though I am native here And to the manner born, it is a custom More honour'd in the breach than the…"

    D. "I heard it not: then it draws near the season Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk."

    Key: D ("I heard it not: then it draws near the season Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk.")

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act I, Scene V?

    A. "Haste me to know't, that I, with wings as swift As meditation or the thoughts of love, May sweep to my revenge."

    B. "If thou didst ever thy dear father love—"

    C. "Murder most foul, as in the best it is; But this most foul, strange and unnatural."

    D. "I find thee apt; And duller shouldst thou be than the fat weed That roots itself in ease on Lethe wharf, Wouldst thou not stir in this."

    Key: B ("If thou didst ever thy dear father love—")

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 18 reveal about the character or situation? "Now, Hamlet, hear: 'Tis given out that, sleeping in my orchard, A serpent stung me; so the whole ear of Denmark Is by a forged process of my death Rankly abused: but know, thou noble youth, The serpent that did sting thy father's life Now…" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 18) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words "sleeping" and "orchard" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act II, Scene I?

    A. "And then, sir, does he this—he does—what was I about to say?"

    B. "By the mass, I was about to say something: where did I leave?"

    C. "You shall do marvellous wisely, good Reynaldo, Before you visit him, to make inquire Of his behavior."

    D. "Give him this money and these notes, Reynaldo."

    Key: D ("Give him this money and these notes, Reynaldo.")

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 55 shapes its tone: "Come on—you hear this fellow in the cellarage— Consent to swear." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "cellarage" and "fellow" (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 55) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather

than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet swears to remember. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act II, Scene I, paragraph 7 shapes its tone: “Look you, sir, Inquire me first what Danskers are in Paris; And how, and who, what means, and where they keep, What company, at what expense; and finding By this encompassment and drift of question That they do know my son, come you more…” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “encompassment” and “particular” (Act II, Scene I, paragraph 7) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: indirection. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “I am thy father’s spirit, Doom’d for a certain term to walk the night, And for the day confined to fast in fires, Till the foul crimes done in my days of nature Are burnt and purged away.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 12) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet swears to remember. Its words “confined” and “certain” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Murder most foul, as in the best it is; But this most foul, strange and unnatural.” (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 16), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene I, paragraph 19 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “By the mass, I was about to say something: where did I leave?” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene I, paragraph 19) develops corruption and the state: indirection. Its words “something” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “My lord, as I was sewing in my closet, Lord Hamlet, with his doublet all unbraced; No hat upon his head; his stockings…” (Act II, Scene I, paragraph 34), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 10? “So art thou to _____, when thou shalt hear.”

    A. offence

    B. truepenny

    C. father

    D. revenge

    Key: D (revenge)

34. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This is the very _____ of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures.” Word bank: brothel, indirections, ecstasy, windlasses

    Key: ecstasy

35. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…”, what does “windlasses” most nearly mean?

    A. roundabout methods

    B. picture; portrait

C. prohibition; ban (on playing)

D. quickness; speed

Key: A (roundabout methods)

36. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 42 shapes its tone: “I’m sorry they offend you, heartily; Yes, ’faith heartily.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “heartily” and “offend” (Act I, Scene V, paragraph 42) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet swears to remember. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

37. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.

A. Tone / mood

B. Characterization

C. Allusion

D. Theme

Key: B (Characterization)

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene I, paragraph 38 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Long stay’d he so; At last, a little shaking of mine arm And thrice his head thus waving up and down, He raised a sigh so piteous and profound As it did seem to shatter all his bulk And end his being: that done, he lets me go: And, with…” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene I, paragraph 38) develops appearance and reality: indirection. Its words “shoulder” and “profound” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “No, my good lord, but, as you did command, I did repel his letters and denied His access to me.” (Act II, Scene I, paragraph 40), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

39. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act I, Scene V, paragraph 59? “Come hither, _____, And lay your hands again upon my sword: Never to speak of this that you have heard, Swear by my sword.”

A. gentlemen

B. scholars

C. wondrous

D. truepenny

Key: A (gentlemen)

40. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Polonius's method. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. The words “indirections” and “directions” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.".

41. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 20: “It waves me forth again: I’ll _____ it.” Word bank: follow, season, wherefore, artery

    Key: follow

42. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 21 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “The very place puts toys of desperation, Without more motive, into every brain That looks so many fathoms to the sea And hears it roar beneath.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 21) develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Its words “desperation” and “beneath” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “By heaven, I’ll make a ghost of him that lets me!” (Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 26), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

43. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What can you infer from this line? “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Polonius's method. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

44. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 14 shapes its tone: “What may this mean, That thou, dead corse, again in complete steel Revisit’st thus the glimpses of the moon, Making night hideous; and we fools of nature So horridly to shake our disposition With thoughts beyond the reaches of our souls?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “disposition” and “complete” (Act I, Scene IV, paragraph 14) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 10, 9, 17, 18, 1, 7, 11, 5, 4, 19, 12, 20, 21, 14, 22	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	23, 24, 4, 3, 7, 2, 25, 26, 27, 28, 12, 29, 30, 15, 31, 32	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	33, 5, 34, 4, 35, 25, 26, 27, 28, 12, 36, 15, 30, 37, 32, 38	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	39, 5, 3, 4, 25, 27, 26, 28, 12, 36, 29, 15, 20, 31, 40, 38	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	41, 9, 3, 25, 27, 28, 12, 36, 29, 30, 20, 37, 42, 31, 22, 40	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 6, 35, 27, 28, 13, 43, 44, 29, 15, 30, 20, 31, 38, 16, 22	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	3, 34, 25, 26, 28, 12, 44, 29, 36, 37, 15, 42, 16, 38, 40, 22	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

College Junior	9, 35, 3, 34, 13, 44, 36, 29, 20, 15, 42, 31, 32, 40, 38, 22	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	24, 5, 26, 28, 44, 36, 21, 14, 20, 15, 42, 31, 16, 38, 32, 22	recall 2, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 6
Graduate / PhD	39, 3, 34, 8, 13, 44, 29, 30, 14, 15, 42, 31, 38, 32, 16, 22	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act II, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show Polonius spies on Laertes? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene I suggests about Polonius spies on Laertes. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act II, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act II, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Polonius spies on Laertes follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene I and its treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Polonius spies on Laertes in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “brothel” most nearly mean?

   A. madness; frenzy

   B. a house of prostitution

   C. good judgment

   D. curse (a mild oath)

2. *At “closes in the consequence,” ay, marry; He closes thus: “I know the gentleman; I saw him yesterday, or t’ other day, Or then, or then; with such, or such; and, as you say, There was a’ gaming; there o’ertook in’s rouse; There falling out at tennis:” or perchance, “I saw him enter such a house of sale,” Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth. See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son. You have me, have you not?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene I”?

   A. Polonius spies on Laertes

   B. The plot against Hamlet

   C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   D. Fortinbras's army

SAT key: 1. B (a house of prostitution); 2. A (Polonius spies on Laertes)

Lesson 9: Act II, Scene II

Focus: Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act II, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (slang (sexual)): 'Fishmonger' may carry the slang sense of a pimp; gloss briefly as an insult and move on.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Suggested language: “What does this language show about the speaker?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.

Background: Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference.

Significance: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why might someone need proof before acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Prompt: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appurtenance — accompaniment; proper ceremony; fishmonger — a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang; quintessence — the purest essence; messengers — people who carry messages; apprehension — fear; perception. "appurtenance": Origin: Anglo-Norman apurtenance; earlier Latin appertineō ("to belong"). "apprehension": Origin: Latin apprehensio.
Words: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony · fishmonger: a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang · quintessence: the purest essence · messengers: people who carry messages · apprehension: fear; perception

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference. Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests" (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" slowly and put it in my own words: After talking with Hamlet, Polonius says aside that though this is madness, there is method in it. Next, craft. I notice the aside, which lets Polonius speak truth he will not act on. The strongest word is "method": it suggests Hamlet's madness has a pattern and purpose. Then, effect. What does Polonius notice about Hamlet's madness? My answer: Polonius half-sees that Hamlet's "madness" is controlled and pointed, but he still blames love; the line invites the audience to question whether Hamlet is mad or acting.

> *Though this be madness, yet there is method in't (Act II, Scene II, Polonius)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" slowly and put it in my own words: After talking with Hamlet, Polonius says aside that though this is madness, there is method in it. Next, craft. I notice the aside, which lets Polonius speak truth he will not act on. The strongest word is "method": it suggests Hamlet's madness has a pattern and purpose. Then, effect. What does Polonius notice about Hamlet's madness? My answer: Polonius half-sees that Hamlet's "madness" is controlled and pointed, but he still blames love; the line invites the audience to question whether Hamlet is mad or acting.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

> *the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king* (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting? Why does Hamlet need proof?
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet need proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. ("What a piece of work is a man", Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. ("What a piece of work is a man", Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Key takeaway: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.
- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I."
- **Plot:** Hamlet plans The Mousetrap.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests" (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "by time, by means and place, / All given to mine ear" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) Polonius's aside.
- "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet on humanity.
- "the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) The plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth.
Evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appurtenance (noun)	accompaniment; proper ceremony	*Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like entertainment than yours.*	"appurtenance": Origin: Anglo-Norman apurtenance; earlier Latin appertineō ("to belong"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/appurtenance#Etymology)
fishmonger (noun)	a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang	*Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.*	
quintessence (noun)	the purest essence	*And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.*	
messengers (noun)	people who carry messages	*That she should lock herself from his resort, / Admit no messengers, receive no tokens.*	
apprehension (noun)	fear; perception	*What a piece of work is a man! how noble in reason! how infinite in faculty! in form and moving how express and admirable! in action how like an angel! in apprehension how like a god! the beauty of the world! the paragon of animals!*	"apprehension": Origin: Latin apprehensio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/apprehension#Etymology)
chanson (noun)	a song; ballad	*Why, "As by lot, God wot," and then, you know, "It came to pass, as most like it was,"— the first row of the pious chanson will show you more; for look, where my abridgement comes.*	

inhibition (noun)	prohibition; ban (on playing)	*I think their inhibition comes by the means of the late innovation.*	"inhibition": Origin: Old French inibicion; earlier Latin inhibitio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inhibition#Etymology)
strumpet (noun)	a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all	*O, most true; she is a strumpet.*	
swaddling (noun)	cloths wrapped around a baby	*Hark you, Guildenstern; and you too: at each ear a hearer: that great baby you see there is not yet out of his swaddling-clouts.*	

Discussion questions

1. Why might someone need proof before acting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whose death does the First Player describe? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Priam's, and Hecuba's grief.
2. Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude
3. What does Polonius read? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia
4. What does Hamlet call Polonius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A fishmonger
5. Who arrives at court? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Travelling players
6. What will the play catch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The conscience of the king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and

plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.

8. Who is on stage in “Act II, Scene II”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act II, Scene II” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like…” What does “appurtenance” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet doubt the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It may be a devil.
2. What does “Act II, Scene II” suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the structure in this scene shape what we understand about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Aside.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for…
7. How does “Act II, Scene II” build on “Act II, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy:

"O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why might someone need proof before acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act II, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act II, Scene II” treats Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act III, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Why, 'As by lot, God wot,' and then, you know, 'It came to pass, as most like it was,'— the first row of the pious _____ will show you more; for look, where my abridgement comes." Word bank: fishmonger, appurtenance, quintessence, chanson
    Key: chanson
2. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose death does the First Player describe?
    Sample answer: Priam's, and Hecuba's grief.
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet call Polonius?
    A. A fishmonger
    B. A friend
    C. A ghost
    D. A king

    Key: A (A fishmonger)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?
    A. Hamlet
    B. Claudius and Gertrude
    C. Polonius
    D. Horatio

    Key: B (Claudius and Gertrude)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.", what does "fishmonger" most nearly mean?
    A. conflict; distress
    B. completion; ending
    C. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang
    D. cleansing; also medical purging

    Key: C (a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O, most true; she is a _____." Word bank: quintessence, fishmonger, appurtenance, strumpet

   Key: strumpet

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like…", what does "appurtenance" most nearly mean?

   A. one who challenges others

   B. an herb symbolizing remembrance

   C. picture; portrait

   D. accompaniment; proper ceremony

   Key: D (accompaniment; proper ceremony)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, Hamlet: "the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the _____ of the king"

   Key: conscience

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What will the play catch?

   A. A thief

   B. The conscience of the king

   C. Ophelia

   D. Fortinbras

   Key: B (The conscience of the king)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I think their _____ comes by the means of the late innovation." Word bank: inhibition, appurtenance, quintessence, fishmonger

    Key: inhibition

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.", what does "quintessence" most nearly mean?

    A. villainous; sly

    B. delays; extends

    C. the purest essence

    D. roundabout methods

    Key: C (the purest essence)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act II, Scene II"?

    A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

    B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    C. The graveyard

    D. Polonius spies on Laertes

    Key: A (Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Hamlet doubt the Ghost?
    Sample answer: It may be a devil: Hamlet on humanity. The evidence is "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Polonius's aside. The evidence is "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet berates himself for inaction.
    A. Revenge and justice
    B. Action and delay
    C. Death and mortality
    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: B (Action and delay)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from Act II, Scene I to Act II, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act II, Scene I, Polonius, the text reads "By indirections find directions out" — Polonius's method. In Act II, Scene II, "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) — Polonius's aside. Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "That she should lock herself from his resort, / Admit no messengers, receive no tokens.", what does "messengers" most nearly mean?
    A. people who carry messages
    B. ceremony; show
    C. picture; portrait
    D. conflict; distress

    Key: A (people who carry messages)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "What a piece of work is a man! how noble in reason! how infinite in faculty! in form and moving how express and admirable! in action how like an angel! in _____ how like a god! the beauty of the world! the paragon of animals!" Word bank: fishmonger, appurtenance, apprehension, quintessence
    Key: apprehension

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, Polonius: "Though this be _____, yet there is method in't"
    Key: madness

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 16: "Give first admittance to the _____; My news shall be the fruit to that great feast." Word bank: faithful, provoke, expostulate, ambassadors
    Key: ambassadors

21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 24 reveal about the character or situation? "Therefore, since brevity is the soul of wit, And tediousness the limbs and outward flourishes, I will be brief: your noble son is mad: Mad call I it; for, to define true

madness, What is't but to be nothing else but mad?" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 24) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words "tediousness" and "flourishes" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

22. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act II, Scene II?

    A. "If it will please you To show us so much gentry and good will As to expend your time with us awhile, For the supply and profit of our hope,…"

    B. "Moreover that we much did long to see you, The need we have to use you did provoke Our hasty sending."

    C. "Something have you heard Of Hamlet's transformation; so call it, Sith nor the exterior nor the inward man Resembles that it was."

    D. "Good gentlemen, he hath much talk'd of you; And sure I am two men there are not living To whom he more adheres."

    Key: B ("Moreover that we much did long to see you, The need we have to use you did provoke Our hasty sending.")

23. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 90 reveal about the character or situation? "Why, then, 'tis none to you; for there is nothing either good or bad, but thinking makes it so: to me it is a prison." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 90) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words "thinking" and "nothing" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 96 shapes its tone: "Shall we to the court? for, by my fay, I cannot reason." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "reason" and "cannot" (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 96) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 28 shapes its tone: "Doubt thou the stars are fire; Doubt that the sun doth move; Doubt truth to be a liar; But never doubt I love." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 28) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 44 shapes its tone: "Away, I do beseech you, both away: I'll board him presently." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "presently" and "beseech" (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 44) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the scene: "Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth." Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) supports it: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.". But "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius)

complicates it: the line (Polonius's aside) shows the same issue from another side, and its "Though" marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. A fair verdict is that the claim is mostly right but overstated; it needs a limiting clause to cover that passage.

28. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Polonius read?

    A. The Ghost's words

    B. Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia

    C. A letter from Laertes

    D. A play

    Key: B (Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia)

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 23? "It likes us well; And at our more _____'d time well read, Answer, and think upon this business."

    A. instantly

    B. majesties

    C. consider

    D. practices

    Key: C (consider)

30. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 3: "Moreover that we much did long to see you, The need we have to use you did _____ Our hasty sending."
    Word bank: provoke, father, instantly, circumstances
    Key: provoke

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 4 shapes its tone: "If it will please you To show us so much gentry and good will As to expend your time with us awhile, For the supply and profit of our hope, Your visitation shall receive such thanks As fits a king's remembrance." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "remembrance" and "visitation" (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 4) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Polonius's aside. The evidence is "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words "madness" and "method" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.".

33. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 28: "Good madam, stay awhile; I will be _____." Word bank: ambassadors, provoke, faithful, defective
    Key: faithful

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 58 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "Still harping on my daughter: yet he knew me not at first; he said I was a fishmonger: he is far gone, far gone: and truly in my youth I suffered much extremity for

love; very near this." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 58) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Its words "fishmonger" and "extremity" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "How pregnant sometimes his replies are! a happiness that often madness hits on, which reason and sanity could not so…" (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 66), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 18 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "I doubt it is no other but the main; His father's death, and our o'erhasty marriage." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 18) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Its words "marriage" and "erhasty" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "That it might please you to give quiet pass Through your dominions for this enterprise, On such regards of safety and…" (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 22), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 77 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "Happy, in that we are not over-happy; On fortune's cap we are not the very button." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 77) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Its words "fortune" and "button" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "None, my lord, but that the world's grown honest." (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 83), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

37. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Hamlet on humanity. The evidence is "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

38. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Which literary element does this describe in "Act II, Scene II"? Soliloquy: 'O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I.'

A. Structure

B. Simile

C. Metaphor

D. Tone / mood

Key: A (Structure)

39. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost?

Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet on humanity. The evidence is "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.".

40. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act II, Scene II, paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "The ambassadors from Norway, my good lord, Are joyfully return'd." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 12) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Its words "ambassadors" and "joyfully" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "O, speak of that; that do I long to hear." (Act II, Scene II, paragraph 15), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

41. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Who arrives at court?

    A. Pirates

    B. Fortinbras

    C. Travelling players

    D. Laertes

    Key: C (Travelling players)

42. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The plan. The evidence is “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words “conscience” and “catch” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

43. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.

    A. Alliteration

    B. Metaphor

    C. Irony

    D. Characterization

    Key: D (Characterization)

44. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.". The evidence is “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet on humanity. This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 1, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 2, 7, 18, 19, 5, 20, 10, 21, 22, 13, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	28, 7, 29, 6, 30, 18, 19, 23, 21, 22, 13, 25, 31, 26, 32, 27	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	7, 8, 2, 33, 5, 21, 12, 13, 23, 22, 25, 24, 31, 15, 34, 35	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	18, 7, 30, 11, 13, 12, 21, 22, 23, 15, 31, 24, 25, 34, 36, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 6, 11, 4, 21, 13, 37, 24, 26, 15, 31, 38, 34, 16, 39, 40	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	33, 5, 19, 4, 22, 21, 23, 15, 25, 31, 26, 24, 36, 16, 34, 27	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 19, 1, 22, 21, 13, 15, 25, 31, 38, 26, 40, 36, 27, 35, 34	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5

College Junior	41, 33, 1, 22, 12, 31, 15, 42, 25, 26, 16, 40, 35, 34, 39, 27	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	19, 1, 4, 28, 3, 26, 31, 43, 24, 36, 35, 40, 32, 16, 27, 39	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 4, synthesis 7
Graduate / PhD	7, 1, 10, 4, 15, 44, 38, 25, 26, 35, 40, 34, 27, 16, 36, 39	recall 4, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 7

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act II, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene II suggests about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act II, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act II, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the

players follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene II and its treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “quintessence” most nearly mean?

   A. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

   B. the purest essence

   C. prohibition; ban (on playing)

   D. cloths wrapped around a baby

2. *Aside. How say you by that? Still harping on my daughter: yet he knew me not at first; he said I was a fishmonger: he is far gone, far gone: and truly in my youth I suffered much extremity for love; very near this. I’ll speak to him again. What do you read, my lord?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene II”?

   A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   B. The plot against Hamlet

   C. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   D. The Ghost on the battlements

SAT key: 1. B (the purest essence); 2. C (Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players)

Lesson 10: Act III, Scene I

Focus: 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in “Act III, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Hence we see a great, an almost enormous, intellectual activity, and a proportionate aversion to real action consequent upon it, with all its symptoms and accompanying qualities. This character Shakspeare places in circumstances, under which it is obliged to act on the spur of the moment:--Hamlet is brave and careless of death; but he vacillates from sensibility, and procrastinates from thought, and loses the power of action in the energy of resolve.” (Samuel Taylor Coleridge, poet and critic, *Notes on Hamlet, in The Literary Remains of Samuel Taylor Coleridge, Vol. 2 (1836), "Hamlet"*; public domain). Test the claim: Hamlet kills Polonius instantly in III.iv. Does that contradict Coleridge? *Objective:* Analyze "To be, or not to be" and Hamlet's delay. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Critical voice: “He plays the madman most, when he treats Ophelia with so much rudeness, which seems to be useless and wanton cruelty.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note on Hamlet*; public domain). Seminar: is Hamlet's cruelty to Ophelia strategy, madness, or misogyny? Bring one line for each. *Objective:* Evaluate Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia in the nunnery scene. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, SL.11-12.1

Content note (suicidal thoughts, slang (sexual)): 'To be, or not to be' weighs living against dying. Use the safe-messaging script; keep the discussion on Hamlet's reasoning about action and uncertainty, and name where to find support. 'Nunnery' may also carry the period slang sense of a brothel; present both readings briefly.
Student preview: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What stops Hamlet from acting, according to the speech?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.

Background: Suicide was considered a mortal sin.

Significance: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet contemplates death.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: calumny — slander; nunnery — a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel; pastime — a sport; diversion; inoculate — graft onto; breeder — a mother of children. "nunnery": Origin: an English formation from nun + -ery.
Words: calumny: slander · nunnery: a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel · pastime: a sport; diversion · inoculate: graft onto · breeder: a mother of children

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicide was considered a mortal sin. Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show. Structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "him; / And I'll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England" (Act III, Scene I, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "To be, or not to be: that is the question" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Hamlet asks whether it is better to exist or not to exist. Next, craft. I notice the stark, balanced opening, two short infinitives set against each other. The strongest word is "question": it frames life itself as a problem to be reasoned through. Then, effect. What question is Hamlet weighing in this soliloquy? My answer: Hamlet weighs whether enduring life's pain is better than ending it, and concludes that fear of what comes after death makes people suffer on; the speech shows how thought paralyzes his action.

> *To be, or not to be: that is the question (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "To be, or not to be: that is the question" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Hamlet asks whether it is better to exist or not to exist. Next, craft. I notice the stark, balanced opening, two short infinitives set against each other. The strongest word is "question": it frames life itself as a problem to be reasoned through. Then, effect. What question is Hamlet weighing in this soliloquy? My answer: Hamlet weighs whether enduring life's pain is better than ending it, and concludes that fear of what comes after death makes people suffer on; the speech shows how thought paralyzes his action.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

> *Thus conscience does make cowards of us all (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Does Hamlet know he is being watched?
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet know he is being watched?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. ("Thus conscience does make cowards of us all", Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. ("Thus conscience does make cowards of us all", Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Key takeaway: Hamlet contemplates death.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
- **Irony:** Claudius and Polonius spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet contemplates death.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “him; / And I’ll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England” (Act III, Scene I, Polonius).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “Madam, it so fell out, that certain players / We o’er-raught on the way: of these we told him; / And” (Act III, Scene I, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Life versus death.
- “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Thinking prevents action.
- “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet's rejection.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis.
Evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
calumny (noun)	slander	*If thou dost marry, I’ll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.*	
nunnery (noun)	a convent of nuns; also	*Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?*	“nunnery”: Origin: an English formation from nun + -ery. (Liber et Libri origin note,

	slang for a brothel		https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/nunnery#Etymology)
pastime (noun)	a sport; diversion	*Did you assay him To any pastime?*	
inoculate (verb)	graft onto	*You should not have believed me; for virtue cannot so inoculate our old stock but we shall relish of it: I loved you not.*	
breeder (noun)	a mother of children	*Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?*	
consummation (noun)	completion; ending	*To die: to sleep; No more; and by a sleep to say we end The heart-ache and the thousand natural shocks That flesh is heir to, 'tis a consummation Devoutly to be wish'd.*	
wantonness (noun)	playful affectation	*I have heard of your paintings too, well enough; God has given you one face, and you make yourselves another: you jig, you amble, and you lisp, and nick-name God's creatures, and make your wantonness your ignorance.*	
remembrances (noun)	keepsakes; love-tokens	*My lord, I have remembrances of yours, That I have longed long to re-deliver; I pray you, now receive them.*	"remembrances": Origin of "remembrance": Old French remembrance; earlier Late Latin rememorārī ("to call to mind"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/remembrance#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet call death? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The undiscover'd country.
2. Who hides to watch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Polonius
3. What does Ophelia return? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's gifts
4. Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A nunnery
5. What does Claudius decide? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To send Hamlet to England
6. What does conscience make of us? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Cowards
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "If thou dost marry, I'll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny." What does "calumny" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: calumny: slander.

Inferential / analytical

1. Does Hamlet know he is watched? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A reasoned inference.
2. What does "Act III, Scene I" suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.
7. How does “Act III, Scene I” build on “Act II, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia excusable? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful

evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene I” treats 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet

contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene II" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a _____ of sinners?" Word bank: breeder, nunnery, calumny, pastime
   Key: breeder
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, Hamlet: "Thus _____ does make cowards of us all"
   Key: conscience
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius decide?
   A. To abdicate
   B. To confess
   C. To send Hamlet to England
   D. To kill Hamlet
   Key: C (To send Hamlet to England)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, Hamlet: "To be, or not to be: that is the _____"
   Key: question
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 18? "Gracious, so please you, We will bestow _____."
   A. unwatch

B. commerce

C. plastering

D. ourselves

Key: D (ourselves)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I have heard of your paintings too, well enough; God has given you one face, and you make yourselves another: you jig, you amble, and you lisp, and nick-name God's creatures, and make your _____ your ignorance." Word bank: nunnery, wantonness, pastime, calumny

   Key: wantonness

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Did you assay him To any pastime?", what does "pastime" most nearly mean?

   A. a sport; diversion

   B. read through (a letter)

   C. excellent qualities

   D. a song; ballad

   Key: A (a sport; diversion)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "To die: to sleep; No more; and by a sleep to say we end The heart-ache and the thousand natural shocks That flesh is heir to, 'tis a _____ Devoutly to be wish'd." Word bank: pastime, calumny, consummation, nunnery

   Key: consummation

9. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet call death?

   Sample answer: The undiscover'd country.

10. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 3 reveal about the character or situation? "And can you, by no drift of circumstance, Get from him why he puts on this confusion, Grating so harshly all his days of quiet With turbulent and dangerous lunacy?" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 3) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet contemplates death. The words "circumstance" and "turbulent" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 47 reveal about the character or situation? "There's something in his soul, O'er which his melancholy sits on brood; And I do doubt the hatch and the disclose Will be some danger: which for to prevent, I have in quick determination Thus set it down: he shall with speed to England,…" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 47) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet contemplates death. The words "determination" and "melancholy" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Does Hamlet know he is watched?

    Sample answer: A reasoned inference: Life versus death. The evidence is "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene I"?

    A. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    B. Claudius at prayer

    C. Hamlet hides the body

    D. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    Key: D ('To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 13 shapes its tone: "With all my heart; and it doth much content me To hear him so inclined." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "inclined" and "content" (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 13) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.". The evidence is "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) — Thinking prevents action. This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia excusable?

    Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet's rejection. The evidence is "Get thee to a nunnery" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.".

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who hides to watch?

    A. Laertes

    B. Rosencrantz

    C. Gertrude and Horatio

    D. Claudius and Polonius

    Key: D (Claudius and Polonius)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "If thou dost marry, I'll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.", what does "calumny" most nearly mean?

    A. slander

    B. contrary; opposed

    C. unbending

    D. trickery

    Key: A (slander)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Ophelia return?

    A. Flowers

    B. A letter

    C. Hamlet's gifts

D. A ring

Key: C (Hamlet's gifts)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does conscience make of us?

A. Saints

B. Kings

C. Cowards

D. Heroes

Key: C (Cowards)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go?

A. England

B. Her father

C. A nunnery

D. France

Key: C (A nunnery)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "Get thee to a nunnery" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet's rejection. The evidence is "Get thee to a nunnery" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. The words "nunnery" and "thee" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet contemplates death.

A. Appearance and reality

B. Death and mortality

C. Revenge and justice

D. Action and delay

Key: B (Death and mortality)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act II, Scene II to Act III, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act II, Scene II, Polonius, the text reads "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" — Polonius's aside. In Act III, Scene I, "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) — Life versus death. Hamlet contemplates death.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 23: "Good my lord, How does your _____ for this many a day?" Word bank: devotion, unwatch, plastering, honour

Key: honour

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 35? "Indeed, my lord, you made me _____ so."

A. believe

B. devotion

C. affections

D. gentlemen

Key: A (believe)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “You should not have believed me; for virtue cannot so inoculate our old stock but we shall relish of it: I loved you not.”, what does “inoculate” most nearly mean?

    A. magic; here, seductive power

    B. graft onto

    C. burial cloths

    D. sugared; flattering

    Key: B (graft onto)

28. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene I”? ‘To be, or not to be’ soliloquy.

    A. Theme

    B. Imagery

    C. Allusion

    D. Structure

    Key: D (Structure)

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 48 shapes its tone: “My lord, do as you please; But, if you hold it fit, after the play Let his queen mother all alone entreat him To show his grief: let her be round with him; And I’ll be placed, so please you, in the ear Of all their conference.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “conference” and “entreat” (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 48) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) supports it: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.". But “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) complicates it: the line (Life versus death) shows the same issue from another side, and its “not” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. Weighing the two passages, the claim survives, but only once it admits the tension the second passage creates.

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My lord, I have _____ of yours, That I have longed long to re-deliver; I pray you, now receive them.” Word bank: remembrances, calumny, pastime, nunnery

    Key: remembrances

32. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “Read on this book; That show of such an exercise may colour Your loneliness.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “loneliness” and “exercise” (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet contemplates death. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act III, Scene I"? Hamlet rejects Ophelia.

    A. Characterization

    B. Symbolism

    C. Alliteration

    D. Personification

    Key: A (Characterization)

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 40 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "Let the doors be shut upon him, that he may play the fool nowhere but in's own house." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 40) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet contemplates death. Its words "nowhere" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "And I, of ladies most deject and wretched, That suck'd the honey of his music vows, Now see that noble and most…" (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 45), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

35. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Thinking prevents action. The evidence is "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

36. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Life versus death. The evidence is "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

37. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 26 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "No, not I; I never gave you aught." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 26) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet contemplates death. Its words its wording carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "That if you be honest and fair, your honesty should admit no discourse to your beauty." (Act III, Scene I, paragraph 32), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

38. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 4: "He does confess he feels himself _____; But from what cause he will by no means speak."

    Word bank: erthrown, question, believe, distracted

    Key: distracted

39. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, paragraph 49: "It shall be so: Madness in great ones must not _____'d go." Word bank: unwatch, erthrown, plastering, honour

    Key: unwatch

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 3, 18, 19, 20, 8, 4, 7, 21, 6, 13, 12, 22, 15, 23, 24	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1

HS Sophomore	6, 25, 8, 26, 20, 7, 27, 18, 10, 11, 12, 14, 28, 29, 30, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	20, 26, 6, 7, 17, 9, 31, 10, 11, 12, 32, 15, 33, 29, 34, 24	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	20, 31, 3, 18, 1, 12, 11, 35, 36, 29, 23, 14, 32, 24, 34, 16	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 26, 2, 17, 11, 10, 36, 23, 22, 14, 33, 32, 24, 30, 37, 16	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	38, 17, 25, 19, 12, 11, 13, 15, 14, 23, 22, 32, 30, 16, 34, 37	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	39, 3, 8, 17, 10, 15, 32, 23, 33, 29, 14, 24, 16, 37, 34, 30	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Junior	5, 26, 8, 6, 11, 28, 15, 32, 29, 22, 23, 24, 30, 37, 34, 16	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Senior	18, 8, 6, 17, 19, 36, 11, 14, 23, 32, 22, 34, 16, 30, 24, 37	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	4, 8, 17, 19, 10, 12, 23, 29, 22, 33, 32, 34, 24, 30, 37, 16	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene I suggests about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene I and its treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Did you assay him To any pastime?*

   As used in the text, what does the word “pastime” most nearly mean?

   A. keepsakes; love-tokens

   B. completion; ending

   C. a sport; diversion

   D. playful affectation

2. *Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners? I am myself indifferent honest; but yet I could accuse me of such things that it were better my mother had not borne me: I am very proud, revengeful, ambitious, with more offences at my beck than I have thoughts to put them in, imagination to give them shape, or time to act them in. What should such fellows as I do crawling between earth and heaven? We are arrant knaves, all; believe none of us. Go thy ways to a nunnery. Where’s your father?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene I”?

   A. The Ghost's revelation

   B. Polonius spies on Laertes

   C. The graveyard

   D. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

SAT key: 1. C (a sport; diversion); 2. D ('To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene)

Lesson 11: Act III, Scene II

Focus: the Mousetrap

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in “Act III, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (sexual innuendo, alcohol or drugs (mentioned), suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Before the play-within-the-play, Hamlet makes bawdy jests at Ophelia ('country matters', 'lie in your lap'). Gloss briefly as public sexual humiliation of Ophelia; do not have students perform it, and discuss how it treats her. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…Is in his retirement marvellous distempered. With drink, sir? No, my lord, rather with choler….”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: Hamlet makes crude, sexual jokes at Ophelia in front of the court.
Suggested language: “Why does Hamlet treat Ophelia this way in public?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.

Background: Plays within plays were popular.

Significance: The test succeeds.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Can art reveal the truth? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: Hamlet makes crude, sexual jokes at Ophelia in front of the court. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Can art reveal the truth?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: theater reveals truth.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: candied — sugared; flattering; chameleon — a lizard once believed to live on air; heedful — careful; watchful; dallying — flirting; trifling; purgation — cleansing; also medical purging.
Words: candied: sugared; flattering · chameleon: a lizard once believed to live on air · heedful: careful; watchful · dallying: flirting; trifling · purgation: cleansing; also medical purging

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Plays within plays were popular. The test succeeds. Structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Irony: The Player Queen's vows. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King's ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the" (Act III, Scene II).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells the players to suit their actions to their words and their words to their actions. Next, craft. I notice the mirrored phrasing, which itself matches word and action. The strongest word is "action": it names exactly what Hamlet himself struggles to take. Then, effect. What advice does Hamlet give the actors? My answer: Hamlet advises the actors to suit the action to the word and not overact; his advice about natural acting also comments on his own problem, since he speaks endlessly but does not act.

> *suit the action to the word, the word to the action (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells the players to suit their actions to their words and their words to their actions. Next, craft. I notice the mirrored phrasing, which itself matches word and action. The strongest word is "action": it names exactly what Hamlet himself struggles to take. Then, effect. What advice does Hamlet give the actors? My answer: Hamlet advises the actors to suit the action to the word and not overact; his advice about natural acting also comments on his own problem, since he speaks endlessly but does not act.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

> *The lady doth protest too much, methinks (Act III, Scene II, Queen)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth? Is Claudius's reaction proof?
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth?
Facilitation: Is Claudius's reaction proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. ("The lady doth protest too much, methinks", Act III, Scene II, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. ("The lady doth protest too much, methinks", Act III, Scene II, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes the Mousetrap. Key takeaway: theater reveals truth.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** The Mousetrap play within a play.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
- **Irony:** The Player Queen's vows.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** theater reveals truth.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King’s ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the” (Act III, Scene II).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “a passion to tatters, to very rags, to split the ears of the groundlings, who for the most part are capable of” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) Acting advice.
- “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) Gertrude on the Player Queen.
- “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King) Claudius flees.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius.
Evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen)
Reasoning: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
candied (adjective)	sugared; flattering	*No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.*	
chameleon (noun)	a lizard once believed to live on air	*Excellent, i’ faith; of the chameleon’s dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.*	
heedful (adjective)	careful; watchful		

		Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.	
dallying (noun)	flirting; trifling	*I could interpret between you and your love, if I could see the puppets dallying.*	
purgation (noun)	cleansing; also medical purging	*Your wisdom should show itself more richer to signify this to his doctor; for, for me to put him to his purgation would perhaps plunge him into far more choler.*	
counsel (noun)	secret; private plan	*We shall know by this fellow: the players cannot keep counsel; they'll tell all.*	"counsel": Origin: possibly Old French conseil; earlier Latin cōnsilium. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/counsel#Etymology)
recorders (noun)	wooden flutes	*Come, some music! come, the recorders!*	
protestation (noun)	a solemn declaration	*She kneels, and makes show of protestation unto him.*	
witching (adjective)	when witches are abroad	*Tis now the very witching time of night, When churchyards yawn and hell itself breathes out Contagion to this world: now could I drink hot blood, And do such bitter business as the day Would quake to look on.*	

Discussion questions

1. Can art reveal the truth?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet tell the players about acting? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Suit the action to the word.
2. What is the play's name? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Mousetrap

3. Whom does Hamlet ask to watch Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
4. What does Claudius do during the poisoning scene? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Leaves
5. What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: She protests too much
6. What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A recorder
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning." What does "candied" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: candied: sugared; flattering.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet trust Horatio? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: He is not passion's slave.
2. What does "Act III, Scene II" suggest about the Mousetrap? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The test succeeds.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about the Mousetrap? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true. **Answer guidance:** A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On irony: The Player Queen's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act III, Scene II", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him

to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and…

7. How does “Act III, Scene II” build on “Act III, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Can art reveal the truth?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does the Mousetrap prove Claudius's guilt? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned argument.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The test succeeds.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Mousetrap. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene II” treats the Mousetrap with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene III" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Mousetrap? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.", what does "heedful" most nearly mean?
   A. careful; watchful
   B. distresses deeply; tears at
   C. boisterous; reeling
   D. an herb symbolizing remembrance

   Key: A (careful; watchful)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "I could interpret between you and your love, if I could see the puppets dallying.", what does "dallying" most nearly mean?
   A. serviceable; useful
   B. dark as night; here, mourning-black
   C. flirting; trifling
   D. flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity

   Key: C (flirting; trifling)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "We shall know by this fellow: the players cannot keep _____; they'll tell all." Word bank: heedful, candied, chameleon, counsel

   Key: counsel

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.", what does "candied" most nearly mean?

   A. deep-dyed; ingrained

   B. sugared; flattering

   C. distresses deeply; tears at

   D. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

   Key: B (sugared; flattering)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen?

   A. She is mad

   B. She is beautiful

   C. She is honest

   D. She protests too much

   Key: D (She protests too much)

6. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet tell the players about acting?

   Sample answer: Suit the action to the word.

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, Queen: "The lady doth protest too much, _____"

   Key: methinks

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "She kneels, and makes show of _____ unto him." Word bank: chameleon, candied, heedful, protestation

   Key: protestation

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern?

   A. A lute

   B. A drum

   C. A recorder

   D. A trumpet

   Key: C (A recorder)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom does Hamlet ask to watch Claudius?

    A. Ophelia

    B. Horatio

    C. Polonius

    D. Laertes

    Key: B (Horatio)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Excellent, i' faith; of the chameleon's dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.", what does "chameleon" most nearly mean?

    A. power; capacity

    B. playful affectation

    C. dark as night; here, mourning-black

    D. a lizard once believed to live on air

Key: D (a lizard once believed to live on air)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Acting advice. The evidence is “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Hamlet trust Horatio?
Sample answer: He is not passion's slave: Acting advice. The evidence is “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Theater reveals truth.
    A. Revenge and justice
    B. Death and mortality
    C. Action and delay
    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: D (Appearance and reality)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Claudius flees. The evidence is “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. The words “light” and “some” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act II, Scene I to Act III, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Earlier, in Act II, Scene I, Polonius, the text reads “By indirections find directions out” — Polonius's method. In Act III, Scene II, “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) — Acting advice. Theater reveals truth.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Your wisdom should show itself more richer to signify this to his doctor; for, for me to put him to his _____ would perhaps plunge him into far more choler.” Word bank: candied, purgation, chameleon, heedful
Key: purgation

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Come, some music! come, the _____!” Word bank: candied, recorders, chameleon, heedful
Key: recorders

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is the play's name?
    A. The King's Fall
    B. The Ghost
    C. The Revenge
    D. The Mousetrap

    Key: D (The Mousetrap)

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, Hamlet: “suit the _____ to the word, the word to the action”
Key: action

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene II"?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    C. The Mousetrap

    D. Polonius spies on Laertes

    Key: C (The Mousetrap)

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Does the Mousetrap prove Claudius's guilt?

    Sample answer: A reasoned argument: Acting advice. The evidence is "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!".

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 20? "They are _____ to the play; I must be idle: Get you a place."

    A. coming

    B. forgotten

    C. capital

    D. cheerfully

    Key: A (coming)

24. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 53 reveal about the character or situation? "Belike this show imports the argument of the play." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 53) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: theater reveals truth. The words "argument" and "imports" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act III, Scene II?

    A. "Speak the speech, I pray you, as I pronounced it to you, trippingly on the tongue: but if you mouth it, as many of your players do, I had…"

    B. "Nor do not saw the air too much with your hand, thus, but use all gently; for in the very torrent, tempest, and, as I may say, the…"

    C. "I hope we have reformed that indifferently with us, sir."

    D. "I will the king hear this piece of work?"

    Key: A ("Speak the speech, I pray you, as I pronounced it to you, trippingly on the tongue: but if you mouth it, as many of your players do, I had…")

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 84 reveal about the character or situation? "You are as good as a chorus, my lord." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 84) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: theater reveals truth. The words "chorus" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 67 shapes its tone: “None wed the second but who kill’d the first.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “second” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 67) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: theater reveals truth. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 9 shapes its tone: “I will the king hear this piece of work?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 9) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: theater reveals truth. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 70 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “This world is not for aye, nor ’tis not strange That even our loves should with our fortunes change; For ’tis a question left us yet to prove, Whether love lead fortune, or else fortune love.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 70) develops corruption and the state: theater reveals truth. Its words “question” and “fortunes” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “And hitherto doth love on fortune tend; For who not needs shall never lack a friend, And who in want a hollow friend…” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 70), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

30. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 64 shapes its tone: “Full thirty times hath Phoebus’ cart gone round Neptune’s salt wash and Tellus’ orbed ground, And thirty dozen moons with borrow’d sheen About the world have times twelve thirties been Since love our hearts and Hymen did our hands Unite…” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “commutual” and “thirties” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 64) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: theater reveals truth. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 91 shapes its tone: “He poisons him i’ the garden for’s estate.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “poisons” and “estate” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 91) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: theater reveals truth. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 71 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Each opposite that blanks the face of joy Meet what I would have well and it destroy!” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 71) develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. Its words “opposite” and “destroy” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Sweet, leave me here awhile; My spirits grow dull, and fain I would beguile The tedious day with sleep.” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 73), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

33. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 60: “Is this a _____, or the posy of a ring?” Word bank: journeys, cheerfully, coming, prologue

    Key: prologue

34. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene II”? The Mousetrap play within a play.

    A. Structure

    B. Tone / mood

    C. Simile

    D. Symbolism

    Key: A (Structure)

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 40 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “That’s a fair thought to lie between maids’ legs.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 40) develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. Its words “thought” and “between” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Nay then, let the devil wear black, for I’ll have a suit of sables.” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 48), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

36. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 29: “It was a brute part of him to kill so _____ a calf there.” Word bank: extremity, nothing, capital, accounted

    Key: capital

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen).

    Sample answer: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!". The evidence is “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) — Gertrude on the Player Queen. This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene II, paragraph 25 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “My lord, you played once i’ the university, you say?” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 25) develops corruption and the state: theater reveals truth. Its words “university” and “played” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “I did enact Julius Caesar: I was killed i’ the Capitol; Brutus killed me.” (Act III, Scene II, paragraph 28), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

39. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. The evidence is “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. The words “methinks” and “protest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!".

40. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene II”? Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Symbolism

    C. Characterization

    D. Allusion

    Key: C (Characterization)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 11, 7, 18, 6, 9, 19, 4, 10, 20, 13, 21, 12, 15, 14, 22	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 23, 7, 19, 20, 10, 13, 24, 25, 21, 26, 27, 28, 14, 22, 29	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	3, 19, 23, 6, 17, 21, 13, 25, 24, 26, 28, 30, 14, 31, 29, 32	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	33, 20, 6, 5, 24, 12, 25, 13, 26, 14, 34, 31, 15, 35, 29, 32	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 36, 4, 25, 13, 26, 24, 28, 31, 37, 14, 34, 38, 35, 29, 32	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	18, 17, 10, 25, 26, 13, 24, 30, 34, 14, 15, 27, 39, 16, 32, 35	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	20, 5, 17, 19, 25, 24, 15, 31, 28, 34, 30, 22, 35, 29, 32, 16	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	5, 10, 17, 3, 19, 15, 27, 14, 31, 30, 32, 38, 35, 29, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	33, 17, 19, 10, 14, 30, 40, 15, 28, 31, 22, 32, 16, 35, 38, 29	recall 4, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 6
Graduate / PhD	20, 17, 19, 25, 34, 31, 30, 15, 14, 28, 16, 35, 38, 22, 29, 32	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show the Mousetrap? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Mousetrap? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene II suggests about the Mousetrap. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Mousetrap responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Mousetrap follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene II and its treatment of the Mousetrap. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the Mousetrap in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Mousetrap. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "heedful" most nearly mean?

   A. wooden flutes
   B. a solemn declaration
   C. careful; watchful
   D. when witches are abroad

2. *Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her. She kneels, and makes show of protestation unto him. He takes her up, and declines his head upon her neck: lays him down upon a bank of flowers: she, seeing him asleep, leaves him. Anon comes in a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King's ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the King dead, and makes passionate action. The Poisoner, with some two or three Mutes, comes in again, seeming to lament with her. The dead body is carried away. The Poisoner wooes the Queen with gifts: she seems loath and unwilling awhile, but in the end accepts his love. Exeunt.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene II"?

   A. The court of Denmark
   B. Hamlet's letter from the sea
   C. The duel and the deaths
   D. The Mousetrap

SAT key: 1. C (careful; watchful); 2. D (The Mousetrap)

Lesson 12: Act III, Scene III

Focus: Claudius at prayer

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act III, Scene III” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “He is the prince of philosophical speculators, and because he cannot have his revenge perfect, according to the most refined idea his wish can form, he misses it altogether.” (William Hazlitt, essayist and critic, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays (1817), "Hamlet", "Hamlet"*; public domain). Essay lens: perfectionism as tragic flaw. Use "Now might I do it pat." *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's refusal to kill Claudius at prayer. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned), suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Hamlet imagines Claudius 'in the incestuous pleasure of his bed'. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…ord; and know thou a more horrid hent: When he is drunk asleep, or in his rage, Or in the inces…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes incest (period view, described).
Suggested language: “What does this language show about the speaker?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.

Background: Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation.

Significance: A key moment of delay.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever wrong to wait? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes incest (period view, described). If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet wants damnation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: prolongs — delays; extends; forestalled — prevented beforehand; fetters — chains for the feet; stubborn — unbending; grossly — in a state of gross sin, unprepared.
Words: prolongs: delays; extends · forestalled: prevented beforehand · fetters: chains for the feet · stubborn: unbending · grossly: in a state of gross sin, unprepared

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation. A key moment of delay. Characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Structure: soliloquies of both. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon't" (Act III, Scene III, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Claudius admits his offense is rank and smells to heaven. Next, craft. I notice the image of a crime with a stench that reaches God. The strongest word is "rank": it means foul-smelling and gross, so his guilt is physical and disgusting. Then, effect. What does Claudius's prayer reveal? My answer: Claudius's prayer reveals that he really murdered his brother; he wants forgiveness but will not give up the crown or queen, and Hamlet, seeing him pray, misses his chance for revenge.

> *O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven (Act III, Scene III, King)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Claudius admits his offense is rank and smells to heaven. Next, craft. I notice the image of a crime with a stench that reaches God. The strongest word is "rank": it means foul-smelling and gross, so his guilt is physical and disgusting. Then, effect. What does Claudius's prayer reveal? My answer: Claudius's prayer reveals that he really murdered his brother; he wants forgiveness but will not give up the crown or queen, and Hamlet, seeing him pray, misses his chance for revenge.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

> *Now might I do it pat, now he is praying* *(Act III, Scene III, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait? Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius at prayer. Key takeaway: Hamlet wants damnation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius's confession and prayer.
- **Irony:** Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
- **Structure:** soliloquies of both.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet wants damnation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon’t” (Act III, Scene III, King).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “pleasure of his bed; / At gaming, swearing, or about some act / That has no relish of salvation in’t; / Then trip him, that” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) Claudius confesses.
- “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) Hamlet's chance.
- “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King) Claudius cannot pray.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading.
Evidence: "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King)
Reasoning: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
prolongs (verb)	delays; extends	*My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.*	
forestalled (verb)	prevented beforehand	*And what's in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon'd being down?*	
fetters (noun)	chains for the feet	*Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*	
stubborn (adjective)	unbending	*Bow, stubborn knees; and, heart with strings of steel, Be soft as sinews of the newborn babe!*	
grossly (adverb)	in a state of gross sin, unprepared	*He took my father grossly, full of bread; With all his crimes broad blown, as flush as May; And how his audit stands who knows save heaven?*	
repentance (noun)	sorrow for sin	*Try what repentance can: what can it not?*	"repentance": Origin: Old French repentance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/repentance#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever wrong to wait?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius call his offence? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rank; it smells to heaven.
2. What does Claudius try to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Pray
3. Why does Hamlet not kill him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He might go to heaven
4. What does Claudius admit? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Murdering his brother
5. Can Claudius repent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: No, he will not give up his gains
6. Where is Hamlet going next? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To his mother
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days." What does "prolongs" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: prolongs: delays; extends.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's reasoning ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius was not truly praying.
2. What does "Act III, Scene III" suggest about Claudius at prayer? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A key moment of delay.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
7. How does “Act III, Scene III” build on “Act III, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever wrong to wait?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's reason a pretext? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A key moment of delay.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link:

Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius at prayer. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene III” treats Claudius at prayer with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link:

Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene IV" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.", what does "prolongs" most nearly mean?
   A. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel
   B. delays; extends
   C. a solemn declaration
   D. villainous; sly

   Key: B (delays; extends)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "And what's in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon'd being down?", what does "forestalled" most nearly mean?
   A. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral
   B. a trap for birds
   C. graft onto
   D. prevented beforehand

   Key: D (prevented beforehand)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, King: "O, my _____ is rank, it smells to heaven"
   Key: offence

4. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius call his offence?
   Sample answer: Rank; it smells to heaven.
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.", what does "fetters" most nearly mean?
   A. chains for the feet
   B. habitual drinkers
   C. a bird easily caught; a fool
   D. one who borrows

   Key: A (chains for the feet)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He took my father _____, full of bread; With all his crimes broad blown, as flush as May; And how his audit stands who knows save heaven?" Word bank: grossly, prolongs, fetters, forestalled
   Key: grossly
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Why does Hamlet not kill him?
   A. Gertrude enters
   B. He might go to heaven
   C. Hamlet is afraid
   D. He is guarded

   Key: B (He might go to heaven)
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius admit?
   A. Nothing
   B. Murdering his brother
   C. Fearing Norway
   D. Loving Ophelia

   Key: B (Murdering his brother)
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius try to do?
   A. Pray
   B. Escape
   C. Fight
   D. Sleep

   Key: A (Pray)
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Can Claudius repent?
    A. He refuses to try
    B. Yes
    C. He tries and succeeds
    D. No, he will not give up his gains

    Key: D (No, he will not give up his gains)
11. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene III"?
    A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

B. Claudius at prayer

C. The closet scene

D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

Key: B (Claudius at prayer)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why is Hamlet's reasoning ironic?
Sample answer: Claudius was not truly praying: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Claudius confesses. The evidence is “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet wants damnation.

A. Death and mortality

B. Action and delay

C. Appearance and reality

D. Revenge and justice

Key: D (Revenge and justice)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King).
Sample answer: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.". The evidence is “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King) — Claudius cannot pray. This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from Act I, Scene V to Act III, Scene III. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene V, Ghost, the text reads “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” — The Ghost's command. In Act III, Scene III, “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) — Claudius confesses. Hamlet wants damnation.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, Hamlet: “Now might I do it pat, now he is _____”
Key: praying

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is Hamlet going next?

A. To his mother

B. To the players

C. To England

D. To Ophelia

Key: A (To his mother)

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10 reveal about the character or situation? “O limed soul, that, struggling to be free, Art more engaged!” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet

wants damnation. The words “struggling” and “engaged” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act III, Scene III?

    A. “Fare you well, my liege: I’ll call upon you ere you go to bed, And tell you what I know.”

    B. “And, as you said, and wisely was it said, ’Tis meet that some more audience than a mother, Since nature makes them partial, should o’erhear…”

    C. “Pray can I not, Though inclination be as sharp as will: My stronger guilt defeats my strong intent; And, like a man to double business…”

    D. “Never alone Did the king sigh, but with a general groan.”

    Key: D (“Never alone Did the king sigh, but with a general groan.”)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12 shapes its tone: “That would be scann’d: A villain kills my father; and for that, I, his sole son, do this same villain send To heaven.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “villain” and “father” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet wants damnation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “Whereto serves mercy But to confront the visage of offence?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “confront” and “offence” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet wants damnation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet's reason a pretext?

    Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.".

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12? “When he is drunk asleep, or in his rage, Or in the _____ pleasure of his bed”

    A. madness

    B. general

    C. incestuous

    D. thicker

    Key: C (incestuous)

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10: “Yet what can it when one can not _____?” Word bank: madness, repent, revenge, general

    Key: repent

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

27. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene III”? Claudius's confession and prayer.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Theme

    C. Characterization

    D. Imagery

    Key: C (Characterization)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Claudius cannot pray. The evidence is “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “thoughts” and “remain” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Claudius confesses. The evidence is “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “offence” and “heaven” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.".

30. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Try what _____ can: what can it not?” Word bank: forestalled, repentance, fetters, prolongs

    Key: repentance

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, King: “My words fly up, my _____ remain below”

    Key: thoughts

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 9 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “And, as you said, and wisely was it said, ’Tis meet that some more audience than a mother, Since nature makes them partial, should o’erhear The speech, of vantage.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 9) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet wants damnation. Its words “audience” and “vantage” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But, O, what form of prayer Can serve my turn?” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.6] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene III”? Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.

    A. Simile

    B. Imagery

    C. Alliteration

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)

34. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 3: “I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his _____ range.” Word bank: madness, thicker, ourselves,

incestuous

Key: madness

35. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10? “What if this cursed hand Were _____ than itself with brother’s blood, Is there not rain enough in the sweet heavens To wash it white as snow?”

    A. general

    B. whereto

    C. corrupted

    D. thicker

    Key: D (thicker)

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “praying” and “might” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 7, 10, 4, 3, 2, 17, 18, 12, 19, 13, 20, 14, 21, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 3, 6, 24, 8, 25, 2, 19, 20, 26, 12, 27, 28, 21, 23, 29	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	10, 1, 9, 30, 2, 31, 20, 11, 12, 19, 22, 21, 28, 14, 29, 32	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	18, 10, 24, 5, 17, 3, 20, 12, 19, 33, 22, 14, 21, 16, 29, 23	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	31, 6, 9, 4, 20, 13, 19, 12, 28, 33, 22, 14, 21, 32, 23, 16	recall 4, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Freshman	6, 30, 10, 18, 12, 20, 19, 13, 27, 28, 21, 22, 14, 23, 32, 16	recall 4, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Sophomore	30, 6, 24, 13, 26, 12, 20, 19, 15, 21, 27, 22, 14, 23, 32, 16	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Junior	6, 34, 10, 35, 19, 12, 20, 22, 14, 33, 21, 28, 32, 16, 29, 23	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Senior	6, 10, 30, 8, 20, 19, 12, 15, 14, 27, 21, 22, 23, 16, 32, 29	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	25, 35, 6, 19, 12, 13, 20, 22, 28, 21, 14, 27, 16, 32, 36, 23	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius at prayer? Write a

paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius at prayer? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene III suggests about Claudius at prayer. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act III, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius at prayer responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius at prayer follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene III and its treatment of Claudius at prayer. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius at prayer in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius at prayer. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “fetters” most nearly mean?

   A. unbending

   B. in a state of gross sin, unprepared

   C. chains for the feet

   D. sorrow for sin

2. *I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range. Therefore prepare you; I your commission will forthwith dispatch, And he to England shall along with you: The terms of our estate may not endure Hazard so dangerous as doth hourly grow Out of his lunacies.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene III”?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

   D. Claudius at prayer

SAT key: 1. C (chains for the feet); 2. D (Claudius at prayer)

Lesson 13: Act III, Scene IV

Focus: the closet scene

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act III, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “The only way of expressing emotion in the form of art is by finding an “objective correlative”; in other words, a set of objects, a situation, a chain of events which shall be the formula of that _particular_ emotion; such that when the external facts, which must terminate in sensory experience, are given, the emotion is immediately evoked.” (T. S. Eliot, poet and critic, *"Hamlet and His Problems," The Sacred Wood (1920), "Hamlet and His Problems"*; public domain). Term lesson: define "objective correlative," then judge: does Gertrude's guilt justify Hamlet's fury in III.iv? *Objective:* Analyze the closet scene and whether Hamlet's emotion matches its object. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, RL.11-12.5

Content note (killing, violence toward a parent (threatened), sexual imagery, suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Hamlet frightens his mother and kills Polonius through a curtain. Focus on rashness and responsibility. Hamlet's attack on his mother uses graphic sexual imagery ('the rank sweat of an enseamed bed', 'the nasty sty'). Gloss briefly; keep discussion on Hamlet's disgust and on Gertrude's position, not on the images. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: A man is killed by mistake in this scene. Hamlet uses graphic sexual language toward his mother.
Suggested language: “Who is responsible for Polonius's death?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.

Background: Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room.

Significance: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What happens when anger takes over? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... Content note before we start: A man is killed by mistake in this scene. Hamlet uses graphic sexual language toward his mother. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What happens when anger takes over?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Gertrude's guilt.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: cutpurse — a thief; pickpocket; bodiless — without a body; imagined; prating — chattering; penetrable — capable of being pierced; ulcerous — full of sores. "cutpurse": Origin: an English formation from cut + purse. "bodiless": Origin: an English formation from body + -less. "ulcerous": Origin: an English formation from ulcer + -ous.
Words: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket · bodiless: without a body; imagined · prating: chattering · penetrable: capable of being pierced · ulcerous: full of sores

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room. Hamlet finally acts but wrongly. Plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Structure: The Ghost reappears. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew'd in corruption, honeying and making" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" slowly and put it in my own words: Hearing someone behind the curtain, Hamlet cries "A rat?" and stabs through it, killing Polonius. Next, craft. I notice the short, sharp exclamations, as if he acts before he thinks. The strongest word is "rat": he treats the hidden man as vermin, which shows contempt and rashness. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room show? My answer: Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room shows that after so much delay he can act rashly; he stabs through the arras and kills the wrong man, Polonius, setting off the chain of deaths.

> *How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" slowly and put it in my own words: Hearing someone behind the curtain, Hamlet cries "A rat?" and stabs through it, killing Polonius. Next, craft. I notice the short, sharp exclamations, as if he acts before he thinks. The strongest word is "rat": he treats the hidden man as vermin, which shows contempt and rashness. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room show? My answer: Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room shows that after so much delay he can act rashly; he stabs through the arras and kills the wrong man, Polonius, setting off the chain of deaths.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

> *Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over? Is Gertrude guilty?
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude guilty?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the closet scene. Key takeaway: Gertrude's guilt.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet confronts Gertrude.
- **Structure:** The Ghost reappears.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Gertrude's guilt.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew’d in corruption, honeying and making” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “now, what follows: / Here is your husband; like a mildew’d ear, / Blasting his wholesome brother. Have you eyes? / Could you on this” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet kills Polonius.
- “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.
- “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen) Gertrude's shame.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man.
Evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cutpurse (noun)	a thief; pickpocket	*A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his pocket!*	“cutpurse”: Origin: an English formation from cut + purse. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cutpurse#Etymology)

bodiless (adjective)	without a body; imagined	*This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.*	"bodiless": Origin: an English formation from body + -less. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/bodiless#Etymology)
prating (adjective)	chattering	*Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*	
penetrable (adjective)	capable of being pierced	*Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.*	
ulcerous (adjective)	full of sores	*Mother, for love of grace, Lay not that flattering unction to your soul, That not your trespass, but my madness speaks: It will but skin and film the ulcerous place, Whilst rank corruption, mining all within, Infects unseen.*	"ulcerous": Origin: an English formation from ulcer + -ous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ulcerous#Etymology)
compost (noun)	manure	*Confess yourself to heaven; Repent what's past; avoid what is to come; And do not spread the compost on the weeds, To make them ranker.*	
presentment (noun)	picture; portrait	*Look here, upon this picture, and on this, The counterfeit presentment of two brothers.*	
grained (adjective)	deep-dyed; ingrained	*O Hamlet, speak no more: Thou turn'st mine eyes into my very soul; And there I see such black and grained spots As will not leave their tinct.*	
knavery (noun)	trickery	*There's letters seal'd: and my two schoolfellows, Whom I will trust as I will adders fang'd, They bear the mandate; they must sweep my way, And marshal me to knavery.*	
temperately (adverb)	calmly; steadily	*My pulse, as yours, doth temperately keep time, And makes as healthful music: it is not madness That I have utter'd: bring me to the test, And I the matter will re-word; which madness Would gambol from.*	

Discussion questions

1. What happens when anger takes over?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.

3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet think Polonius is at first? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A rat, or the king.
2. Where does Polonius hide? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Behind the arras
3. Whom does Hamlet kill? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius
4. What does Hamlet compare? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two portraits
5. Who sees the Ghost this time? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Only Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet urge Gertrude? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Avoid Claudius's bed
7. Retell the three most important events of “Act III, Scene IV” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.
8. Who is on stage in “Act III, Scene IV”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act III, Scene IV” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…” What does “cutpurse” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice.

2. What does "Act III, Scene IV" suggest about the closet scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the closet scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "Ay, lady, 'twas my word.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act III, Scene IV", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid…
7. How does "Act III, Scene IV" build on "Act III, Scene III"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: "O Hamlet, speak no more" (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "What happens when anger takes over?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Gertrude guilty of Claudius's crime? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the closet scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act III, Scene IV” treats the closet scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the closet scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom does Hamlet kill?

   A. Laertes

   B. Rosencrantz

   C. Claudius

   D. Polonius

   Key: D (Polonius)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 34: "O, speak to me no more; These words, like _____, enter in mine ears; No more, sweet Hamlet!" Word bank: excrements, husband, daggers, important
   Key: daggers
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet compare?
   A. Two letters
   B. Two swords
   C. Two portraits
   D. Two crowns

   Key: C (Two portraits)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.", what does "bodiless" most nearly mean?
   A. deeds transferring property
   B. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood
   C. unbending
   D. without a body; imagined

   Key: D (without a body; imagined)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Look here, upon this picture, and on this, The counterfeit _____ of two brothers." Word bank: presentment, cutpurse, prating, bodiless
   Key: presentment
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.", what does "prating" most nearly mean?
   A. image; likeness
   B. wooden flutes
   C. curse (a mild oath)
   D. chattering

   Key: D (chattering)
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O Hamlet, speak no more: Thou turn'st mine eyes into my very soul; And there I see such black and _____ spots As will not leave their tinct." Word bank: grained, prating, cutpurse, bodiless
   Key: grained
8. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet think Polonius is at first?
   Sample answer: A rat, or the king.
9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 3: "Look you lay home to him: Tell him his pranks have been too broad to bear with, And that your grace hath screen'd and stood _____ Much heat and him." Word bank: preaching, between, important, daggers
   Key: between
10. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius. The evidence is “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55 reveal about the character or situation? “I will bestow him, and will answer well The death I gave him.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words “answer” and “bestow” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 5 reveal about the character or situation? “I’ll warrant you, Fear me not: withdraw, I hear him coming.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 5) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words “withdraw” and “warrant” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “What wilt thou do? thou wilt not murder me?” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “murder” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 29 shapes its tone: “Such an act That blurs the grace and blush of modesty, Calls virtue hypocrite, takes off the rose From the fair forehead of an innocent love And sets a blister there, makes marriage-vows As false as dicers’ oaths: O, such a deed As from…” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “contraction” and “hypocrite” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 29) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 42 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “Do not forget: this visitation Is but to whet thy almost blunted purpose.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 42) develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. Its words “visitation” and “purpose” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Alas, how is’t with you, That you do bend your eye on vacancy And with the incorporal air do hold discourse?” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 44), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.
17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does Polonius hide?

    A. In the hall
    B. Under the bed
    C. In a closet
    D. Behind the arras

Key: D (Behind the arras)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass’d it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.”, what does “penetrable” most nearly mean?

    A. capable of being pierced

    B. the day of final judgment

    C. pressed with requests; courted

    D. image; likeness

    Key: A (capable of being pierced)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Mother, for love of grace, Lay not that flattering unction to your soul, That not your trespass, but my madness speaks: It will but skin and film the _____ place, Whilst rank corruption, mining all within, Infects unseen.” Word bank: bodiless, cutpurse, ulcerous, prating

    Key: ulcerous

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who sees the Ghost this time?

    A. Polonius

    B. Both

    C. Only Hamlet

    D. Gertrude

    Key: C (Only Hamlet)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet urge Gertrude?

    A. Leave Denmark

    B. Kill Claudius

    C. Avoid Claudius's bed

    D. Confess publicly

    Key: C (Avoid Claudius's bed)

22. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene IV”?

    A. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    B. The closet scene

    C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: B (The closet scene)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55 shapes its tone: “That monster, custom, who all sense doth eat, Of habits devil, is angel yet in this, That to the use of actions fair and good He likewise gives a frock or livery, That aptly is put on.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “likewise” and “actions” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Gertrude's guilt.

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Action and delay

    C. Appearance and reality

    D. Corruption and the state

    Key: D (Corruption and the state)

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Gertrude guilty of Claudius's crime?
    Sample answer: A reasoned view: Hamlet kills Polonius. The evidence is “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.".

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Confess yourself to heaven; Repent what’s past; avoid what is to come; And do not spread the _____ on the weeds, To make them ranker.” Word bank: cutpurse, bodiless, compost, prating
    Key: compost

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost?
    Sample answer: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice. The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 45 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Do not look upon me; Lest with this piteous action you convert My stern effects: then what I have to do Will want true colour; tears perchance for blood.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 45) develops appearance and reality: Gertrude's guilt. Its words “perchance” and “convert” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Look, where he goes, even now, out at the portal!” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 51), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 17? “Come, come, and sit you down; you shall not budge; You go not till I set you up a glass Where you may see the _____ part of you.”

    A. important

    B. thunders

    C. between

    D. inmost

    Key: D (inmost)

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. The words “intruding” and “wretched” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He stabs at "a rat? Dead,

for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.".

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet: “Thou wretched, rash, _____ fool, farewell”

    Key: intruding

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…”, what does “cutpurse” most nearly mean?

    A. coroner

    B. knowing in advance

    C. a thief; pickpocket

    D. sugared; flattering

    Key: C (a thief; pickpocket)

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene IV”? Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Metaphor

    C. Tone / mood

    D. Plot

    Key: D (Plot)

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius. The evidence is “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. The words “ducat” and “dead” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.".

35. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's shame. The evidence is “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. The words “speak” and “more” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act I, Scene IV to Act III, Scene IV. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus, the text reads “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” — Corruption. In Act III, Scene IV, “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet kills Polonius. Gertrude's guilt.

37. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Acceptance before the duel.

    B. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

C. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

D. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

Key: C (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

38. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Sample answer: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.". The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 2, 18, 5, 19, 20, 21, 8, 22, 11, 12, 13, 23, 15, 24, 25	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	7, 2, 26, 17, 6, 4, 27, 12, 22, 13, 11, 14, 24, 15, 25, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	29, 9, 7, 20, 19, 27, 10, 12, 22, 13, 24, 14, 15, 23, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	21, 31, 5, 20, 32, 12, 27, 11, 13, 14, 15, 23, 33, 25, 28, 34	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	31, 17, 6, 19, 1, 12, 13, 14, 24, 35, 15, 23, 16, 25, 36, 28	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 31, 6, 12, 22, 27, 37, 14, 24, 23, 35, 15, 16, 36, 25, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	32, 4, 19, 26, 13, 27, 14, 33, 24, 15, 35, 34, 16, 36, 28, 25	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	26, 20, 19, 17, 12, 15, 38, 33, 14, 23, 24, 28, 34, 36, 25, 16	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Senior	31, 19, 17, 1, 22, 11, 12, 14, 23, 35, 24, 36, 16, 25, 28, 34	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	21, 19, 26, 17, 13, 38, 33, 14, 24, 35, 23, 34, 28, 25, 36, 16	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show the closet scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the closet scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene IV suggests about the closet scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act III, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the closet scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the closet scene follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene IV and its treatment of the closet scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about the closet scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the closet scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial

approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "prating" most nearly mean?

   A. trickery
   B. calmly; steadily
   C. chattering
   D. deep-dyed; ingrained

2. *Ay, lady, 'twas my word. Lifts up the arras and discovers Polonius. Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell! I took thee for thy better: take thy fortune; Thou find'st to be too busy is some danger. Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene IV"?

   A. Hamlet's letter from the sea
   B. The closet scene
   C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return
   D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

SAT key: 1. C (chattering); 2. B (The closet scene)

Lesson 14: Act IV, Scene I

Focus: Claudius hears of Polonius's death

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act IV, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.

Background: Kings feared public unrest.

Significance: Claudius's self-interest.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do leaders handle bad news? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: How do leaders handle bad news?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Claudius worries about public opinion.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Two key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: mineral — a mine of ore; discord — conflict; distress. “mineral”: Origin: probably Old French mineral. “discord”: Origin: Old French descort; earlier Latin discordia.
Words: mineral: a mine of ore · discord: conflict; distress

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Kings feared public unrest. Claudius's self-interest. Characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the” (Act IV, Scene I, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" slowly and put it in my own words: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet is as mad as the sea and wind fighting over which is stronger. Next, craft. I notice the storm simile, which makes his madness a natural force. The strongest word is "mightier": it shows a struggle with no winner, which fits Hamlet's inner battle. Then, effect. How does Gertrude describe Hamlet's state to Claudius? My answer: Gertrude protects Hamlet by insisting he is mad, not dangerous; the image also shows the turmoil she has seen, and Claudius decides to send him to England.

> *Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier* (Act IV, Scene I, Queen)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" slowly and put it in my own words: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet is as mad as the sea and wind fighting over which is stronger. Next, craft. I notice the storm simile, which makes his madness a natural force. The strongest word is "mightier": it shows a struggle with no winner, which fits Hamlet's inner battle. Then, effect. How does Gertrude describe Hamlet's state to Claudius? My answer: Gertrude protects Hamlet by insisting he is mad, not dangerous; the image also shows the turmoil she has seen, and Claudius decides to send him to England.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

> *My soul is full of discord and dismay* (Act IV, Scene I)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news? Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Key takeaway: Claudius worries about public opinion.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.
- **Plot:** Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Mad as the sea and wind."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Claudius worries about public opinion.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the” (Act IV, Scene I, King).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “As level as the canon to his blank, / Transports his poison’d shot, may miss our name, / And hit the woundless air. O” (Act IV, Scene I).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) Gertrude's description.
- “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) Claudius's anxiety.
- “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I) Claudius's political move.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety.
Evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I)
Reasoning: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
mineral (noun)	a mine of ore	*To draw apart the body he hath kill’d: O’er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.*	“mineral”: Origin: probably Old French mineral. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/mineral#Etymology)
discord (noun)	conflict; distress	*My soul is full of discord and dismay.*	“discord”: Origin: Old French descort; earlier Latin discordia. (Liber et Libri origin

			note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/discord#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How do leaders handle bad news?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whom does Claudius send to find Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern.
2. Who tells Claudius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. What does Gertrude say Hamlet is? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Mad
4. What does Claudius fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: It could have been him
5. Where will Hamlet be sent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: England
6. How does Claudius describe his soul? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Full of discord and dismay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done." What does "mineral" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: mineral: a mine of ore.

Inferential / analytical

1. Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: She describes him as mad.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene I” suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Claudius's self-interest.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Friends both, go join you with some further aid: Hamlet in madness hath Polonius slain, And from his mother’s closet hath he dragg’d him: Go seek him out; speak fair, and bring…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene I” build on “Act III, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “How do leaders handle bad news?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or

unusual word choices and their connotations.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does this show about Claudius as king? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Claudius's self-interest.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene I” treats Claudius hears of Polonius's death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we'll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Claudius describe his soul?

   A. At peace

   B. Full of discord and dismay

   C. Empty

   D. Joyful

   Key: B (Full of discord and dismay)

2. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom does Claudius send to find Hamlet?

   Sample answer: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern.

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who tells Claudius?

   A. Gertrude

   B. Hamlet

   C. Laertes

   D. Rosencrantz

   Key: A (Gertrude)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I, Queen: "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the _____"

   Key: mightier

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a _____ of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done." Word bank: discord, mineral

   Key: mineral

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius fear?

   A. It could have been him

   B. Laertes

   C. The players

   D. Norway

   Key: A (It could have been him)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where will Hamlet be sent?

   A. Wittenberg

   B. France

   C. England

   D. Norway

   Key: C (England)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I: "My soul is full of _____ and dismay"

   Key: discord

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Gertrude say Hamlet is?

   A. Guilty

   B. Calm

C. Mad

D. Asleep

Key: C (Mad)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest _____”

    Key: friends

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

    Sample answer: She describes him as mad: Gertrude's description. The evidence is “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

12. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene I”? Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.

    A. Tone / mood

    B. Alliteration

    C. Plot

    D. Setting

    Key: C (Plot)

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Claudius worries about public opinion.

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Action and delay

    C. Appearance and reality

    D. Corruption and the state

    Key: D (Corruption and the state)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I).

    Sample answer: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay.". The evidence is “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) — Claudius's anxiety. This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this show about Claudius as king?

    Sample answer: A judgment: Gertrude's description. The evidence is “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay.".

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act III, Scene IV to Act IV, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet, the text reads “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” — Hamlet kills Polonius. In Act IV, Scene I, “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) — Gertrude's description. Claudius worries about public opinion.

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene I”? Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.

    A. Simile

    B. Characterization

    C. Tone / mood

    D. Alliteration

    Key: B (Characterization)

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Claudius's political move. The evidence is “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion. The words “friends” and “wisest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety. The evidence is “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion. The words “discord” and “dismay” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay.".

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10: “That cannot be; since I am still possess’d Of those effects for which I did the murder, My crown, mine own _____ and my queen.” Word bank: whereto, ambition, thicker, incestuous

    Key: ambition

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 4? “We will _____ provide: Most holy and religious fear it is To keep those many many bodies safe That live and feed upon your majesty.”

    A. ourselves

    B. repent

    C. whereto

    D. madness

    Key: A (ourselves)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 17? “Come, come, and sit you down; you shall not budge; You go not till I set you up a glass Where you may see the _____ part of you.”

    A. important

    B. thunders

    C. between

    D. inmost

    Key: D (inmost)

23. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 3: “There’s matter in these sighs, these profound heaves: You must translate: ’tis fit we _____ them.” Word

bank: bloody, further, divulging, understand

Key: understand

24. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 5 reveal about the character or situation? “I’ll warrant you, Fear me not: withdraw, I hear him coming.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 5) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words “withdraw” and “warrant” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene I”?

    A. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    B. The Ghost's revelation

    C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    D. The graveyard

    Key: A (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 4 reveal about the character or situation? “Bestow this place on us a little while.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 4) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Claudius worries about public opinion. The words “little” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety. The evidence is “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “Pray can I not, Though inclination be as sharp as will: My stronger guilt defeats my strong intent; And, like a man to double business bound, I stand in pause where I shall first begin, And both neglect.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “inclination” and “stronger” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet wants damnation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “But, O, what form of prayer Can serve my turn?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “prayer” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet wants damnation. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “What wilt thou do? thou wilt not murder me?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “murder” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “At gaming, swearing, or about some act That has no relish of salvation in’t” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet wants damnation. Its words “salvation” and “swearing” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But in our circumstance and course of thought, ’Tis heavy with him: and am I then revenged, To take him in the purging…” (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 11? “Friends both, go join you with some _____ aid: Hamlet in madness hath Polonius slain, And from his mother’s closet hath he dragg’d him: Go seek him out; speak fair, and bring the body Into the chapel.”

    A. divulging

    B. further

    C. bloody

    D. understand

    Key: B (further)

33. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 3 reveal about the character or situation? “Therefore prepare you; I your commission will forthwith dispatch, And he to England shall along with you: The terms of our estate may not endure Hazard so dangerous as doth hourly grow Out of his lunacies.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene III, paragraph 3) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “commission” and “dangerous” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

34. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55 reveal about the character or situation? “I will bestow him, and will answer well The death I gave him.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words “answer” and “bestow” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

35. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's description. The evidence is “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

36. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55 shapes its tone: “That monster, custom, who all sense doth eat, Of habits devil, is angel yet in this, That to the use of actions fair and good He likewise gives a frock or livery, That aptly is put on.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “likewise” and “actions” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55) make the tone heavy and deliberate

rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 9 shapes its tone: "The sun no sooner shall the mountains touch, But we will ship him hence: and this vile deed We must, with all our majesty and skill, Both countenance and excuse." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "countenance" and "mountains" (Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 9) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Claudius worries about public opinion. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 45 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "Do not look upon me; Lest with this piteous action you convert My stern effects: then what I have to do Will want true colour; tears perchance for blood." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 45) develops appearance and reality: Gertrude's guilt. Its words "perchance" and "convert" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Look, where he goes, even now, out at the portal!" (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 51), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

39. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 34: "O, speak to me no more; These words, like _____, enter in mine ears; No more, sweet Hamlet!" Word bank: excrements, husband, daggers, important
    Key: daggers

40. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 3: "Look you lay home to him: Tell him his pranks have been too broad to bear with, And that your grace hath screen'd and stood _____ Much heat and him." Word bank: preaching, between, important, daggers
    Key: between

41. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, paragraph 12: "Then trip him, that his heels may kick at heaven, And that his soul may be as damn'd and black As hell, _____ it goes." Word bank: whereto, revenge, ambition, incestuous
    Key: whereto

42. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 29 shapes its tone: "Such an act That blurs the grace and blush of modesty, Calls virtue hypocrite, takes off the rose From the fair forehead of an innocent love And sets a blister there, makes marriage-vows As false as dicers' oaths: O, such a deed As from…" Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "contraction" and "hypocrite" (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 29) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

43. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 42 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "Do not forget: this visitation Is but to whet thy almost blunted purpose." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 42) develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. Its words "visitation" and "purpose" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Alas, how is't with you, That you do bend your eye on vacancy And with the incorporal air do hold discourse?" (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 44), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

44. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My soul is full of _____ and dismay.” Word bank: mineral, discord

    Key: discord

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 1, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	5, 7, 9, 8, 3, 2, 4, 6, 1, 11, 17, 18, 13, 19, 16, 15	recall 9, inference 1, analysis 3, synthesis 3
HS Sophomore	20, 21, 22, 3, 23, 4, 24, 25, 11, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 16	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	20, 22, 1, 32, 5, 3, 33, 34, 35, 26, 28, 36, 30, 37, 31, 38	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	39, 40, 1, 3, 9, 33, 24, 26, 11, 29, 36, 13, 37, 38, 19, 15	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	41, 3, 5, 9, 6, 24, 11, 28, 29, 42, 30, 12, 31, 43, 16, 15	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	41, 23, 6, 3, 9, 24, 11, 28, 42, 13, 37, 18, 31, 43, 16, 15	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 3, 5, 4, 9, 6, 28, 29, 30, 14, 37, 31, 38, 43, 16, 15	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	21, 40, 44, 3, 35, 29, 30, 42, 13, 17, 37, 31, 38, 43, 16, 15	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Senior	23, 5, 3, 9, 6, 29, 42, 30, 14, 18, 13, 31, 38, 43, 16, 15	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	44, 4, 3, 9, 6, 28, 30, 12, 18, 37, 31, 38, 43, 15, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene I suggests about Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius hears of Polonius's death follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene I and its treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius hears of Polonius's death in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Friends both, go join you with some further aid: Hamlet in madness hath Polonius slain, And from his mother's closet hath he dragg'd him: Go seek him out; speak fair, and bring the body Into the chapel. I pray you, haste in this. Exeunt Rosencrantz and Guildenstern. Come, Gertrude, we'll call up our wisest friends; And let them know, both what we mean to do, And what's untimely done. So haply slander— Whose whisper o'er the world's diameter, As level as the canon to his blank, Transports his poison'd shot, may miss our name, And hit the woundless air. O, come away! My soul is full of discord and dismay. Exeunt.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene I"?

   A. The graveyard

B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

C. Polonius spies on Laertes

D. The Ghost's revelation

SAT key: 1. B (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

Lesson 15: Act IV, Scene II

Focus: Hamlet hides the body

Objective: Students will summarize what happens in Act IV, Scene II (Hamlet hides the body) in 2 sentences and, in a 3-sentence warm-up response, explain how one quoted line from the scene sets up the scene that follows.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.3

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.

Background: Sponges soak and are squeezed dry.

Significance: Hamlet's wit as weapon.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Why use riddles? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....*
> **Prompt:** Why use riddles?
> **Sentence starters:** I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
> **Strong response:** A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the courtiers serve the king.

> **8–16 min · Background and context · I do (8 min)**
> Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
> *Sponges soak and are squeezed dry. Hamlet's wit as weapon. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Plot: Hamlet hides the body. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).*

> **16–20 min · Closure · I do (4 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes Hamlet hides the body. Key takeaway: the courtiers serve the king.*

Total: 20 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
- **Plot:** Hamlet hides the body.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the courtiers serve the king.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “What have you done, my lord, with the dead body” (Act IV, Scene II, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Rosencrantz as sponge.
- “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Riddle.
- “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet runs.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool.
Evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
knavish (adjective)	villainous; sly	*I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.*	“knavish”: Origin: an English formation from knave + -ish. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/knavish#Etymology)
replication (noun)	a reply or answer	*Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what replication should be made by the son of a king?*	

Discussion questions

1. Why use riddles?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.

3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the body and king? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.
2. Who asks where the body is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern
3. What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A sponge
4. How does Hamlet answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In riddles
5. What does Hamlet do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Runs off
6. Whose favour does the sponge soak up? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king's
7. Retell the three most important events of “Act IV, Scene II” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
8. Who is on stage in “Act IV, Scene II”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act IV, Scene II” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.” What does “knavish” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: knavish: villainous; sly.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does the sponge image mean? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Courtiers are used and discarded.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene II” suggest about Hamlet hides the body? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's wit as weapon.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance, his rewards, his authorities.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene II” build on “Act IV, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why use riddles?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On plot: Hamlet hides the body. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet mad here? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet's wit as weapon.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet hides the body. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with

criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how "Act IV, Scene II" treats Hamlet hides the body with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene III" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Hamlet answer?

   A. Silently

   B. In riddles

   C. With a letter

   D. Directly

   Key: B (In riddles)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who asks where the body is?

   A. Gertrude

B. Horatio

C. Claudius

D. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern

Key: D (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz?

   A. A friend

   B. A sponge

   C. A fool

   D. A rat

   Key: B (A sponge)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what _____ should be made by the son of a king?" Word bank: replication, knavish

   Key: replication

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.", what does "knavish" most nearly mean?

   A. causing great pain

   B. conflict; distress

   C. villainous; sly

   D. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

   Key: C (villainous; sly)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's _____"

   Key: countenance

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet do at the end?

   A. Confesses

   B. Runs off

   C. Weeps

   D. Fights

   Key: B (Runs off)

8. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say about the body and king?

   Sample answer: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose favour does the sponge soak up?

   A. Polonius's

   B. Hamlet's

   C. The king's

   D. Gertrude's

   Key: C (The king's)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I am glad of it: a _____ speech sleeps in a foolish ear." Word bank: knavish, replication

    Key: knavish

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene II"?

    A. Worms and kings

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. Hamlet hides the body

    D. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

    Key: C (Hamlet hides the body)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does the sponge image mean?

    Sample answer: Courtiers are used and discarded: Rosencrantz as sponge. The evidence is "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

13. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.". The evidence is "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet runs. The evidence is "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words "after" and "and" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The courtiers serve the king.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Corruption and the state

    Key: D (Corruption and the state)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet mad here?

    Sample answer: A reasoned view: Riddle. The evidence is "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 7: "But, like the owner of a foul disease, To keep it from _____, let it feed Even on the pith of Life." Word bank: divulging, further, bloody, understand

    Key: divulging

18. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act III, Scene IV?

    A. "Come, come, and sit you down; you shall not budge; You go not till I set you up a glass Where you may see the inmost part of you."

    B. "No, by the rood, not so: You are the queen, your husband's brother's wife; And—would it were not so! —you are my mother."

C. “What wilt thou do? thou wilt not murder me?”

D. “Nay, then, I’ll set those to you that can speak.”

Key: B (“No, by the rood, not so: You are the queen, your husband’s brother’s wife; And—would it were not so!—you are my mother.”)

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 28 reveal about the character or situation? “What have I done, that thou darest wag thy tongue In noise so rude against me?” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 28) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words “against” and “tongue” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act IV, Scene I?

A. “But, like the owner of a foul disease, To keep it from divulging, let it feed Even on the pith of Life.”

B. “It will be laid to us, whose providence Should have kept short, restrain’d and out of haunt, This mad young man”

C. “The sun no sooner shall the mountains touch, But we will ship him hence: and this vile deed We must, with all our majesty and skill, Both…”

D. “Alas, how shall this bloody deed be answer’d?”

Key: D (“Alas, how shall this bloody deed be answer’d?”)

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act IV, Scene II?

A. “But soft, what noise? who calls on Hamlet?”

B. “Tell us where ’tis, that we may take it thence And bear it to the chapel.”

C. “That I can keep your counsel and not mine own.”

D. “What have you done, my lord, with the dead body?”

Key: A (“But soft, what noise? who calls on Hamlet?”)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 39 shapes its tone: “Save me, and hover o’er me with your wings, You heavenly guards!” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “heavenly” and “guards” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 39) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.

A. Simile

B. Alliteration

C. Characterization

D. Setting

Key: C (Characterization)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Once more, good night: And when you are desirous to be bless’d, I’ll blessing beg of you.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55) develops appearance and reality: Gertrude's guilt. Its words

"blessing" and "desirous" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "That monster, custom, who all sense doth eat, Of habits devil, is angel yet in this, That to the use of actions fair…" (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act IV, Scene I to Act IV, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene I, Queen, the text reads "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" — Gertrude's description. In Act IV, Scene II, "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) — Rosencrantz as sponge. The courtiers serve the king.

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 42: "But, look, _____ on thy mother sits: O, step between her and her fighting soul: Conceit in weakest bodies strongest works: Speak to her, Hamlet." Word bank: amazement, father, virtue, thunders
    Key: amazement

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 60 reveal about the character or situation? "Alack, I had forgot: 'tis so concluded on." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 60) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Gertrude's guilt. The words "concluded" and "forgot" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 44 shapes its tone: "O gentle son, Upon the heat and flame of thy distemper Sprinkle cool patience." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "distemper" and "patience" (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 44) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Gertrude's guilt. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 51 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "Why, look you there! look, how it steals away!" Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 51) develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. Its words "steals" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "I will bestow him, and will answer well The death I gave him." (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 55), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 7 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "It will be laid to us, whose providence Should have kept short, restrain'd and out of haunt, This mad young man" Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 7) develops appearance and reality: Claudius worries about public opinion. Its words "providence" and "restrain" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "The sun no sooner shall the mountains touch, But we will ship him hence: and this vile deed We must, with all our…" (Act IV, Scene I, paragraph 9), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 15: "No, by the rood, not so: You are the queen, your _____'s brother's wife; And—would it were not so!—you are my mother." Word bank: brother, answer, husband, father
    Key: husband

32. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Riddle. The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 16 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Nay, then, I’ll set those to you that can speak.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 16) develops appearance and reality: Gertrude's guilt. Its words its wording carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “What wilt thou do? thou wilt not murder me?” (Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 18), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

34. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

    A. Foreshadowing
    B. Diction / vocabulary
    C. Setting
    D. Structure

    Key: B (Diction / vocabulary)

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge. The evidence is “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words “countenance” and “soaks” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene II, paragraph 17 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “My lord, you must tell us where the body is, and go with us to the king.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene II, paragraph 17) develops appearance and reality: the courtiers serve the king. Its words its wording carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “What have you done, my lord, with the dead body?” (Act IV, Scene II, paragraph 7), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

37. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which word completes this sentence from Act III, Scene IV, paragraph 51? “My _____, in his habit as he lived!”

    A. amazement
    B. husband
    C. father
    D. brother

    Key: C (father)

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning?

Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Riddle. The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words “with” and “king” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 3, 9, 10, 8, 1, 7, 5, 2, 6, 12, 11, 14, 13, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 5, 4, 1, 7, 6, 18, 19, 20, 21, 12, 22, 15, 23, 24, 25	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	26, 17, 6, 8, 9, 27, 19, 20, 11, 21, 28, 13, 15, 14, 29, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	31, 2, 3, 4, 18, 27, 19, 12, 32, 28, 22, 15, 14, 33, 24, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 6, 1, 19, 18, 27, 32, 28, 22, 15, 34, 14, 24, 30, 25, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 10, 2, 19, 18, 20, 21, 28, 22, 15, 14, 13, 29, 16, 35, 36	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	10, 5, 4, 19, 18, 12, 22, 28, 15, 34, 13, 29, 30, 36, 25, 16	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	31, 37, 10, 27, 20, 22, 28, 14, 15, 34, 29, 33, 24, 30, 25, 38	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	31, 3, 10, 2, 1, 28, 15, 14, 33, 29, 24, 30, 38, 36, 16, 25	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 3, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	10, 4, 2, 18, 28, 22, 15, 23, 33, 29, 24, 30, 25, 36, 16, 35	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 4, synthesis 8

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet hides the body? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet hides the body? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene II develops the idea of Hamlet hides the body. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence,

and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene II suggests about Hamlet hides the body. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet hides the body responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet hides the body follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene II and its treatment of Hamlet hides the body. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet hides the body in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet hides the body. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance, his rewards, his authorities. But such officers do the king best service in the end: he keeps them, like an ape, in the corner of his jaw; first mouthed, to be last swallowed: when he needs what you have gleaned, it is but squeezing you, and, sponge, you shall be dry again.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene II"?

   A. The graveyard

   B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

   C. Hamlet hides the body

   D. Claudius at prayer

SAT key: 1. C (Hamlet hides the body)

Lesson 16: Act IV, Scene III

Focus: worms and kings

Objective: Students will analyze how diction / vocabulary develops in "Act IV, Scene III" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: This lesson mentions suicide.
Suggested language:
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.

Background: England owed Denmark tribute.

Significance: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death do to rank? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What does death do to rank?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: kings and beggars.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Four key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appliance — remedy; convocation — an assembly; scourge — a punishment; whip; politic — crafty; shrewd. "appliance": Origin: an English formation from apply + -ance. "convocation": Origin: Old French convocation; earlier Latin convocatio.
Words: appliance: remedy · convocation: an assembly · scourge: a punishment; whip · politic: crafty; shrewd

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
England owed Denmark tribute. Mortality and Claudius's treachery. Diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Watch for acting and seeming: "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: "all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or" (Act IV, Scene III, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Claudius that worms are the only true emperors, since all bodies end as their food. Next, craft. I notice the dark joke, turning "emperor" into a word for worms. The strongest word is "emperor": it mocks royal power, since even kings feed worms. Then, effect. What is Hamlet saying about death and kings? My answer: Hamlet's wit hides a threat and a truth: Claudius too will die and rot; death levels everyone, a theme that grows in the graveyard scene.

> *Your worm is your only emperor for diet* *(Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Claudius that worms are the only true emperors, since all bodies end as their food. Next, craft. I notice the dark joke, turning "emperor" into a word for worms. The strongest word is "emperor": it mocks royal power, since even kings feed worms. Then, effect. What is Hamlet saying about death and kings? My answer: Hamlet's wit hides a threat and a truth: Claudius too will die and rot; death levels everyone, a theme that grows in the graveyard scene.

40–50 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (10 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

> *a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar* *(Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

50–55 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (5 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."
Task: Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

55–60 min · Discussion · We do (5 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does death do to rank? Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?
Anchor question: What does death do to rank?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?

60–67 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. (“a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar”, Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. (“a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar”, Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

67–70 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how diction / vocabulary shapes worms and kings. Key takeaway: kings and beggars.

Total: 70 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Diction / vocabulary:** Worms and kings.
- **Plot:** Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
- **Characterization:** Claudius's soliloquy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** kings and beggars.

Symbols and motifs

- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or” (Act IV, Scene III, King).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “Where the dead body is bestow’d, my lord, / We cannot get from him” (Act IV, Scene III, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Death levels all.
- “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Mortality.
- “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King) Claudius's plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death.
Evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appliance (noun)	remedy	*To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*	“appliance”: Origin: an English formation from apply + -ance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/appliance#Etymology)
convocation (noun)	an assembly	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.*	“convocation”: Origin: Old French convocation; earlier Latin convocatio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/convocation#Etymology)
scourge (noun)	a punishment; whip	*Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He’s loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where ’tis so, the offender’s scourge is weigh’d, But never the offence.*	
politic (adjective)	crafty; shrewd	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does death do to rank?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What will a king do through a beggar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Go a progress through his guts.
2. Where does Hamlet say Polonius is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At supper, being eaten
3. What does Claudius order? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's death in England
4. What does Hamlet say about worms? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Your worm is your only emperor for diet
5. Where is the body? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Up the stairs into the lobby
6. What does Claudius call Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Like the hectic in my blood
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all." What does "appliance" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: appliance: remedy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Claudius's letter significant? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: It shows his intent to kill.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene III" suggest about worms and kings? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.
3. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about worms and kings? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels

all. On plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “I have sent to seek him, and to find the body.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene III” build on “Act IV, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What does death do to rank?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Hamlet suspect the plot? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Mortality and Claudius's treachery.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A

defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of worms and kings. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the diction / vocabulary in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. On diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene III” treats worms and kings with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene IV" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about worms and kings? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is the body?

   A. Up the stairs into the lobby

   B. In the garden

   C. In the chapel

   D. In the river

   Key: A (Up the stairs into the lobby)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He's loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where 'tis so, the offender's scourge is weigh'd, But never the offence.", what does "scourge" most nearly mean?

   A. uncontrolled

   B. a punishment; whip

   C. idle, flirtatious play

   D. trickery

   Key: B (a punishment; whip)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet: "a king may go a _____ through the guts of a beggar"
   Key: progress
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say about worms?
   A. Worms are friends
   B. Worms fear kings
   C. Your worm is your only emperor for diet
   D. Nothing

   Key: C (Your worm is your only emperor for diet)
5. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What will a king do through a beggar?
   Sample answer: Go a progress through his guts.
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does Hamlet say Polonius is?
   A. In heaven
   B. In the river
   C. In England
   D. At supper, being eaten

   Key: D (At supper, being eaten)
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate _____ are relieved, Or not at all." Word bank: scourge, appliance, politic, convocation
   Key: appliance
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain _____ of politic worms are e'en at him." Word bank: politic, convocation, scourge, appliance
   Key: convocation
9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet: "Your worm is your only _____ for diet"
   Key: emperor
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius order?
    A. Hamlet's death in England
    B. Hamlet's crowning
    C. Polonius's burial only
    D. Laertes's return

    Key: A (Hamlet's death in England)
11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius call Hamlet?
    A. A son
    B. A friend
    C. Like the hectic in my blood
    D. A traitor

    Key: C (Like the hectic in my blood)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why is Claudius's letter significant?
    Sample answer: It shows his intent to kill. The evidence is "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King) — Claudius's plan. This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Death levels all. The evidence is "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act IV, Scene III"? Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
    A. Imagery
    B. Alliteration
    C. Plot
    D. Allusion

    Key: C (Plot)
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Kings and beggars.
    A. Death and mortality
    B. Appearance and reality
    C. Action and delay
    D. Revenge and justice

    Key: A (Death and mortality)
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act III, Scene I to Act IV, Scene III. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act III, Scene I, Hamlet, the text reads "To be, or not to be: that is the question" — Life versus death. In Act IV, Scene III, "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) — Death levels all. Kings and beggars.
17. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene III"?
    A. Worms and kings
    B. The closet scene
    C. Claudius at prayer
    D. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    Key: A (Worms and kings)
18. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Claudius's plan. The evidence is "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. It reads more sharply beside "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet), which shows the same situation from another angle.

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 31? “My _____: father and mother is man and wife; man and wife is one flesh; and so, my mother.”

    A. indeed

    B. cicatrice

    C. associates

    D. mother

    Key: D (mother)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act IV, Scene III?

    A. “But indeed, if you find him not within this month, you shall nose him as you go up the stairs into the lobby.”

    B. “A man may fish with the worm that hath eat of a king, and eat of the fish that hath fed of that worm.”

    C. “In heaven; send hither to see: if your messenger find him not there, seek him i’ the other place yourself.”

    D. “Hamlet, this deed, for thine especial safety— Which we do tender, as we dearly grieve For that which thou hast done—must send thee hence…”

    Key: B (“A man may fish with the worm that hath eat of a king, and eat of the fish that hath fed of that worm.”)

21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 32 reveal about the character or situation? “Follow him at foot; tempt him with speed aboard; Delay it not; I’ll have him hence to-night: Away! for every thing is seal’d and done That else leans on the affair: pray you, make haste.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 32) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: kings and beggars. The words “aboard” and “affair” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.". The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) — Mortality. This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Death levels all. The evidence is “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. The words “emperor” and “only” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.".

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 6: “Where the dead body is _____’d, my lord, We cannot get from him.” Word bank: indeed, mother, bestow, cicatrice

    Key: bestow

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 21 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “In heaven; send hither to see: if your messenger find him not there, seek him i’ the other place yourself.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 21) develops appearance and reality: kings and beggars. Its words “messenger” and “yourself” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Hamlet, this deed, for thine especial safety— Which we do tender, as we dearly grieve For that which thou hast…” (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 24), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.
26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Does Hamlet suspect the plot?
    Sample answer: A judgment: Mortality. The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.".
27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.”, what does “politic” most nearly mean?
    A. a punishment; whip
    B. crafty; shrewd
    C. an assembly
    D. remedy

    Key: B (crafty; shrewd)
28. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Mortality. The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.
29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene III”? Worms and kings.
    A. Structure
    B. Alliteration
    C. Point of view
    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Mortality. The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. The words “progress” and “through” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.".
31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] In the line “To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.”, what does “appliance” most nearly mean?
    A. remedy

B. crafty; shrewd

C. a punishment; whip

D. an assembly

Key: A (remedy)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 10, 3, 8, 11, 9, 5, 4, 2, 6, 12, 13, 17, 15, 18, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	4, 9, 5, 3, 19, 8, 1, 11, 20, 12, 21, 22, 15, 18, 23, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 3, 7, 10, 24, 9, 11, 1, 20, 21, 12, 14, 15, 18, 23, 25	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 2, 1, 4, 19, 9, 12, 21, 17, 20, 18, 15, 22, 25, 26, 23	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 3
AP	7, 24, 10, 19, 27, 20, 12, 21, 28, 18, 15, 14, 16, 25, 23, 26	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Freshman	9, 5, 27, 24, 11, 12, 28, 20, 13, 21, 18, 15, 29, 26, 25, 16	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 3
College Sophomore	7, 24, 11, 19, 2, 21, 20, 12, 13, 14, 18, 15, 26, 16, 25, 30	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Junior	7, 10, 1, 11, 9, 20, 13, 21, 12, 29, 18, 15, 25, 16, 30, 26	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Senior	9, 10, 19, 31, 3, 20, 21, 12, 28, 29, 18, 15, 25, 23, 16, 26	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	10, 6, 1, 3, 8, 21, 12, 20, 15, 22, 29, 18, 25, 16, 23, 26	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show worms and kings? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of worms and kings? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of

worms and kings. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene III suggests about worms and kings. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses diction / vocabulary in Act IV, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of worms and kings. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of worms and kings responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of worms and kings follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene III and its treatment of worms and kings. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about worms and kings in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of worms and kings. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “appliance” most nearly mean?

   A. remedy

   B. a punishment; whip

C. an assembly

D. crafty; shrewd

2. *I have sent to seek him, and to find the body. How dangerous is it that this man goes loose! Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He's loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where 'tis so, the offender's scourge is weigh'd, But never the offence. To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene III"?

A. The plot against Hamlet

B. The Ghost's revelation

C. The closet scene

D. Worms and kings

SAT key: 1. A (remedy); 2. D (Worms and kings)

Lesson 17: Act IV, Scene IV

Focus: Fortinbras's army

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in “Act IV, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “This exclamation and this question both show the same thing, that the whole story turns upon the peculiar character of the hero.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III*; public domain). Thought experiment (Bradley's own): swap Hamlet for Fortinbras or Laertes. How short is the play? Context: Bradley is answering the question why Hamlet did not obey the Ghost at once. *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's self-reproach on seeing Fortinbras's army. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: This lesson mentions suicide.
Suggested language:
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.

Background: Fortinbras as foil.

Significance: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is fighting for honour admirable? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because.... If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet resolves.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: imposthume — an abscess; internal swelling; oblivion — forgetfulness; capability — power; capacity; frontier — a border region; fantasy — imagination; a figment. "oblivion": Origin: Anglo-Norman oblivion; earlier Latin oblīviō ("forgetfulness").
Words: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling · oblivion: forgetfulness · capability: power; capacity · frontier: a border region · fantasy: imagination; a figment

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fortinbras as foil. A turning point in Hamlet's resolve. Structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Watch for death and the grave: skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "How all occasions do inform against me" slowly and put it in my own words: Seeing Fortinbras's army march to fight for a tiny piece of land, Hamlet says every event accuses him. Next, craft. I notice the personified "occasions" that inform against him like witnesses. The strongest word is "inform": it means accuse, so the world itself testifies against his delay. Then, effect. What does Hamlet see in Fortinbras's army? My answer: In Fortinbras's army Hamlet sees thousands of soldiers ready to die for a worthless patch of ground; shamed, he resolves that his thoughts will be bloody, which sharpens his sense of failure.

> *How all occasions do inform against me (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "How all occasions do inform against me" slowly and put it in my own words: Seeing Fortinbras's army march to fight for a tiny piece of land, Hamlet says every event accuses him. Next, craft. I notice the personified "occasions" that inform against him like witnesses. The strongest word is "inform": it means accuse, so the world itself testifies against his delay. Then, effect. What does Hamlet see in Fortinbras's army? My answer: In Fortinbras's army Hamlet sees thousands of soldiers ready to die for a worthless patch of ground; shamed, he resolves that his thoughts will be bloody, which sharpens his sense of failure.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

> *Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable? Is Fortinbras admirable?
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Facilitation: Is Fortinbras admirable?

> **80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
> Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
> *Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.*
> **Exit ticket:** In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation.
> **Answer:** Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how structure shapes Fortinbras's army. Key takeaway: Hamlet resolves.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."
- **Characterization:** Fortinbras as foil.
- **Conflict:** Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet resolves.

Symbols and motifs

- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet's self-reproach.
- "Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Greatness.
- "O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Resolve.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution.
Evidence: "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
imposthume (noun)	an abscess; internal swelling	*Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*	
oblivion (noun)	forgetfulness	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*	"oblivion": Origin: Anglo-Norman oblivion; earlier Latin oblīviō ("forgetfulness"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/oblivion#Etymology)
capability (noun)	power; capacity	*Sure, he that made us with such large discourse, Looking before and after, gave us not That capability and god-like reason To fust in us unused.*	
frontier (noun)	a border region	*Goes it against the main of Poland, sir, Or for some frontier?*	
fantasy (noun)	imagination; a figment	*The imminent death of twenty thousand men, / That, for a fantasy and trick of fame,*	

Discussion questions

1. Is fighting for honour admirable?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many men will die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Twenty thousand.
2. Whose army passes? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras's
3. What are they fighting for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A little patch of ground
4. How does Hamlet react? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He berates his delay
5. What does Hamlet vow? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Bloody thoughts
6. Who tells Hamlet about the war? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A Captain
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene IV", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene IV" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies." What does "imposthume" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling.

Inferential / analytical

1. What makes Fortinbras a foil? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: He acts decisively.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene IV" suggest about Fortinbras's army? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene IV” build on “Act IV, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is fighting for honour admirable?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does conflict appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Fortinbras's war admirable or absurd? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A

defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Fortinbras's army. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene IV” treats Fortinbras's army with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: "O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene V" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: "Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 31? "My _____: father and mother is man and wife; man and wife is one flesh; and so, my mother."

   A. indeed

   B. cicatrice

   C. associates

   D. mother

   Key: D (mother)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 6: "Where the dead body is _____'d, my lord, We cannot get from him." Word bank: indeed, mother, bestow, cicatrice

   Key: bestow
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet: "How all _____ do inform against me"

   Key: occasions

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The imminent death of twenty thousand men, / That, for a _____ and trick of fame," Word bank: fantasy, oblivion, imposthume, capability

   Key: fantasy

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What are they fighting for?

   A. A little patch of ground

   B. A princess

   C. Gold

   D. Denmark

   Key: A (A little patch of ground)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Hamlet react?

   A. He weeps

   B. He laughs

   C. He berates his delay

   D. He joins

   Key: C (He berates his delay)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who tells Hamlet about the war?

   A. Fortinbras

   B. Horatio

   C. Rosencrantz

   D. A Captain

   Key: D (A Captain)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Sure, he that made us with such large discourse, Looking before and after, gave us not That capability and god-like reason To fust in us unused.", what does "capability" most nearly mean?

   A. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

   B. release; acquittal

   C. deeds transferring property

   D. power; capacity

   Key: D (power; capacity)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet: "O, from this time forth, / My _____ be bloody, or be nothing worth"

   Key: thoughts

10. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene II, paragraph 7 reveal about the character or situation? "What have you done, my lord, with the dead body?" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene II, paragraph 7) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: the courtiers serve the king. The words its wording are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 32 reveal about the character or situation? “Follow him at foot; tempt him with speed aboard; Delay it not; I’ll have him hence to-night: Away! for every thing is seal’d and done That else leans on the affair: pray you, make haste.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 32) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: kings and beggars. The words “aboard” and “affair” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act IV, Scene III?
    A. “But indeed, if you find him not within this month, you shall nose him as you go up the stairs into the lobby.”
    B. “A man may fish with the worm that hath eat of a king, and eat of the fish that hath fed of that worm.”
    C. “In heaven; send hither to see: if your messenger find him not there, seek him i’ the other place yourself.”
    D. “Hamlet, this deed, for thine especial safety— Which we do tender, as we dearly grieve For that which thou hast done—must send thee hence…”

    Key: B (“A man may fish with the worm that hath eat of a king, and eat of the fish that hath fed of that worm.”)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What makes Fortinbras a foil?
    Sample answer: He acts decisively: Hamlet's self-reproach. The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet resolves.
    A. Revenge and justice
    B. Death and mortality
    C. Appearance and reality
    D. Action and delay

    Key: D (Action and delay)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene IV”? Fortinbras as foil.
    A. Diction / vocabulary
    B. Allusion
    C. Hyperbole
    D. Characterization

    Key: D (Characterization)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 21 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “In heaven; send hither to see: if your messenger find him not there, seek him i’ the other place yourself.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 21) develops appearance and reality: kings and beggars. Its words “messenger” and “yourself” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Hamlet, this deed, for thine especial safety— Which we do tender, as we dearly grieve For that which thou hast…” (Act IV, Scene III, paragraph 24), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 3: "Go, captain, from me greet the Danish king; Tell him that, by his license, Fortinbras Craves the _____ of a promised march Over his kingdom." Word bank: defend, addition, conveyance, invisible

    Key: conveyance

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose army passes?

    A. England's

    B. Fortinbras's

    C. Claudius's

    D. Laertes's

    Key: B (Fortinbras's)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 20? "Witness this army of such mass and charge Led by a delicate and tender prince, Whose spirit with divine ambition puff'd Makes mouths at the _____ event, Exposing what is mortal and unsure To all that fortune, death and danger dare, Even for an egg-shell."

    A. conveyance

    B. invisible

    C. addition

    D. defend

    Key: B (invisible)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet vow?

    A. Bloody thoughts

    B. To confess

    C. Peace

    D. To flee

    Key: A (Bloody thoughts)

21. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How many men will die?

    Sample answer: Twenty thousand.

22. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene IV"?

    A. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    B. The Ghost's revelation

    C. Fortinbras's army

    D. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

    Key: C (Fortinbras's army)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 14 shapes its tone: "To pay five ducats, five, I would not farm it; Nor will it yield to Norway or the Pole A ranker rate, should it be sold in fee." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "should" and "ranker" (Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 14) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) supports it: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!". But “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) complicates it: the line (Resolve) shows the same issue from another side, and its “nothing” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. A fair verdict is that the claim is mostly right but overstated; it needs a limiting clause to cover that passage.

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.”, what does “imposthume” most nearly mean?

    A. prohibition; ban (on playing)

    B. an abscess; internal swelling

    C. placed in a coffin

    D. last night

    Key: B (an abscess; internal swelling)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter’d, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say…”, what does “oblivion” most nearly mean?

    A. conflict; distress

    B. seize and hold

    C. forgetfulness

    D. image; likeness

    Key: C (forgetfulness)

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!". The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's self-reproach. This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Fortinbras's war admirable or absurd?

    Sample answer: A judgment: Greatness. The evidence is “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!".

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach. The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The words “occasions” and “against” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!".

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from Act II, Scene II to Act IV, Scene IV. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act II, Scene II, Polonius, the text reads “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” — Polonius's aside. In Act IV, Scene IV, “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's self-reproach. Hamlet resolves.
31. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach. The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves.
32. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Greatness. The evidence is “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves.
33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene IV”? Soliloquy: ‘How all occasions do inform against me.’
    A. Point of view
    B. Hyperbole
    C. Structure
    D. Metaphor

    Key: C (Structure)
34. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Analyze the word choice in “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Resolve. The evidence is “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The words “thoughts” and “nothing” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.
35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Greatness. The evidence is “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The words “argument” and “without” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 18, 6, 8, 19, 4, 20, 9, 21, 12, 11, 22, 13, 23, 14, 24	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 2, 4, 8, 7, 25, 26, 10, 11, 12, 13, 27, 14, 23, 24, 28	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	2, 17, 18, 21, 5, 25, 4, 10, 12, 11, 13, 15, 23, 14, 29, 24	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 21, 19, 5, 9, 10, 12, 11, 22, 13, 23, 27, 14, 16, 28, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 3

AP	20, 4, 3, 10, 11, 12, 13, 31, 32, 33, 23, 14, 16, 28, 30, 24	recall 3, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 3, 6, 10, 12, 22, 13, 27, 34, 23, 14, 16, 28, 24, 35, 30	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	17, 4, 6, 10, 11, 12, 13, 22, 23, 27, 14, 16, 35, 24, 30, 28	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 5
College Junior	4, 3, 26, 10, 11, 12, 13, 31, 22, 34, 23, 14, 16, 28, 24, 30	recall 3, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 4
College Senior	2, 25, 3, 10, 11, 12, 13, 22, 27, 14, 23, 34, 16, 24, 30, 28	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 3, 25, 10, 12, 11, 13, 33, 14, 23, 27, 16, 30, 24, 28, 35	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show Fortinbras's army? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Fortinbras's army? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene IV suggests about Fortinbras's army. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act IV, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Fortinbras's army responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Fortinbras's army follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene IV and its treatment of Fortinbras's army. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Fortinbras's army in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Fortinbras's army. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “imposthume” most nearly mean?

   A. an abscess; internal swelling

   B. imagination; a figment

   C. power; capacity

   D. a border region

2. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies. I humbly thank you, sir.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene IV”?

   A. Hamlet hides the body

   B. Fortinbras's army

   C. The Ghost's revelation

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. A (an abscess; internal swelling); 2. B (Fortinbras's army)

Lesson 18: Act IV, Scene V

Focus: Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Act IV, Scene V" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (mental illness, sexual content in songs): Ophelia's madness includes bawdy songs. Present her grief with care and discuss how the court responds to her.
Student preview: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Suggested language: "What do the people around Ophelia do, or fail to do?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.

Background: Flowers carried symbolic meanings.

Significance: Laertes foils Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do people show grief? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Prompt: How do people show grief?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes acts at once.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: juggled — tricked; deceived; cuckold — a man whose wife is unfaithful; hatchment — a coat of arms displayed at a funeral; pelican — a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood; rosemary — an herb symbolizing remembrance. "rosemary": Origin: Middle English rosmarine; earlier Old French rosmarin.
Words: juggled: tricked; deceived · cuckold: a man whose wife is unfaithful · hatchment: a coat of arms displayed at a funeral · pelican: a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood · rosemary: an herb symbolizing remembrance

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Flowers carried symbolic meanings. Laertes foils Hamlet. Characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Plot: Laertes demands revenge. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to" (Act IV, Scene V, Queen).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" slowly and put it in my own words: In her madness, Ophelia hands out flowers, giving rosemary for remembrance. Next, craft. I notice the gentle, song-like speech that hides deep grief. The strongest word is "remembrance": it names memory, which haunts her after her father's death. Then, effect. What does Ophelia's flower speech show? My answer: Ophelia's madness shows the cost of the court's violence; each flower carries a meaning, so her broken speech still speaks truth about loss and betrayal.

> *There's rosemary, that's for remembrance* (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" slowly and put it in my own words: In her madness, Ophelia hands out flowers, giving rosemary for remembrance. Next, craft. I notice the gentle, song-like speech that hides deep grief. The strongest word is "remembrance": it names memory, which haunts her after her father's death. Then, effect. What does Ophelia's flower speech show? My answer: Ophelia's madness shows the cost of the court's violence; each flower carries a meaning, so her broken speech still speaks truth about loss and betrayal.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

> *To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil* (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do people show grief? Compare Laertes and Hamlet.
Anchor question: How do people show grief?
Facilitation: Compare Laertes and Hamlet.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. (“To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil”, Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. (“To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil”, Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Key takeaway: Laertes acts at once.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.
- **Symbolism:** Ophelia's flowers.
- **Plot:** Laertes demands revenge.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes acts at once.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin’s true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to” (Act IV, Scene V, Queen).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “watch, I pray you. Exit Horatio. / O, this is the poison of deep grief; it springs / All from her father’s death. O” (Act IV, Scene V, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) Ophelia's flowers.
- “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) Laertes.
- “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King) Claudius.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.
Evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes)
Reasoning: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
juggled (verb)	tricked; deceived	*I’ll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!*	
cuckold (noun)	a man whose wife is unfaithful	*That drop of blood that’s calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.*	

hatchment (noun)	a coat of arms displayed at a funeral	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*	
pelican (noun)	a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood	*To his good friends thus wide I'll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.*	
rosemary (noun)	an herb symbolizing remembrance	*There's rosemary, that's for remembrance; pray, love, remember: and there is pansies, that's for thoughts.*	"rosemary": Origin: Middle English rosmarine; earlier Old French rosmarin. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/rosemary#Etymology)
riotous (adjective)	wild; rebellious	*Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers.*	"riotous": Origin: Anglo-Norman riotous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/riotous#Etymology)
battalions (noun)	armies; large groups	*O Gertrude, Gertrude, When sorrows come, they come not single spies, But in battalions.*	"battalions": Origin of "battalion": Middle French battaillon. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/battalion#Etymology)
columbines (noun)	flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity	*There's fennel for you, and columbines: there's rue for you; and here's some for me: we may call it herb-grace o' Sundays: O you must wear your rue with a difference.*	
ostentation (noun)	ceremony; show	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*	

Discussion questions

1. How do people show grief?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius say about sorrows? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They come in battalions.
2. What does Ophelia hand out? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Flowers
3. Who storms the castle? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes
4. What does rosemary mean? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Remembrance
5. Who calms Laertes? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
6. What do the people cry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes shall be king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!" What does "juggled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: juggled: tricked; deceived.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Ophelia go mad? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Father's death and Hamlet's rejection.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene V" suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Laertes foils Hamlet.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the symbolism in this scene shape what we understand about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O’erbears your officers.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene V”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene V” build on “Act IV, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “How do people show grief?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On plot: Laertes demands revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Compare Laertes and Hamlet. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Laertes foils Hamlet.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position

with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene V”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene V”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene V” treats Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle ·

wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene VI" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who storms the castle?

   A. Laertes
   B. Horatio
   C. Hamlet
   D. Fortinbras

   Key: A (Laertes)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!", what does "juggled" most nearly mean?

   A. indirect means
   B. tricked; deceived
   C. a border region
   D. a bird easily caught; a fool

   Key: B (tricked; deceived)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There's _____, that's for remembrance; pray, love, remember: and there is pansies, that's for thoughts." Word bank: rosemary, cuckold, juggled, hatchment
   Key: rosemary
4. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Claudius say about sorrows?
   Sample answer: They come in battalions.
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, Laertes: "To hell, _____! vows, to the blackest devil"
   Key: allegiance
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a _____ head, O'erbears your officers." Word bank: cuckold, juggled, hatchment, riotous
   Key: riotous
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "That drop of blood that's calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.", what does "cuckold" most nearly mean?
   A. boisterous; reeling
   B. serviceable; useful
   C. last night
   D. a man whose wife is unfaithful
   Key: D (a man whose wife is unfaithful)
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, King: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in _____"
   Key: battalions
9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O Gertrude, Gertrude, When sorrows come, they come not single spies, But in _____." Word bank: hatchment, juggled, cuckold, battalions
   Key: battalions
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Ophelia hand out?
    A. Coins
    B. Letters
    C. Flowers
    D. Rings
    Key: C (Flowers)
11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There's fennel for you, and _____: there's rue for you; and here's some for me: we may call it herb-grace o' Sundays: O you must wear your rue with a difference." Word bank: juggled, columbines, cuckold, hatchment
    Key: columbines
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's flowers. The evidence is "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene V"?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. Polonius spies on Laertes

    C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

    D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    Key: C (Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Ophelia go mad?
    Sample answer: Father's death and Hamlet's rejection: Ophelia's flowers. The evidence is "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Laertes acts at once.

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Death and mortality

    D. Action and delay

    Key: A (Revenge and justice)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from Act III, Scene III to Act IV, Scene V. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act III, Scene III, King, the text reads "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" — Claudius confesses. In Act IV, Scene V, "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) — Ophelia's flowers. Laertes acts at once.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60: "By heaven, thy _____ shall be paid by weight, Till our scale turn the beam." Word bank: departed, madness, importunate, swoopstake
    Key: madness

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What do the people cry?

    A. Long live Hamlet

    B. Peace

    C. Laertes shall be king

    D. Death to Claudius

    Key: C (Laertes shall be king)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "To his good friends thus wide I'll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.", what does "pelican" most nearly mean?

    A. without a body; imagined

    B. pressed with requests; courted

    C. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

    D. military; warlike

    Key: C (a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood)

20. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60 reveal about the character or situation? “O heat, dry up my brains! tears seven times salt, Burn out the sense and virtue of mine eye!” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words “virtue” and “brains” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 6 reveal about the character or situation? “She speaks much of her father; says she hears There’s tricks i’ the world; and hems, and beats her heart; Spurns enviously at straws; speaks things in doubt, That carry but half sense: her speech is nothing, Yet the unshaped use of it doth…” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 6) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words “collection” and “unhappily” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 25 shapes its tone: “Indeed, la, without an oath, I’ll make an end on’t: Sings.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “without” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 25) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 63 shapes its tone: “You must sing a-down a-down, An you call him a-down-a.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 63) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Compare Laertes and Hamlet.
    Sample answer: A judgment: Laertes. The evidence is “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.".
25. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44? “Tell me, Laertes, Why thou art thus _____.”

    A. counter
    B. incensed
    C. guiltless
    D. rebellion

    Key: B (incensed)
26. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 23? “Then up he rose, and donn’d his clothes, And dupp’d the chamber-door; Let in the maid, that out a maid Never _____ more.”

    A. madness
    B. departed

C. swoopstake

D. daughter

Key: B (departed)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral — No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o’er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as ’twere from heaven to earth, That I must call’t in…”, what does “hatchment” most nearly mean?

A. offers (of love)

B. burial cloths

C. a reply or answer

D. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

Key: D (a coat of arms displayed at a funeral)

28. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Laertes. The evidence is “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 19 shapes its tone: “Larded with sweet flowers; Which bewept to the grave did go With true-love showers.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “flowers” and “showers” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 19) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) supports it: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.". But “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King) complicates it: the line (Claudius) shows the same issue from another side, and its “not” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. The claim is therefore a strong reading, not a complete one, and a careful answer says where it stops applying.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Who calms Laertes?

A. Ophelia

B. Gertrude

C. Claudius

D. Polonius

Key: C (Claudius)

32. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 69 shapes its tone: “No, no, he is dead: Go to thy death-bed: He never will come again.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words its wording (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 69) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene V”? Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Hyperbole

    C. Characterization

    D. Alliteration

    Key: C (Characterization)

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Laertes. The evidence is “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words “allegiance” and “blackest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.".

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “My brother shall know of it: and so I thank you for your good counsel.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27) develops corruption and the state: Laertes acts at once. Its words “brother” and “counsel” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “How cheerfully on the false trail they cry!” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 34), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Let him go, Gertrude; do not fear our person: There’s such divinity doth hedge a king, That treason can but peep to what it would, Acts little of his will.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44) develops appearance and reality: Laertes acts at once. Its words “divinity” and “treason” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “My will, not all the world: And for my means, I’ll husband them so well, They shall go far with little.” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 51), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes).

    Sample answer: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.". The evidence is “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) — Laertes. This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Ophelia's flowers. The evidence is “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words “remembrance” and “rosemary” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.".

39. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King). Pick two words and explain what

they suggest.

Sample answer: Claudius. The evidence is "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words "battalions" and "sorrows" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

40. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] What does rosemary mean?

    A. Peace

    B. Hate

    C. Love

    D. Remembrance

    Key: D (Remembrance)

41. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27: "Good night, _____; good night, sweet ladies; good night, good night." Word bank: ladies, importunate, guiltless, counter

    Key: ladies

42. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 4: "She is _____, indeed distract: Her mood will needs be pitied." Word bank: daughter, importunate, incensed, patient

    Key: importunate

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 1, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 17, 18, 19, 3, 1, 4, 11, 20, 14, 13, 21, 22, 23, 15, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	25, 8, 5, 10, 26, 27, 2, 20, 21, 14, 28, 22, 15, 29, 24, 30	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	25, 18, 31, 10, 7, 5, 9, 14, 20, 21, 22, 15, 32, 33, 34, 35	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	10, 31, 5, 3, 1, 20, 12, 21, 14, 15, 23, 22, 29, 35, 36, 30	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 5, 9, 1, 14, 21, 13, 37, 23, 32, 29, 15, 24, 16, 35, 30	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 27, 18, 6, 14, 20, 33, 32, 23, 15, 22, 38, 24, 35, 16, 36	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	18, 27, 3, 6, 14, 15, 33, 22, 39, 29, 16, 35, 24, 36, 38, 34	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Junior	2, 40, 3, 6, 10, 15, 22, 32, 29, 39, 23, 35, 30, 16, 36, 24	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Senior	41, 3, 10, 1, 40, 23, 15, 29, 32, 36, 24, 30, 16, 34, 38, 35	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 4, synthesis 7
Graduate / PhD	42, 3, 10, 1, 15, 32, 33, 29, 39, 22, 16, 38, 36, 35, 30, 24	recall 4, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene V," how does Shakespeare show Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene V suggests about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene V and its treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Position

your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "hatchment" most nearly mean?

   A. flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity

   B. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

   C. ceremony; show

   D. armies; large groups

2. *Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers. The rabble call him lord; And, as the world were now but to begin, Antiquity forgot, custom not known, The ratifiers and props of every word, They cry "Choose we: Laertes shall be king:" Caps, hands, and tongues, applaud it to the clouds: "Laertes shall be king, Laertes king!"*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene V"?

   A. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   C. The graveyard

   D. The plot against Hamlet

SAT key: 1. B (a coat of arms displayed at a funeral); 2. A (Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return)

Lesson 19: Act IV, Scene VI

Focus: Hamlet's letter from the sea

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act IV, Scene VI” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.

Background: Piracy was common.

Significance: Chance returns Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What role does luck play? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: What role does luck play?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Four key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: boarded — forced their way onto (a ship); overlooked — read through (a letter); grapple — seize and hold; appointment — equipment and arming (of a ship).
Words: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship) · overlooked: read through (a letter) · grapple: seize and hold · appointment: equipment and arming (of a ship)

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Piracy was common. Chance returns Hamlet. Plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" slowly and put it in my own words: Horatio reads Hamlet's letter saying a pirate ship attacked them two days into the voyage. Next, craft. I notice the quick, adventurous tone of the letter. The strongest word is "pirate": it introduces chance as the force that saves Hamlet. Then, effect. What does Horatio's account reveal? My answer: Horatio's account reveals that Hamlet escaped the ship to England with the pirates' help and is returning; Hamlet's escape shows fate working for him and brings him back for the final confrontation.

> *Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" slowly and put it in my own words: Horatio reads Hamlet's letter saying a pirate ship attacked them two days into the voyage. Next, craft. I notice the quick, adventurous tone of the letter. The strongest word is "pirate": it introduces chance as the force that saves Hamlet. Then, effect. What does Horatio's account reveal? My answer: Horatio's account reveals that Hamlet escaped the ship to England with the pirates' help and is returning; Hamlet's escape shows fate working for him and brings him back for the final confrontation.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends." Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

> *They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends."
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What role does luck play? Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?
Anchor question: What role does luck play?
Facilitation: Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how plot shapes Hamlet's letter from the sea. Key takeaway: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court.
- **Structure:** The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “to me with as much speed as thou wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) The pirate attack.
- “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.
- “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence.
Evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)
Reasoning: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
boarded (verb)	forced their way onto (a ship)	*Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*	
overlooked (verb)	read through (a letter)	*"Horatio, when thou shalt have overlooked this, give these fellows some means to the king: they have letters for him.*	
grapple (verb)	seize and hold	*Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*	
appointment (noun)	equipment and arming (of a ship)	*Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase.*	

Discussion questions

1. What role does luck play?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many days at sea? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two.
2. Who brings the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sailors
3. Who attacked Hamlet's ship? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Pirates
4. How did pirates treat Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Like thieves of mercy
5. Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: England
6. Who receives the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VI" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's

ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.

8. Who is on stage in “Act IV, Scene VI”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act IV, Scene VI” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.” What does “boarded” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship).

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's return important? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He comes back to complete revenge.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene VI” suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Chance returns Hamlet.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “He shall, sir, an’t please him.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VI”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VI” build on “Act IV, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What role does luck play?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is the pirate episode convincing? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Chance returns Hamlet.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet

acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VI”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet's letter from the sea. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VI”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VI” treats Hamlet's letter from the sea with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene VII" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: "They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How many days at sea?

   Sample answer: Two.
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I _____ them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner." Word bank: overlooked, boarded, grapple, appointment

   Key: boarded
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who brings the letter?

   A. Sailors

   B. Rosencrantz

   C. A messenger

   D. Osric

   Key: A (Sailors)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who receives the letter?

   A. Horatio

   B. Gertrude

   C. Laertes

   D. Claudius

Key: A (Horatio)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio: "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike _____ gave us chase"
   Key: appointment
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Horatio, when thou shalt have _____ this, give these fellows some means to the king: they have letters for him."
   Word bank: grapple, appointment, overlooked, boarded
   Key: overlooked
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio: "They have dealt with me like _____ of mercy"
   Key: thieves
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go?
   A. Norway
   B. England
   C. Denmark
   D. Poland

   Key: B (England)
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who attacked Hamlet's ship?
   A. English soldiers
   B. Norwegians
   C. Danes
   D. Pirates

   Key: D (Pirates)
10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How did pirates treat Hamlet?
    A. Like thieves of mercy
    B. Cruelly
    C. As a slave
    D. As a king

    Key: A (Like thieves of mercy)
11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why is Hamlet's return important?
    Sample answer: He comes back to complete revenge. The evidence is "I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
12. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. The evidence is "I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. The words "thine" and "speak" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.
13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.
    A. Appearance and reality

B. Action and delay

C. Death and mortality

D. Corruption and the state

Key: B (Action and delay)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act IV, Scene VI"? Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ('I alone became their prisoner'), the decisiveness he lacked at court.

A. Irony

B. Personification

C. Characterization

D. Symbolism

Key: C (Characterization)

15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is the pirate episode convincing?

Sample answer: A judgment: the pirate attack. The evidence is "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.".

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from Act IV, Scene IV to Act IV, Scene VI. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet, the text reads "How all occasions do inform against me" — Hamlet's self-reproach. In Act IV, Scene VI, "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — The pirate attack. Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

17. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VI"?

A. The court of Denmark

B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

C. Polonius spies on Laertes

D. The Mousetrap

Key: B (Hamlet's letter from the sea)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60: "By heaven, thy _____ shall be paid by weight, Till our scale turn the beam." Word bank: departed, madness, importunate, swoopstake

Key: madness

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 23? "Then up he rose, and donn'd his clothes, And dupp'd the chamber-door; Let in the maid, that out a maid Never _____ more."

A. madness

B. departed

C. swoopstake

D. daughter

Key: B (departed)

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27: "Good night, _____; good night, sweet ladies; good night, good night." Word bank: ladies, importunate, guiltless, counter

    Key: ladies

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44? "Tell me, Laertes, Why thou art thus _____."

    A. counter
    B. incensed
    C. guiltless
    D. rebellion

    Key: B (incensed)

22. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 3 reveal about the character or situation? "If that his majesty would aught with us, We shall express our duty in his eye; And let him know so." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 3) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet resolves. The words "express" and "majesty" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

23. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 6 reveal about the character or situation? "She speaks much of her father; says she hears There's tricks i' the world; and hems, and beats her heart; Spurns enviously at straws; speaks things in doubt, That carry but half sense: her speech is nothing, Yet the unshaped use of it doth…" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 6) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words "collection" and "unhappily" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

24. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60 reveal about the character or situation? "O heat, dry up my brains! tears seven times salt, Burn out the sense and virtue of mine eye!" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 60) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words "virtue" and "brains" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in Act IV, Scene VI?

    A. "There's a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is."
    B. "I do not know from what part of the world I should be greeted, if not from Lord Hamlet."
    C. "What are they that would speak with me?"
    D. "Sailors, sir: they say they have letters for you."

    Key: C ("What are they that would speak with me?")

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 69 shapes its tone: "No, no, he is dead: Go to thy death-bed: He never will come again." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 69) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 25 shapes its tone: “Indeed, la, without an oath, I’ll make an end on’t: Sings.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “without” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 25) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Let him go, Gertrude; do not fear our person: There’s such divinity doth hedge a king, That treason can but peep to what it would, Acts little of his will.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 44) develops appearance and reality: Laertes acts at once. Its words “divinity” and “treason” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “My will, not all the world: And for my means, I’ll husband them so well, They shall go far with little.” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 51), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 4: “She is _____, indeed distract: Her mood will needs be pitied.” Word bank: daughter, importunate, incensed, patient
    Key: importunate

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “My brother shall know of it: and so I thank you for your good counsel.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 27) develops corruption and the state: Laertes acts at once. Its words “brother” and “counsel” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “How cheerfully on the false trail they cry!” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 34), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, paragraph 15: “Why, then the Polack never will _____ it.” Word bank: invisible, addition, defend, conveyance
    Key: defend

32. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 19 shapes its tone: “Larded with sweet flowers; Which bewept to the grave did go With true-love showers.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “flowers” and “showers” (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 19) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 63 shapes its tone: “You must sing a-down a-down, An you call him a-down-a.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act IV, Scene V, paragraph 63) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes acts at once. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

34. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “I have words to speak in thine

ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

Sample answer: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.". The evidence is “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene VI, paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “These good fellows will bring thee where I am.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene VI, paragraph 10) develops appearance and reality: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Its words “fellows” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Sailors, sir: they say they have letters for you.” (Act IV, Scene VI, paragraph 4), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

36. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.

    C. Another prince who has lost a father.

    D. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    Key: B (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

37. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VI”? Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.

    A. Plot

    B. Symbolism

    C. Personification

    D. Setting

    Key: A (Plot)

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The pirate attack. The evidence is “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. The words “appointment” and “warlike” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.".

39. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. The evidence is “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. The words “thieves” and “dealt” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing

either would soften the effect. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 1, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	6, 3, 5, 4, 2, 7, 1, 10, 8, 9, 17, 11, 13, 12, 16, 15	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 2
HS Sophomore	18, 19, 20, 21, 7, 5, 22, 23, 24, 11, 25, 26, 27, 13, 28, 15	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	29, 21, 7, 6, 5, 22, 23, 24, 25, 11, 26, 27, 14, 13, 30, 15	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	31, 18, 10, 7, 22, 24, 25, 11, 17, 26, 32, 12, 13, 28, 15, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 2, 9, 6, 3, 8, 22, 26, 32, 27, 33, 34, 30, 28, 35, 15	recall 6, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	21, 2, 6, 22, 36, 25, 11, 33, 32, 27, 37, 12, 30, 28, 15, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	2, 3, 6, 22, 24, 25, 33, 27, 13, 12, 37, 30, 35, 38, 39, 15	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 10, 6, 3, 25, 33, 32, 27, 26, 34, 13, 30, 28, 35, 16, 15	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Senior	31, 21, 6, 25, 17, 26, 33, 32, 27, 12, 13, 30, 28, 16, 15, 35	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	29, 2, 3, 22, 25, 27, 32, 26, 13, 34, 37, 30, 28, 15, 16, 35	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene VI,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet's letter from the sea? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VI, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VI (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VI suggests about Hamlet's letter from the sea. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VI to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene VI within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene VI alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet's letter from the sea follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VI and its treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet's letter from the sea in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “boarded” most nearly mean?

   A. equipment and arming (of a ship)

   B. forced their way onto (a ship)

   C. read through (a letter)

   D. seize and hold

2. *He shall, sir, an't please him. There's a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VI"?

A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

B. The Mousetrap

C. Worms and kings

D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

SAT key: 1. B (forced their way onto (a ship)); 2. D (Hamlet's letter from the sea)

Lesson 20: Act IV, Scene VII

Focus: the plot against Hamlet

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in "Act IV, Scene VII" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (suicide (implied), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Gertrude reports Ophelia's drowning; whether it was suicide is debated later. Use the safe-messaging script. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…s more violent to that end— And that he calls for drink, I'll have prepared him A chalice for t…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does Gertrude describe the death so gently?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.

Background: Fencing was an aristocratic sport.

Significance: The trap is set.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
When does revenge become crime? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: When does revenge become crime?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: conjunctive — closely united; acquittance — release; acquittal; envenom — poison; perfections — excellent qualities; challenger — one who challenges others. “conjunctive”: Origin: Latin coniunctivus (“serving to connect”). “envenom”: Origin: Old French envenimer (“to poison”).
Words: conjunctive: closely united · acquittance: release; acquittal · envenom: poison · perfections: excellent qualities · challenger: one who challenges others

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fencing was an aristocratic sport. The trap is set. Plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” slowly and put it in my own words: Laertes agrees to Claudius's plan and adds that he will poison his sword. Next, craft. I notice he goes beyond Claudius's plan, adding his own treachery. The strongest word is “anoint”: it is a holy word for applying oil, here used for poison. Then, effect. What does Laertes agree to do? My answer: Laertes agrees to kill Hamlet in a fencing match with an unblunted, poisoned sword; his grief turns him into a schemer, and the plot sets up the deaths of Hamlet, Laertes, Gertrude and Claudius.

> *I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword* (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” slowly and put it in my own words: Laertes agrees to Claudius's plan and adds that he will poison his sword. Next, craft. I notice he goes beyond Claudius's plan, adding his own treachery. The strongest word is “anoint”: it is a holy word for applying oil, here used for poison. Then, effect. What does Laertes agree to do? My answer: Laertes agrees to kill Hamlet in a fencing match with an unblunted, poisoned sword; his grief turns him into a schemer, and the plot sets up the deaths of Hamlet, Laertes, Gertrude and Claudius.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

> *To cut his throat i' the church (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: When does revenge become crime? Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.
Anchor question: When does revenge become crime?
Facilitation: Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the plot against Hamlet. Key takeaway: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.
- **Characterization:** Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.
- **Imagery:** Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “for friend, / Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, / That he which hath your noble father slain / Pursued my life” (Act IV, Scene VII, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "To cut his throat i' the church" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
- "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Laertes adds poison to the plan.
- "There is a willow grows aslant a brook" (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen) Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits.
Evidence: "There is a willow grows aslant a brook" (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen)
Reasoning: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
conjunctive (adjective)	closely united	*The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*	"conjunctive": Origin: Latin coniunctivus ("serving to connect"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/conjunctive#Etymology)
acquittance (noun)	release; acquittal	*Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.*	
envenom (verb)	poison	*Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o'er, to play with him.*	"envenom": Origin: Old French envenimer ("to poison"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/envenom#Etymology)
perfections (noun)	excellent qualities	*And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood challenger on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.*	
challenger (noun)	one who challenges others	*And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood*	

		challenger on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.	

Discussion questions

1. When does revenge become crime?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where would Laertes cut Hamlet's throat? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In the church.
2. What will Laertes's sword have? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poison on an unblunted tip
3. What is the backup plan? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A poisoned cup
4. How does Ophelia die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Drowning
5. Who reports her death? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
6. Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude and the people love him
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VII" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene VII", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene VII" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her." What does "conjunctive" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: conjunctive: closely united.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Laertes add poison? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He bought an unction from a mountebank.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene VII” suggest about the plot against Hamlet? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The trap is set.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew’d, But yet to me they are strong.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VII”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VII” build on “Act IV, Scene VI”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “When does revenge become crime?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

10. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Laertes more honourable than Hamlet? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The trap is set.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VII”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the plot against Hamlet. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VII”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1,

RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. On plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VII” treats the plot against Hamlet with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII,

Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes: “I will do’t: / And, for that _____, I’ll anoint my sword”

   Key: purpose

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is the backup plan?

   A. An ambush

   B. A false letter

   C. A poisoned cup

   D. A second sword

   Key: C (A poisoned cup)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What will Laertes's sword have?

   A. Poison on an unblunted tip

   B. Nothing special

   C. A jewel

   D. A curse

   Key: A (Poison on an unblunted tip)

4. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where would Laertes cut Hamlet's throat?

   Sample answer: In the church.

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o’er, to play with him.”, what does “envenom” most nearly mean?

   A. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang

   B. magic; here, seductive power

   C. poison

   D. military; warlike

   Key: C (poison)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Queen: “There is a _____ grows aslant a brook”

   Key: willow

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood

_____ on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come." Word bank: challenger, envenom, acquittance, conjunctive

Key: challenger

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Ophelia die?

   A. Drowning

   B. Poison

   C. Fever

   D. A fall

   Key: A (Drowning)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes: "To cut his _____ i' the church"

   Key: throat

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.", what does "acquittance" most nearly mean?

    A. release; acquittal

    B. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

    C. ministers; preachers

    D. curse (a mild oath)

    Key: A (release; acquittal)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.", what does "conjunctive" most nearly mean?

    A. closely united

    B. boisterous; reeling

    C. like a pig; gross

    D. ready and armed for fighting

    Key: A (closely united)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Laertes add poison?

    Sample answer: He bought an unction from a mountebank. The evidence is "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) — Laertes adds poison to the plan.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "To cut his throat i' the church" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. The evidence is "To cut his throat i' the church" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Laertes would 'cut his throat i' the church'; Claudius says revenge 'should have no bounds.'

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Action and delay

D. Death and mortality

Key: A (Revenge and justice)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. The evidence is “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “aslant” and “willow” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Laertes more honourable than Hamlet?
Sample answer: A judgment: Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. The evidence is “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet?
A. He forgot
B. He liked Hamlet
C. Gertrude and the people love him
D. He feared Laertes

Key: C (Gertrude and the people love him)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who reports her death?
A. Laertes
B. Gertrude
C. Horatio
D. Claudius

Key: B (Gertrude)

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.
A. Personification
B. Setting
C. Alliteration
D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from Act IV, Scene V to Act IV, Scene VII. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia, the text reads “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” — Ophelia's flowers. In Act IV, Scene VII, “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) — Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 35? “But, good Laertes, Will you do this, keep close within your _____.”
A. another
B. chamber

C. follow

D. graveness

Key: B (chamber)

22. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 4: “It well appears: but tell me Why you _____ not against these feats, So crimeful and so capital in nature, As by your safety, wisdom, all things else, You mainly were stirr’d up.” Word bank: proceeded, undertake, errule, thereunto

Key: proceeded

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 13? “To-morrow shall I beg leave to see your kingly eyes: when I shall, first asking your pardon _____, recount the occasion of my sudden and more strange return.”

A. shortly

B. proceeded

C. thereunto

D. chamber

Key: C (thereunto)

24. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 37 reveal about the character or situation? “Soft! let me see: We’ll make a solemn wager on your cunnings: I ha’t.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 37) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “cunnings” and “solemn” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

25. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 7 reveal about the character or situation? “Break not your sleeps for that: you must not think That we are made of stuff so flat and dull That we can let our beard be shook with danger And think it pastime.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 7) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “pastime” and “sleeps” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen).

Sample answer: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury. The evidence is “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen) — Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 20 shapes its tone: “My lord, I will be ruled; The rather, if you could devise it so That I might be the organ.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “devise” and “rather” (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 20) make the tone heavy and deliberate

rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 46 shapes its tone: “Let’s follow, Gertrude: How much I had to do to calm his rage!” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “follow” (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 46) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 35 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Hamlet return’d shall know you are come home: We’ll put on those shall praise your excellence And set a double varnish on the fame The Frenchman gave you, bring you in fine together And wager on your heads: he, being remiss, Most generous…” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 35) develops appearance and reality: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". Its words “excellence” and “contriving” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “No place, indeed, should murder sanctuarize; Revenge should have no bounds.” (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 35), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 28 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “I know him well: he is the brooch indeed And gem of all the nation.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 28) develops corruption and the state: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". Its words “brooch” and “nation” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Not that I think you did not love your father; But that I know love is begun by time; And that I see, in passages of…” (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 33), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 23: “A very riband in the cap of youth, Yet needful too; for youth no less becomes The light and careless livery that it wears Than settled age his sables and his weeds, Importing health and _____.” Word bank: graveness, follow, sickness, thereunto

    Key: graveness

32. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Claudius and Laertes this device a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Plot

    C. Simile

    D. Irony

    Key: B (Plot)

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 13 shapes its tone: “Or is it some abuse, and no such thing?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 13) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

34. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene VII”?
    A. The Mousetrap
    B. Hamlet hides the body
    C. The plot against Hamlet
    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    Key: C (The plot against Hamlet)

35. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, paragraph 46: “Now fear I this will give it start again; Therefore let’s _____.” Word bank: sickness, received, chamber, follow

    Key: follow

36. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen)
    A. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
    B. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").
    C. Acceptance before the duel.
    D. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

    Key: D (Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.)

37. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. The evidence is “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “church” and “throat” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

38. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] What does this passage most clearly show? “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)
    A. Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
    B. Death levels the mighty.
    C. Gertrude on the Player Queen.
    D. Acceptance before the duel.

    Key: A (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 11, 17, 2, 10, 6, 8, 18, 9, 3, 12, 13, 15, 14, 19, 20	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1

HS Sophomore	21, 6, 9, 4, 5, 22, 23, 17, 12, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	23, 31, 18, 22, 8, 17, 4, 24, 25, 12, 32, 27, 28, 33, 16, 30	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 9, 8, 18, 24, 13, 12, 25, 34, 14, 28, 27, 33, 16, 29, 20	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 17, 35, 24, 12, 13, 36, 27, 19, 14, 28, 33, 29, 16, 30, 20	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	17, 5, 2, 9, 1, 13, 24, 33, 14, 26, 27, 28, 29, 16, 20, 30	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 22, 9, 3, 12, 15, 14, 32, 27, 28, 33, 30, 20, 37, 29, 16	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Junior	8, 7, 9, 3, 12, 25, 28, 15, 33, 14, 19, 27, 29, 30, 16, 20	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 4
College Senior	2, 9, 1, 10, 25, 15, 14, 32, 27, 33, 28, 16, 30, 20, 37, 29	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	9, 1, 38, 24, 12, 36, 25, 32, 14, 28, 27, 33, 29, 20, 30, 16	recall 2, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene VII,” how does Shakespeare show the plot against Hamlet? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VII, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the plot against Hamlet? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VII (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VII suggests about the plot against Hamlet. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VII to complicate the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene VII within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the plot against Hamlet responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene VII alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the plot against Hamlet follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VII and its treatment of the plot against Hamlet. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as evidence for a larger claim about the plot against Hamlet in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the plot against Hamlet. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which — She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "conjunctive" most nearly mean?

   A. poison

   B. one who challenges others

   C. excellent qualities

   D. closely united

2. *O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew'd, But yet to me they are strong. The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which — She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her. The other motive, Why to a public count I might not go, Is the great love the general gender bear him; Who, dipping all his faults in their affection, Would, like the spring that turneth wood to stone, Convert his gyves to graces; so that my arrows, Too slightly timber'd for so loud a wind, Would have reverted to my bow again, And not where I had aim'd them.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VII"?

   A. The plot against Hamlet

B. The graveyard

C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

D. The Mousetrap

SAT key: 1. D (closely united); 2. A (The plot against Hamlet)

Lesson 21: Act V, Scene I

Focus: the graveyard

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act V, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “_Hamlet_ is singular in its kind: a tragedy of thought inspired by continual and never-satisfied meditation on human destiny and the dark perplexity of the events of this world, and calculated to call forth the very same meditation in the minds of the spectators.” (August Wilhelm Schlegel, critic and translator of Shakespeare, *Lectures on Dramatic Art and Literature (1809-11), trans. John Black, Lecture XXV, Lecture XXV*; public domain). Response journal: after Yorick, what "meditation on human destiny" does the scene call forth in you? *Objective:* Determine how the graveyard scene develops the theme of death and mortality. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.2

Content note (suicide (discussed), human remains, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Gravediggers debate whether Ophelia took her own life; skulls are handled. Use the safe-messaging script; keep focus on mortality and on how the Church and court treat her. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…day. Go, get thee to Yaughan: fetch me a stoup of liquor. Exit Second Clown. He digs and sings…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What does the debate over her burial show about this society?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.

Background: Suicides were denied full Christian burial.

Significance: Hamlet's view of death matures.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death mean to you? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What does death mean to you?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: outface — outdo; defy; equivocation — ambiguity; word-play; shipwright — a builder of ships; conveyances — deeds transferring property; crowner — coroner. "equivocation": Origin: Old French equivocation; earlier Late Latin aequivocus ("ambiguous"). "shipwright": Origin: an English formation from ship + wright. "conveyances": Origin of "conveyance": an English formation from convey + -ance.
Words: outface: outdo; defy · equivocation: ambiguity; word-play · shipwright: a builder of ships · conveyances: deeds transferring property · crowner: coroner

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicides were denied full Christian burial. Hamlet's view of death matures. Characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "I' faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will" (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" slowly and put it in my own words: Holding the skull of the old jester Yorick, Hamlet says he knew him. Next, craft. I notice the shift from casual talk to personal memory. The strongest word is "Yorick": it is a name, which turns an anonymous skull into a beloved person. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull show? My answer: Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull shows him facing death directly: even the jester who carried him as a child is reduced to bones, and the scene deepens Hamlet's acceptance of mortality.

> *Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" slowly and put it in my own words: Holding the skull of the old jester Yorick, Hamlet says he knew him. Next, craft. I notice the shift from casual talk to personal memory. The strongest word is "Yorick": it is a name, which turns an anonymous skull into a beloved person. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull show? My answer: Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull shows him facing death directly: even the jester who carried him as a child is reduced to bones, and the scene deepens Hamlet's acceptance of mortality.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

> *Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does death mean to you? Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?
Anchor question: What does death mean to you?
Facilitation: Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the graveyard. Key takeaway: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.
- **Plot:** Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “I’ faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “the point: if I drown myself wittingly, it argues an act: and an act hath three branches; it is, to act, to” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.
- “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Death levels the mighty.
- “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet's claim at the grave.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

> **Claim:** The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone.
> **Evidence:** “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)
> **Reasoning:** Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
outface (verb)	outdo; defy	*To outface me with leaping in her grave?*	
equivocation (noun)	ambiguity; word-play	*How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.*	"equivocation": Origin: Old French equivocation; earlier Late Latin aequivocus ("ambiguous"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/equivocation#Etymology)
shipwright (noun)	a builder of ships	*What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?*	"shipwright": Origin: an English formation from ship + wright. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/shipwright#Etymology)
conveyances (noun)	deeds transferring property	*The very conveyances of his lands will hardly lie in this box; and must the inheritor himself have no more, ha?*	"conveyances": Origin of "conveyance": an English formation from convey + -ance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/conveyance#Etymology)
crowner (noun)	coroner	*I tell thee she is: and therefore make her grave straight: the crowner hath sat on her, and finds it Christian burial.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does death mean to you?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How long has the gravedigger worked? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Since the day Hamlet was born, thirty years.
2. Whose skull does Hamlet hold? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Yorick's
3. Who was Yorick? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king's jester
4. Whose grave is being dug? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Ophelia's

5. Who leaps into the grave? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes and Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet say of Caesar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Turned to clay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To outface me with leaping in her grave?" What does "outface" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: outface: outdo; defy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does the priest limit the rites? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Her death was doubtful.
2. What does "Act V, Scene I" suggest about the graveyard? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's view of death matures.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the graveyard? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "How absolute the knave is!", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act V, Scene I", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
7. How does "Act V, Scene I" build on "Act IV, Scene VII"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "What does death mean to you?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's grief sincere? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: "Hamlet's view of death matures." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and

evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act V, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the graveyard. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act V, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act V, Scene I” treats the graveyard with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and

universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the graveyard? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, Hamlet: “I loved Ophelia: forty _____ brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum”
   Key: thousand

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.”, what does “equivocation” most nearly mean?

   A. ambiguity; word-play

   B. a border region

   C. excellent qualities

   D. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

   Key: A (ambiguity; word-play)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?”, what does “shipwright” most nearly mean?

   A. a builder of ships

   B. not yet having feathers; immature

C. chattering

D. cleansing; also medical purging

Key: A (a builder of ships)

4. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How long has the gravedigger worked?
   Sample answer: Since the day Hamlet was born, thirty years.

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "The very conveyances of his lands will hardly lie in this box; and must the inheritor himself have no more, ha?", what does "conveyances" most nearly mean?

   A. deeds transferring property

   B. remedy

   C. graft onto

   D. quickness; speed

   Key: A (deeds transferring property)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who leaps into the grave?

   A. Only Horatio

   B. Claudius

   C. Laertes and Hamlet

   D. Gertrude

   Key: C (Laertes and Hamlet)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say of Caesar?

   A. A hero

   B. A god

   C. A coward

   D. Turned to clay

   Key: D (Turned to clay)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I tell thee she is: and therefore make her grave straight: the _____ hath sat on her, and finds it Christian burial." Word bank: shipwright, equivocation, crowner, outface
   Key: crowner

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who was Yorick?

   A. The king's jester

   B. A priest

   C. A gravedigger

   D. A soldier

   Key: A (The king's jester)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose skull does Hamlet hold?

    A. Polonius's

    B. His father's

    C. Yorick's

    D. Caesar's

Key: C (Yorick's)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Death levels the mighty. The evidence is “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does the priest limit the rites?
Sample answer: Her death was doubtful: Death levels the mighty. The evidence is “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.
    A. Death and mortality
    B. Revenge and justice
    C. Appearance and reality
    D. Action and delay

    Key: A (Death and mortality)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene I”? The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.
    A. Simile
    B. Personification
    C. Characterization
    D. Allusion

    Key: C (Characterization)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet's grief sincere?
Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.".

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 3: “Is she to be buried in Christian burial that wilfully seeks her own _____?” Word bank: salvation, profession, methought, therefore
    Key: salvation

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 33? “That skull had a _____ in it, and could sing once: how the knave jowls it to the ground, as if it were Cain’s jaw-bone, that did the first murder!”
    A. profession
    B. shrouding
    C. tongue

D. therefore

Key: C (tongue)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose grave is being dug?

A. Polonius's

B. Gertrude's

C. Hamlet's

D. Ophelia's

Key: D (Ophelia's)

20. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 5 reveal about the character or situation? “How can that be, unless she drowned herself in her own defence?” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 5) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words “defence” and “drowned” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 59 reveal about the character or situation? “Ay, marry, why was he sent into England?” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 59) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words its wording are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene I”? Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.

A. Point of view

B. Irony

C. Setting

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 15 shapes its tone: “A’ was the first that ever bore arms.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words its wording (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 15) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act IV, Scene III to Act V, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet, the text reads “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” — Death levels all. In Act V, Scene I, “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 46: “You lie out on’t, sir, and _____ it is not yours: for my part, I do not lie in’t, and yet it is mine.” Word bank: profession, therefore, question, offendendo

Key: therefore

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act V, Scene I"?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. Polonius spies on Laertes

    C. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

    D. The graveyard

    Key: D (The graveyard)

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 28 shapes its tone: "Go, get thee to Yaughan: fetch me a stoup of liquor." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "liquor" (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 28) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's claim at the grave. The evidence is "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words "brothers" and "quantity" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 85 shapes its tone: "Why may not imagination trace the noble dust of Alexander, till he find it stopping a bung-hole?" Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "imagination" and "stopping" (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 85) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 96 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "Lay her i' the earth: And from her fair and unpolluted flesh May violets spring!" Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 96) develops corruption and the state: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Its words "unpolluted" and "violets" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "I hoped thou shouldst have been my Hamlet's wife; I thought thy bride-bed to have deck'd, sweet maid, And not have…" (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 98), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 13? "There is no ancient gentleman but gardeners, ditchers, and grave-makers: they hold up Adam's _____."

    A. methought

    B. question

    C. therefore

    D. profession

    Key: D (profession)

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “To outface me with leaping in her grave?”, what does “outface” most nearly mean?

    A. outdo; defy

    B. one who borrows

    C. a sport; diversion

    D. causing great pain

    Key: A (outdo; defy)

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.". The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

34. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 72 shapes its tone: “Here’s a skull now; this skull has lain in the earth three and twenty years.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “twenty” (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 72) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Death levels the mighty. The evidence is “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words “turn” and “clay” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.".

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 100 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “What is he whose grief Bears such an emphasis? whose phrase of sorrow Conjures the wandering stars, and makes them stand Like wonder-wounded hearers?” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 100) develops appearance and reality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Its words “wandering” and “emphasis” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The Attendants part them, and they come out of the grave.” (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 106), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

37. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 45 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “I think it be thine, indeed; for thou liest in’t.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 45) develops appearance and reality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Its words “indeed” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Thou dost lie in’t, to be in’t and say it is thine: ’tis for the dead, not for the quick; therefore thou liest.” (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 47), so

the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

38. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. The first line: a play of questions.

    B. Another prince who has lost a father.

    C. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

    D. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    Key: C (Hamlet's claim at the grave.)

39. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene I, paragraph 33 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “It might be the pate of a politician, which this ass now o’er-reaches; one that would circumvent God, might it not?” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 33) develops corruption and the state: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Its words “politician” and “circumvent” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Did these bones cost no more the breeding, but to play at loggats with ’em? mine ache to think on’t.” (Act V, Scene I, paragraph 37), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 17, 1, 9, 18, 2, 3, 19, 12, 20, 13, 21, 22, 14, 23, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	10, 8, 6, 17, 1, 25, 7, 20, 13, 26, 21, 27, 28, 29, 30, 16	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 31, 4, 6, 1, 32, 18, 20, 21, 13, 33, 34, 29, 15, 35, 30	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 1, 10, 4, 7, 18, 20, 21, 13, 14, 29, 27, 15, 24, 36, 37	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	25, 32, 17, 10, 38, 13, 20, 23, 27, 29, 34, 15, 35, 16, 39, 37	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	8, 7, 31, 1, 38, 20, 11, 14, 34, 29, 23, 27, 39, 16, 37, 24	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	1, 9, 8, 13, 38, 21, 23, 34, 14, 22, 29, 24, 30, 39, 35, 37	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 8, 1, 10, 13, 23, 22, 29, 34, 14, 37, 36, 30, 35, 16, 39	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	31, 8, 1, 10, 9, 14, 34, 27, 23, 28, 37, 36, 16, 39, 30, 24	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 6
Graduate / PhD	18, 8, 1, 26, 38, 20, 14, 33, 34, 29, 39, 30, 16, 36, 37, 24	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 6

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act V, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show the graveyard? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the graveyard? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene I suggests about the graveyard. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act V, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act V, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the graveyard responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act V, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the graveyard follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene I and its treatment of the graveyard. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the graveyard in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the graveyard. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *To outface me with leaping in her grave?*

   As used in the text, what does the word "outface" most nearly mean?

   A. a builder of ships

   B. outdo; defy

   C. coroner

   D. deeds transferring property

2. *How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us. By the Lord, Horatio, these three years I have taken a note of it; the age is grown so picked that the toe of the peasant comes so near the heel of the courtier, he galls his kibe. How long hast thou been a grave-maker?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act V, Scene I"?

   A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   B. The graveyard

   C. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

   D. Claudius at prayer

SAT key: 1. B (outdo; defy); 2. B (The graveyard)

Lesson 22: Act V, Scene II

Focus: the duel and the deaths

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act V, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Hamlet is, through the whole play, rather an instrument than an agent. After he has, by the stratagem of the play, convicted the King, he makes no attempt to punish him, and his death is at last effected by an incident which Hamlet has no part in producing.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note on Hamlet*; public domain). Debate: "There's a divinity that shapes our ends." Is Hamlet's passivity in V.ii defeat or acceptance? *Objective:* Evaluate Hamlet's agency in the final scene. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, RL.11-12.5

Content note (poisoning, multiple deaths, suicide (attempted, prevented), incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Four principal characters die on stage. Focus on justice and responsibility, not methods. Horatio reaches for the poisoned cup ('I am more an antique Roman than a Dane: / Here's yet some liquor left'), and the dying Hamlet stops him: 'Absent thee from felicity awhile, / And in this harsh world draw thy breath in pain, / To tell my story' (5.2). Use the safe-messaging script; do not dwell on methods. Frame it as Hamlet asking his friend to live and tell his story: staying is the braver choice. Hamlet calls Claudius 'thou incestuous, murderous, damned Dane'. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…e to play. Ay, my good lord. Set me the stoups of wine upon that table. If Hamlet give the fir…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: The ending shows several deaths. Horatio is ready to die with his friend; Hamlet asks him to stay alive and tell his story. Staying, and telling the story, is the braver choice. If you're struggling, call or text 988.
Suggested language: “Is the ending just?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.

Background: Royal successions were often decided by force.

Significance: The tragedy's resolution.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is the ending just? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: The ending shows several deaths. Horatio is ready to die with his friend; Hamlet asks him to stay alive and tell his story. Staying, and telling the story, is the braver choice. If you're struggling, call or text 988. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Is the ending just?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: disclaiming — denial; lapwing — a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head; rapiers — light slender swords; woodcock — a bird easily caught; a fool; springe — a trap for birds. "disclaiming": Origin of "disclaim": Anglo-Norman disclaimer.
Words: disclaiming: denial · lapwing: a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head · rapiers: light slender swords · woodcock: a bird easily caught; a fool · springe: a trap for birds

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Royal successions were often decided by force. The tragedy's resolution. Plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Aside. It is the poison'd cup: it is too late" (Act V, Scene II, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Horatio that a divinity shapes our ends, however roughly we plan them. Next, craft. I notice the image of a craftsman's rough cut finished by a higher hand. The strongest word is "divinity": it names a guiding power, Providence, beyond human plans. Then, effect. What has Hamlet come to believe before the duel? My answer: Hamlet now trusts fate rather than his own schemes; his calm acceptance prepares him for the duel and his death.

> *There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Horatio that a divinity shapes our ends, however roughly we plan them. Next, craft. I notice the image of a craftsman's rough cut finished by a higher hand. The strongest word is "divinity": it names a guiding power, Providence, beyond human plans. Then, effect. What has Hamlet come to believe before the duel? My answer: Hamlet now trusts fate rather than his own schemes; his calm acceptance prepares him for the duel and his death.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

> *the readiness is all (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is the ending just? Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?
Anchor question: Is the ending just?
Facilitation: Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. (“the readiness is all”, Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. (“the readiness is all”, Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the duel and the deaths. Key takeaway: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
- **Structure:** Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Aside. It is the poison’d cup: it is too late” (Act V, Scene II, King).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “Aside. It is the poison’d cup: it is too late” (Act V, Scene II, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's new trust in providence.
- “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Acceptance before the duel.
- “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's last words.
- “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio) Horatio's farewell.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone.
Evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
disclaiming (noun)	denial	*Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have*	“disclaiming”: Origin of “disclaim”: Anglo-Norman disclaimer. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://

		shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother.	en.wiktionary.org/wiki/disclaim#Etymology)
lapwing (noun)	a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head	*This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.*	
rapiers (noun)	light slender swords	*Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*	
woodcock (noun)	a bird easily caught; a fool	*Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.*	
springe (noun)	a trap for birds	*Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.*	
bloodily (adverb)	in a bloody way	*O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So bloodily hast struck?*	
sequent (adjective)	following	*Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was sequent Thou know'st already.*	"sequent": Origin: Middle French sequent; earlier Old French sequent. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/sequent#Etymology)
portraiture (noun)	image; likeness	*But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The portraiture of his: I'll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion.*	
changeling (noun)	substitute	*I had my father's signet in my purse, Which was the model of that Danish seal; Folded the writ up in form of the other, Subscribed it, gave't the impression, placed it safely, The changeling never known.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is the ending just?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They were executed in England.
2. Who drinks the poisoned cup? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. How does Hamlet kill Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poisoned sword and drink
4. Who confesses the plot? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes
5. Who becomes king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras
6. What are Hamlet's last words? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The rest is silence
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother." What does "disclaiming" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: disclaiming: denial.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: To tell his story.
2. What does "Act V, Scene II" suggest about the duel and the deaths? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The tragedy's resolution.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Why, even in that was heaven ordinant.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act V, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet…
7. How does “Act V, Scene II” build on “Act V, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is the ending just?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. On

structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Who is most responsible for the deaths? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The tragedy's resolution.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act V, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the duel and the deaths. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act V, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act V, Scene II” treats the duel and the deaths with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. As the final scene, does this ending resolve revenge and justice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What are Hamlet's last words?

   A. Farewell

   B. Good night

   C. The rest is silence

   D. Remember me

   Key: C (The rest is silence)

2. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?
   Sample answer: They were executed in England.

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother.", what does "disclaiming" most nearly mean?

   A. imagination; a figment

   B. full of sores

   C. denial

   D. placed in a coffin

   Key: C (denial)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Horatio: "Good night, sweet prince; / And _____ of angels sing thee to thy rest"
   Key: flights

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Hamlet: "There's a _____ that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will"
   Key: divinity

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Hamlet kill Claudius?

   A. Poisoned sword and drink

   B. A fall

   C. Strangling

   D. A pistol

   Key: A (Poisoned sword and drink)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who confesses the plot?

   A. Horatio

   B. Osric

   C. Gertrude

   D. Laertes

Key: D (Laertes)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.”, what does “rapiers” most nearly mean?

   A. light slender swords

   B. a builder of ships

   C. without a body; imagined

   D. wild; rebellious

   Key: A (light slender swords)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.”, what does “lapwing” most nearly mean?

   A. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

   B. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   C. indirect means

   D. villainous; sly

   Key: A (a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

    A. The Ghost on the battlements

    B. Hamlet hides the body

    C. The duel and the deaths

    D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    Key: C (The duel and the deaths)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live?

    Sample answer: To tell his story: Horatio's farewell. The evidence is “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence. The evidence is “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's last words. The evidence is “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “silence” and “rest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Appearance and reality

    D. Death and mortality

    Key: D (Death and mortality)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Who is most responsible for the deaths?
    Sample answer: A judgment: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Why, as a woodcock to mine own _____, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery." Word bank: lapwing, springe, rapiers, disclaiming
    Key: springe

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The _____ of his: I'll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion." Word bank: disclaiming, portraiture, lapwing, rapiers
    Key: portraiture

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was _____ Thou know'st already." Word bank: sequent, disclaiming, lapwing, rapiers
    Key: sequent

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who becomes king?

    A. Osric

    B. Horatio

    C. Laertes

    D. Fortinbras

    Key: D (Fortinbras)

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act V, Scene II"? Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Plot

    D. Theme

    Key: C (Plot)

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its

meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence. The evidence is “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “divinity” and “shapes” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.". The evidence is “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) — Acceptance before the duel. This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act V, Scene I to Act V, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act V, Scene I, Hamlet, the text reads “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. In Act V, Scene II, “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet's new trust in providence. Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 37? “Sir, his definement suffers no perdition in you; though, I know, to divide him _____ would dizzy the arithmetic of memory, and yet but yaw neither, in respect of his quick sail.”

    A. understand

    B. inventorially

    C. proceed

    D. gracious

    Key: B (inventorially)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 59? “The king, sir, hath laid, that in a dozen passes between yourself and him, he shall not exceed you three hits: he hath laid on twelve for nine; and it would come to _____ trial, if your lordship would vouchsafe the answer.”

    A. approve

    B. bonnet

    C. immediate

    D. gracious

    Key: C (immediate)

27. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 9 reveal about the character or situation? “Here’s the commission: read it at more leisure.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 9) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “commission” and “leisure” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

28. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 61 reveal about the character or situation? “I mean, my lord, the opposition of your person in trial.” Answer in

two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 61) shows the situation turning on revenge and justice: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words "opposition" and "person" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 27 shapes its tone: "He hath much land, and fertile: let a beast be lord of beasts, and his crib shall stand at the king's mess: 'tis a chough; but, as I say, spacious in the possession of dirt." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "possession" and "spacious" (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 27) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 33 shapes its tone: "But yet methinks it is very sultry and hot for my complexion." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "complexion" and "methinks" (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 33) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 94 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: "I do not fear it; I have seen you both: But since he is better'd, we have therefore odds." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 94) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Its words "therefore" and "better" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Set me the stoups of wine upon that table." (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 98), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

32. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 3: "So much for this, sir: now shall you see the other; You do remember all the _____?" Word bank: conceited, northerly, understand, circumstance

    Key: circumstance

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 82 shapes its tone: "Enter King, Queen, Laertes, Lords, Osric, and Attendants with foils, etc." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 82) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to action and delay: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 50 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: "I mean, sir, for his weapon; but in the imputation laid on him by them, in his meed he's unfellowed." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 50) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Its words "imputation" and "unfellowed" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "The phrase would be more german to the matter, if we could carry cannon by our sides: I would it might be hangers till…" (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 58), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

35. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 49: “I dare not confess that, lest I should compare with him in _____; but, to know a man well, were to know himself.” Word bank: approve, understand, excellence, circumstance

    Key: excellence

36. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    B. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

    C. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    D. Another prince who has lost a father.

    Key: C (Hamlet's new trust in providence.)

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 72 shapes its tone: “The king and queen and all are coming down.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “coming” (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 72) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 39 to the story's treatment of corruption and the state: “The concernancy, sir? why do we wrap the gentleman in our more rawer breath?” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 39) develops corruption and the state: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Its words “concernancy” and “gentleman” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “His purse is empty already; all’s golden words are spent.” (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 44), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating corruption and the state as central.

39. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 110 to the story's treatment of appearance and reality: “Here, Hamlet, take my napkin, rub thy brows: The queen carouses to thy fortune, Hamlet.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 110) develops appearance and reality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Its words “carouses” and “fortune” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “It is the poison’d cup: it is too late.” (Act V, Scene II, paragraph 114), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating appearance and reality as central.

40. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 31: “No, believe me, ’tis very cold; the wind is _____.” Word bank: proceed, understand, northerly, excellence

    Key: northerly

41. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So _____ hast struck?” Word bank: lapwing, bloodily, rapiers, disclaiming

    Key: bloodily

42. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Another prince who has lost a father.

B. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

C. Acceptance before the duel.

D. The first line: a play of questions.

Key: C (Acceptance before the duel.)

43. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Who drinks the poisoned cup?

A. Laertes

B. Gertrude

C. Claudius

D. Hamlet

Key: B (Gertrude)

44. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which word completes this sentence from Act V, Scene II, paragraph 27? “Thy state is the more _____; for ’tis a vice to know him.”

A. edified

B. lordship

C. business

D. gracious

Key: D (gracious)

45. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “readiness” and “all” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 6, 7, 18, 19, 9, 8, 20, 2, 1, 11, 12, 21, 14, 15, 22	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 9, 4, 5, 20, 8, 1, 17, 13, 11, 10, 23, 14, 15, 16, 24	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 4, 6, 25, 26, 27, 13, 10, 12, 28, 29, 14, 30, 15, 24, 31	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 4, 26, 25, 32, 11, 28, 27, 12, 33, 15, 30, 14, 31, 34, 24	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	35, 5, 7, 36, 12, 10, 11, 15, 37, 29, 14, 30, 34, 38, 24, 39	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	40, 41, 20, 27, 36, 42, 28, 37, 14, 15, 30, 29, 39, 34, 31, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	41, 40, 43, 6, 7, 20, 29, 33, 37, 30, 23, 39, 24, 38, 34, 31	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	1, 26, 41, 19, 11, 37, 15, 30, 33, 21, 34, 39, 24, 31, 16, 38	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	44, 17, 41, 43, 6, 7, 14, 37, 29, 33, 34, 39, 24, 16, 31, 38	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 4, synthesis 6
Graduate / PhD	18, 41, 43, 6, 7, 15, 29, 30, 39, 38, 22, 16, 31, 45, 34, 24	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 3, synthesis 8

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act V, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show the duel and the deaths? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the duel and the deaths? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene II suggests about the duel and the deaths. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act V, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act V, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the duel and the deaths responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act V, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the duel and the deaths follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene II and its treatment of the duel and the deaths. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the duel and the deaths in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the duel and the deaths. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “rapiers” most nearly mean?

   A. light slender swords

   B. image; likeness

   C. following

   D. substitute

2. *Why, even in that was heaven ordinant. I had my father’s signet in my purse, Which was the model of that Danish seal; Folded the writ up in form of the other, Subscribed it, gave’t the impression, placed it safely, The changeling never known. Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was sequent Thou know’st already.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

   A. The duel and the deaths

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. The Mousetrap

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. A (light slender swords); 2. A (The duel and the deaths)

Unit test

Hamlet: unit test · 90 minutes · 50 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax’d of other nations: They clepe us _____, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform’d at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.” Word bank: hearsed, cerements, beckons, drunkards
   Key: drunkards
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My hour is almost come, When I to _____ and tormenting flames Must render up myself.” Word bank: sulphurous, ambiguous, howsoever, traitorous
   Key: sulphurous
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With _____ of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!” Word bank: ambiguous, witchcraft, howsoever, traitorous
   Key: witchcraft
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.”, what does “ambiguous” most nearly mean?
   A. knowing in advance
   B. open to more than one meaning
   C. trickery
   D. in a state of gross sin, unprepared
   Key: B (open to more than one meaning)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, Ghost: “Revenge his foul and most _____ murder”
   Key: unnatural

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.", what does "howsoever" most nearly mean?

   A. a thief; pickpocket

   B. imagination; a figment

   C. tricked; deceived

   D. in whatever way

   Key: D (in whatever way)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Reynaldo told to do?

   A. Fight Laertes

   B. Bring money only

   C. Spy on Laertes

   D. Find Hamlet

   Key: C (Spy on Laertes)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "This is the very _____ of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures." Word bank: brothel, indirections, ecstasy, windlasses

   Key: ecstasy

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene I, Ophelia: "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so _____"

   Key: affrighted

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…", what does "windlasses" most nearly mean?

    A. roundabout methods

    B. picture; portrait

    C. prohibition; ban (on playing)

    D. quickness; speed

    Key: A (roundabout methods)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…", what does "cutpurse" most nearly mean?

    A. coroner

    B. knowing in advance

    C. a thief; pickpocket

    D. sugared; flattering

    Key: C (a thief; pickpocket)

12. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet: "Thou wretched, rash, _____ fool, farewell"

    Key: intruding

13. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who sees the Ghost this time?

    A. Polonius
    B. Both
    C. Only Hamlet
    D. Gertrude

    Key: C (Only Hamlet)

14. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.", what does "penetrable" most nearly mean?

    A. capable of being pierced
    B. the day of final judgment
    C. pressed with requests; courted
    D. image; likeness

    Key: A (capable of being pierced)

15. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Confess yourself to heaven; Repent what's past; avoid what is to come; And do not spread the _____ on the weeds, To make them ranker." Word bank: cutpurse, bodiless, compost, prating

    Key: compost

16. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet urge Gertrude?

    A. Leave Denmark
    B. Kill Claudius
    C. Avoid Claudius's bed
    D. Confess publicly

    Key: C (Avoid Claudius's bed)

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does Polonius hide?

    A. In the hall
    B. Under the bed
    C. In a closet
    D. Behind the arras

    Key: D (Behind the arras)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "My soul is full of _____ and dismay." Word bank: mineral, discord

    Key: discord

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.", what does "mineral" most nearly mean?

    A. a mine of ore

B. last night

C. dark as night; here, mourning-black

D. light slender swords

Key: A (a mine of ore)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what replication should be made by the son of a king?", what does "replication" most nearly mean?

A. fear; perception

B. the purest essence

C. full of sores

D. a reply or answer

Key: D (a reply or answer)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who reports her death?

A. Laertes

B. Gertrude

C. Horatio

D. Claudius

Key: B (Gertrude)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "To outface me with leaping in her grave?", what does "outface" most nearly mean?

A. outdo; defy

B. one who borrows

C. a sport; diversion

D. causing great pain

Key: A (outdo; defy)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose grave is being dug?

A. Polonius's

B. Gertrude's

C. Hamlet's

D. Ophelia's

Key: D (Ophelia's)

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was _____ Thou know'st already." Word bank: sequent, disclaiming, lapwing, rapiers

Key: sequent

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who drinks the poisoned cup?

A. Claudius

B. Laertes

C. Hamlet

D. Gertrude

Key: D (Gertrude)

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So _____ hast struck?” Word bank: disclaiming, lapwing, bloodily, rapiers

    Key: bloodily

27. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The _____ of his: I'll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion.” Word bank: disclaiming, portraiture, lapwing, rapiers

    Key: portraiture

28. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who becomes king?

    A. Osric

    B. Horatio

    C. Laertes

    D. Fortinbras

    Key: D (Fortinbras)

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Why, as a woodcock to mine own _____, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.” Word bank: lapwing, springe, rapiers, disclaiming

    Key: springe

30. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position. The evidence is “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

31. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae)

    A. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

    B. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

    C. Another prince who has lost a father.

    D. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

    Key: C (Another prince who has lost a father.)

32. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene IV”?

    A. Polonius spies on Laertes

    B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    C. The duel and the deaths

    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    Key: D (Hamlet sees the Ghost)

33. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Corruption. The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

34. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Polonius's method. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

35. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene II”?

A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

B. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

C. The Mousetrap

D. Polonius spies on Laertes

Key: C (The Mousetrap)

36. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost?
Sample answer: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice. The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

37. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety. The evidence is “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

38. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Riddle. The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

39. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge. The evidence is “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

40. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Mortality. The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.

41. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene IV”?

A. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

B. The Ghost's revelation

C. Fortinbras's army

D. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

Key: C (Fortinbras's army)

42. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? ‘Scene: Denmark’: a single kingdom, a court, a castle.

    A. Conflict

    B. Setting

    C. Allusion

    D. Plot

    Key: B (Setting)

43. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius uses lies to find truth.

    A. Alliteration

    B. Metaphor

    C. Irony

    D. Tone / mood

    Key: C (Irony)

44. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Claudius's political move. The evidence is “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion. The words “friends” and “wisest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

45. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Symbolism

    C. Point of view

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)

46. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.". The evidence is “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) — Acceptance before the duel. This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

47. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Plot

    D. Theme

    Key: C (Plot)

48. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles. The evidence is “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. The words “mother” and “queen” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

49. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act IV, Scene I to Act IV, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene I, Queen, the text reads “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” — Gertrude's description. In Act IV, Scene II, “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) — Rosencrantz as sponge. The courtiers serve the king.

50. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence. The evidence is “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “divinity” and “shapes” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

51. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who killed him?

    A. Fortinbras
    B. Gertrude
    C. Polonius
    D. Claudius

    Key: D (Claudius)

52. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do?

    A. Pray for him
    B. Marry Ophelia
    C. Remember him and take revenge
    D. Leave Denmark

    Key: C (Remember him and take revenge)

53. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so _____!” Word bank: windlasses, brothel, indirections, affrighted

    Key: affrighted

54. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where is Reynaldo sent?

    A. London
    B. Wittenberg
    C. Paris
    D. Norway

Key: C (Paris)

55. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "By heaven, it is as proper to our age To cast beyond ourselves in our opinions As it is common for the younger sort To lack _____." Word bank: brothel, windlasses, discretion, indirections

    Key: discretion

56. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.", what does "prating" most nearly mean?

    A. image; likeness

    B. wooden flutes

    C. curse (a mild oath)

    D. chattering

    Key: D (chattering)

57. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.", what does "bodiless" most nearly mean?

    A. deeds transferring property

    B. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

    C. unbending

    D. without a body; imagined

    Key: D (without a body; imagined)

58. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I: "Come, Gertrude, we'll call up our wisest _____"

    Key: friends

59. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who leaps into the grave?

    A. Only Horatio

    B. Claudius

    C. Laertes and Hamlet

    D. Gertrude

    Key: C (Laertes and Hamlet)

60. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I tell thee she is: and therefore make her grave straight: the _____ hath sat on her, and finds it Christian burial." Word bank: shipwright, equivocation, crowner, outface

    Key: crowner

61. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.", what does "woodcock" most nearly mean?

    A. a mother of children

    B. a bird easily caught; a fool

    C. favor and approval

    D. in whatever way

    Key: B (a bird easily caught; a fool)

62. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Horatio: “Good night, sweet prince; / And _____ of angels sing thee to thy rest”

    Key: flights

63. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line “Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o’er the house, And hurt my brother.”, what does “disclaiming” most nearly mean?

    A. imagination; a figment

    B. full of sores

    C. denial

    D. placed in a coffin

    Key: C (denial)

64. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Hamlet: “There’s a _____ that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will”

    Key: divinity

65. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

    A. The plot against Hamlet

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    D. Fortinbras's army

    Key: B (The court of Denmark)

66. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Acceptance before the duel.

    B. Death levels the mighty.

    C. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    D. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

    Key: C (Hamlet sees the Ghost.)

67. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene V”?

    A. The Ghost's revelation

    B. Polonius spies on Laertes

    C. The court of Denmark

    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    Key: A (The Ghost's revelation)

68. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The Ghost's command. The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

69. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius. The evidence is “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

70. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Gertrude's description. The evidence is “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

71. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's flowers. The evidence is “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

72. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The pirate attack. The evidence is “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

73. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence. The evidence is “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

74. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae).
    Sample answer: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict. The evidence is “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) — Gertrude's two roles. This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

75. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.
    A. Symbolism
    B. Allusion
    C. Tone / mood
    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: D (Foreshadowing)

76. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Indirection.
    A. Appearance and reality
    B. Action and delay

C. Death and mortality

D. Revenge and justice

Key: A (Appearance and reality)

77. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene IV”? Hamlet confronts Gertrude.

A. Theme

B. Setting

C. Characterization

D. Hyperbole

Key: C (Characterization)

78. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I).

Sample answer: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay.". The evidence is “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) — Claudius's anxiety. This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

79. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen).

Sample answer: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury. The evidence is “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen) — Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

80. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet's claim at the grave. The evidence is “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words “brothers” and “quantity” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

81. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene I”? The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.

A. Simile

B. Personification

C. Characterization

D. Allusion

Key: C (Characterization)

82. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position. The evidence is “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. The words

"present" and "nephew" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

83. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Who is most responsible for the deaths?
Sample answer: A judgment: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

84. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.", what does "brothel" most nearly mean?

A. one who challenges others
B. release; acquittal
C. outdo; defy
D. a house of prostitution

Key: D (a house of prostitution)

85. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How was Hamlet dressed?
Sample answer: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.

86. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whom will Polonius tell?

A. Laertes
B. Gertrude only
C. The king
D. Horatio

Key: C (The king)

87. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] In the line "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…", what does "indirections" most nearly mean?

A. distresses deeply; tears at
B. indirect means
C. graft onto
D. of sulphur; hellish

Key: B (indirect means)

88. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I am glad of it: a _____ speech sleeps in a foolish ear." Word bank: knavish, replication
Key: knavish

89. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz?

A. A friend
B. A sponge
C. A fool
D. A rat

Key: B (A sponge)

90. [short · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Hamlet say about the body and king?

    Sample answer: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

91. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who asks where the body is?

    A. Gertrude

    B. Horatio

    C. Claudius

    D. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern

    Key: D (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern)

92. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Whose favour does the sponge soak up?

    A. Polonius's

    B. Hamlet's

    C. The king's

    D. Gertrude's

    Key: C (The king's)

93. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Hamlet kill Claudius?

    A. Poisoned sword and drink

    B. A fall

    C. Strangling

    D. A pistol

    Key: A (Poisoned sword and drink)

94. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who confesses the plot?

    A. Horatio

    B. Osric

    C. Gertrude

    D. Laertes

    Key: D (Laertes)

95. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles. The evidence is “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

96. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene III”?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. The Ghost on the battlements

    D. Claudius at prayer

    Key: A (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

97. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Thinking prevents action. The evidence is "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

98. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. The evidence is "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth.

99. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Acting advice. The evidence is "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth.

100. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Claudius confesses. The evidence is "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

101. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Death levels the mighty. The evidence is "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

102. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

A. Hamlet's claim at the grave.
B. Another prince who has lost a father.
C. Mood: cold and unease.
D. Acceptance before the duel.

Key: A (Hamlet's claim at the grave.)

103. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

104. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in "Dramatis Personae"? Hamlet is 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king': his whole conflict in one line.

A. Simile
B. Characterization
C. Allusion
D. Imagery

Key: B (Characterization)

105. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Which literary element does this describe in "Act I, Scene V"? Remember me.

A. Theme
B. Setting

C. Alliteration

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)

106. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Polonius's diagnosis. The evidence is “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. The words “ecstasy” and “very” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

107. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Claudius worries about public opinion.

A. Revenge and justice

B. Action and delay

C. Appearance and reality

D. Corruption and the state

Key: D (Corruption and the state)

108. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet runs. The evidence is “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words “after” and “and” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

109. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. The evidence is “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “aslant” and “willow” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

110. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

A. Death and mortality

B. Revenge and justice

C. Appearance and reality

D. Action and delay

Key: A (Death and mortality)

111. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet accepts whatever comes: ‘the readiness is all.’

A. Simile

B. Tone / mood

C. Allusion

D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

112. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act I, Scene III to Act II, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene III, Polonius, the text reads “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” — Polonius's advice. In Act II, Scene I, “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. Indirection.

113. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Polonius's method. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. The words “indirections” and “directions” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.".

114. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Is Hamlet mad here?

    Sample answer: A reasoned view: Riddle. The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

115. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Riddle. The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words “with” and “king” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

116. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. The words “poor” and “knew” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.".

117. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene I, Polonius: “This is the very _____ of love”

    Key: ecstasy

118. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what _____ should be made by the son of a king?” Word bank: replication, knavish

    Key: replication

119. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.”, what does “knavish” most nearly mean?

    A. causing great pain

    B. conflict; distress

    C. villainous; sly

    D. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

Key: C (villainous; sly)

120. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] How does Hamlet answer?

A. Silently

B. In riddles

C. With a letter

D. Directly

Key: B (In riddles)

121. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] What does Hamlet do at the end?

A. Confesses

B. Runs off

C. Weeps

D. Fights

Key: B (Runs off)

122. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line "This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.", what does "lapwing" most nearly mean?

A. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

B. a man whose wife is unfaithful

C. indirect means

D. villainous; sly

Key: A (a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head)

123. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line "Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.", what does "rapiers" most nearly mean?

A. light slender swords

B. a builder of ships

C. without a body; imagined

D. wild; rebellious

Key: A (light slender swords)

124. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Atmosphere. The evidence is "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

125. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

126. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

Sample answer: She describes him as mad: Gertrude's description. The evidence is "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion.

127. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What does the sponge image mean?
Sample answer: Courtiers are used and discarded: Rosencrantz as sponge. The evidence is “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

128. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Death levels all. The evidence is “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars.

129. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach. The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves.

130. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. The evidence is “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

131. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

132. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live?
Sample answer: To tell his story: Horatio's farewell. The evidence is “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

133. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).
Sample answer: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.". The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

134. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Gertrude's shame. The evidence is “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. The words “speak” and “more” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

135. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene I”? Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.

A. Simile
B. Characterization
C. Tone / mood
D. Alliteration

Key: B (Characterization)

136. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene I”? Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.

A. Point of view

B. Irony

C. Setting

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: D (Diction / vocabulary)

137. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] What frightened Ophelia?

A. Laertes's letter

B. Her father's anger

C. Hamlet's strange visit

D. A ghost

Key: C (Hamlet's strange visit)

138. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s _____”

Key: countenance

139. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Appearance versus reality. The evidence is “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".

140. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Polonius's advice. The evidence is “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

141. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Hamlet on humanity. The evidence is “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

142. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

Sample answer: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!". The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) — The Ghost's command. This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember.

143. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene V”? The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.

A. Alliteration

B. Characterization

C. Symbolism

D. Simile

Key: B (Characterization)

144. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.

A. Tone / mood

B. Characterization

C. Allusion

D. Theme

Key: B (Characterization)

145. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King).

Sample answer: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.". The evidence is “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King) — Claudius cannot pray. This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation.

146. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Gertrude's guilt.

A. Revenge and justice

B. Action and delay

C. Appearance and reality

D. Corruption and the state

Key: D (Corruption and the state)

147. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Claudius and Laertes this device a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.

A. Hyperbole

B. Plot

C. Simile

D. Irony

Key: B (Plot)

148. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The Ghost's farewell. The evidence is “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “remember” and “adieu” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!".

149. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue.

Sample answer: A reasoned reading: Polonius's diagnosis. The evidence is “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.".

150. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from Act III, Scene IV to Act IV, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet, the text reads “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” — Hamlet kills Polonius. In Act IV, Scene I, “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) — Gertrude's description. Claudius worries about public opinion.

151. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. The evidence is “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “church” and “throat” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

152. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Is Hamlet's grief sincere?
Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.".

153. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.”, what does “fencing” most nearly mean?

A. indirect means

B. a house of prostitution

C. roundabout methods

D. sword-fighting for sport

Key: D (sword-fighting for sport)

154. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.11-12.1] What are Hamlet's last words?

A. Farewell

B. The rest is silence

C. Remember me

D. Good night

Key: B (The rest is silence)

155. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene I”?

A. Worms and kings

B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

C. The duel and the deaths

D. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

Key: B (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

156. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] Why is Hamlet's return important?
Sample answer: He comes back to complete revenge. The evidence is “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

157. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one

detail.

Sample answer: Laertes adds poison to the plan. The evidence is “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.".

158. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

A. Another prince who has lost a father.

B. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

C. Death levels the mighty.

D. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

Key: C (Death levels the mighty.)

159. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king”

A. Dramatis Personae

B. Act III, Scene IV

C. Act IV, Scene IV

D. Act IV, Scene VII

Key: A (Dramatis Personae)

160. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Ophelia's obedience. The evidence is “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “shall” and “obey” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

161. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet's reluctance. The evidence is “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “cursed” and “joint” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

162. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier”

A. Act V, Scene II

B. Act II, Scene II

C. Act IV, Scene I

D. Act I, Scene I

Key: C (Act IV, Scene I)

163. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).

Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the

king is not with the body.". The evidence is “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king.

164. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will”

A. Act IV, Scene III

B. Act V, Scene II

C. Act V, Scene I

D. Act II, Scene II

Key: B (Act V, Scene II)

165. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Appearance versus reality. The evidence is “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not ‘seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “seems” and “madam” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!".

166. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from Act I, Scene II to Act I, Scene III. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act I, Scene II, Hamlet, the text reads “A little more than kin, and less than kind” — Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. In Act I, Scene III, “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) — Polonius's advice. Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

167. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Corruption. The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words “rotten” and “state” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.".

168. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's chance. The evidence is “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “praying” and “might” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.".

169. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Claudius confesses. The evidence is “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “offence” and “heaven” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below.".

170. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius. The evidence is “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt. The words “ducat” and “dead” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.".

171. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge. The evidence is “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: the courtiers serve the king. The words “countenance” and “soaks” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.".

172. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act IV, Scene III to Act V, Scene I. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet, the text reads “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” — Death levels all. In Act V, Scene I, “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

173. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Shall I strike at it with my _____?” Word bank: harrows, foreknowing, partisan, doomsday
Key: partisan

174. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does Polonius conclude?

A. Hamlet is ill

B. Hamlet is spying

C. Hamlet is mad for love

D. Hamlet is faking

Key: C (Hamlet is mad for love)

175. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Why is Polonius's method ironic?
Sample answer: He uses lies to discover truth. The evidence is “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) — Polonius's method. This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

176. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What can you infer from this line? “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Ophelia's fear. The evidence is “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia). This develops appearance and reality: indirection.

177. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Why does the priest limit the rites?
Sample answer: Her death was doubtful: Death levels the mighty. The evidence is “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

178. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What does this passage most clearly show? “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

A. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

B. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

C. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

D. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

Key: C (Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.)

179. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio).

Sample answer: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.". The evidence is “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio) — Horatio's reading of the Ghost. This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

180. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

Sample answer: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!". The evidence is “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) — First soliloquy. This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'".

181. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark”

A. Act I, Scene IV

B. Act IV, Scene VII

C. Act V, Scene I

D. Act I, Scene V

Key: A (Act I, Scene IV)

182. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Analyze the word choice in “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet sees the Ghost. The evidence is “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words “ministers” and “defend” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

183. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet).

Sample answer: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.". The evidence is “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet on humanity. This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

184. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “To be, or not to be: that is the question”

A. Dramatis Personae

B. Act IV, Scene V

C. Act V, Scene I

D. Act III, Scene I

Key: D (Act III, Scene I)

185. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.

A. Characterization

B. Simile

C. Hyperbole

D. Imagery

Key: A (Characterization)

186. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

Sample answer: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.". The evidence is “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

187. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from the opening of “Dramatis Personae” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

Sample answer: Near the start, “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) — Hamlet's divided position. Later, “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae) — Another prince who has lost a father. The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

188. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate.

Sample answer: A reasoned judgment: Polonius's advice. The evidence is “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.".

189. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Gertrude's description. The evidence is “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen). This develops corruption and the state: Claudius worries about public opinion. The words “mightier” and “contend” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay.".

190. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. The evidence is “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. The words “thieves” and “dealt” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.".

191. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The pirate attack. The evidence is “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. The words “appointment” and “warlike” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb.".

192. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Laertes adds poison to the plan. The evidence is “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds.". The words “purpose” and “anoint” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

193. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from Act V, Scene I to Act V, Scene II. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Earlier, in Act V, Scene I, Hamlet, the text reads “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. In Act V, Scene II, “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) — Hamlet's new trust in providence. Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

194. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene II”?

A. Claudius at prayer

B. Hamlet hides the body

C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

D. The duel and the deaths

Key: B (Hamlet hides the body)

195. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

A. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

B. The duel and the deaths

C. The Ghost's revelation

D. Claudius at prayer

Key: B (The duel and the deaths)

196. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).

Sample answer: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.". The evidence is “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III,

Polonius) — Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

197. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).
Sample answer: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.". The evidence is “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) — Corruption. This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

198. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “By indirections find directions out”
A. Act II, Scene I
B. Dramatis Personae
C. Act IV, Scene I
D. Act I, Scene II
Key: A (Act II, Scene I)

199. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).
Sample answer: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more.". The evidence is “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) — Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. This develops corruption and the state: Gertrude's guilt.

200. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance”
A. Act IV, Scene V
B. Act IV, Scene II
C. Act III, Scene II
D. Act I, Scene II
Key: A (Act IV, Scene V)

201. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes).
Sample answer: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.". The evidence is “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) — Laertes. This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once.

202. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Hamlet's last words. The evidence is “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “silence” and “rest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

203. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.
A. Action and delay
B. Revenge and justice

C. Death and mortality

D. Appearance and reality

Key: C (Death and mortality)

204. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The first line: a play of questions. The evidence is “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.".

205. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The Ghost's command. The evidence is “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet swears to remember. The words “unnatural” and “murder” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!".

206. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Ophelia's fear. The evidence is “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia). This develops appearance and reality: indirection. The words “affrighted” and “have” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love.".

207. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost?

Sample answer: A judgment: Hamlet on humanity. The evidence is “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.".

208. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Thinking prevents action. The evidence is “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. The words “conscience” and “cowards” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.".

209. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. The evidence is “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. The words “methinks” and “protest” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!".

210. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Acting advice. The evidence is “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: theater reveals truth. The words “action” and “word” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!".

211. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) supports it: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance.". But “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King) complicates it: the line (Claudius) shows the same issue from another side, and its “not” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. The claim is therefore a strong reading, not a complete one, and a careful answer says where it stops applying.

212. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from Act IV, Scene IV to Act IV, Scene VI. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Earlier, in Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet, the text reads “How all occasions do inform against me” — Hamlet's self-reproach. In Act IV, Scene VI, “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) — The pirate attack. Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

213. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel. The evidence is “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. The words “readiness” and “all” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence.".

214. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With _____ stalk hath he gone by our watch.” Word bank: doomsday, martial, harrows, foreknowing
Key: martial

215. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Another prince who has lost a father. The evidence is “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). This develops corruption and the state: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

216. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.

A. Alliteration

B. Setting

C. Personification

D. Hyperbole

Key: B (Setting)

217. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Claim: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum.". The evidence is “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) — Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. This develops death and mortality: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

218. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. The evidence is “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “little” and “than” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!".

219. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Polonius's aside. The evidence is “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words “madness” and “method” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king.".

220. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Life versus death. The evidence is “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death. The words “question” and “that” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.".

221. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Death levels all. The evidence is “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. The words “emperor” and “only” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.".

222. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] What does this passage most clearly show? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Another prince who has lost a father.

    B. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

    C. Acceptance before the duel.

    D. The first line: a play of questions.

Key: C (Acceptance before the duel.)

223. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Horatio's reading of the Ghost. The evidence is “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The words “eruption” and “strange” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

224. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: First soliloquy. The evidence is “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops appearance and reality: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'". The words “would” and “solid” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

225. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.

A. Alliteration
B. Symbolism
C. Imagery
D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

226. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene II”? Soliloquy: ‘O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I.’

A. Structure
B. Simile
C. Metaphor
D. Tone / mood

Key: A (Structure)

227. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: The plan. The evidence is “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. The words “conscience” and “catch” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

228. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

A. Appearance and reality
B. Action and delay
C. Death and mortality
D. Revenge and justice

Key: B (Action and delay)

229. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all”

(Act III, Scene I, Hamlet).

Sample answer: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery.". The evidence is “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) — Thinking prevents action. This develops death and mortality: Hamlet contemplates death.

230. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Claudius cannot pray. The evidence is “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King). This develops revenge and justice: Hamlet wants damnation. The words “thoughts” and “remain” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

231. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene IV”? Soliloquy: ‘How all occasions do inform against me.’

A. Point of view

B. Hyperbole

C. Structure

D. Metaphor

Key: C (Structure)

232. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Claudius. The evidence is “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King). This develops revenge and justice: Laertes acts at once. The words “battalions” and “sorrows” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

233. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VI”? Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.

A. Plot

B. Symbolism

C. Personification

D. Setting

Key: A (Plot)

234. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Mood: cold and unease. The evidence is “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco). This develops corruption and the state: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. The words “bitter” and “heart” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state.".

235. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Mortality. The evidence is “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III,

Hamlet). This develops death and mortality: kings and beggars. The words “progress” and “through” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England.".

236. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach. The evidence is “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The words “occasions” and “against” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!".

237. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.

A. Setting
B. Conflict
C. Metaphor
D. Plot

Key: B (Conflict)

238. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven”

A. Act IV, Scene I
B. Act III, Scene III
C. Act IV, Scene II
D. Act IV, Scene IV

Key: B (Act III, Scene III)

239. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene IV”? Fortinbras as foil.

A. Personification
B. Alliteration
C. Characterization
D. Irony

Key: C (Characterization)

240. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Resolve. The evidence is “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops action and delay: Hamlet resolves. The words “thoughts” and “nothing” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

241. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Analyze the word choice in “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. The evidence is “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). This develops action and delay: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to

Denmark and to his revenge. The words “thine” and “speak” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

242. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.

A. Diction / vocabulary

B. Characterization

C. Tone / mood

D. Setting

Key: B (Characterization)

243. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). The evidence is “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius). This develops appearance and reality: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. The words “ownself” and “thine” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord.".

244. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Atmosphere. The evidence is “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). This develops corruption and the state: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. The words “shrewdly” and “bites” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark.".

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50	recall 29, inference 12, analysis 6, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	2, 51, 4, 52, 53, 54, 10, 55, 8, 12, 11, 15, 56, 57, 19, 18, 58, 20, 59, 60, 61, 26, 25, 62, 63, 64, 65, 31, 66, 67, 68, 69, 36, 70, 38, 71, 72, 73, 74, 75, 76, 77, 78, 45, 79, 80, 81, 82, 49, 83	recall 26, inference 12, analysis 9, synthesis 3
HS Sophomore	84, 85, 7, 86, 87, 55, 54, 88, 89, 90, 91, 92, 20, 93, 26, 63, 24, 94, 61, 95, 30, 31, 96, 66, 33, 97, 98, 99, 100, 69, 40, 72, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 106, 78, 107, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 50	recall 19, inference 16, analysis 9, synthesis 6
HS Junior	84, 87, 86, 54, 55, 117, 118, 119, 120, 121, 88, 122, 28, 61, 123, 26, 31, 124, 66, 100, 125, 126, 39, 127, 128, 129, 71, 72, 130, 131, 101, 132, 104, 106, 133, 43, 134, 78, 107, 135, 136, 110, 80, 46, 48, 82, 115, 114, 83, 50	recall 16, inference 16, analysis 12, synthesis 6
HS Senior	54, 8, 85, 86, 137, 138, 92, 119, 120, 94, 24, 27, 122, 65, 95, 30, 31, 139, 140, 66, 141, 100, 69, 128, 40, 129, 101, 131, 73, 142, 143, 133, 144, 145, 146, 77, 78, 147, 80, 47, 46, 148, 112, 149, 150, 49, 115, 151, 152, 83	recall 13, inference 16, analysis 12, synthesis 9

AP	55, 8, 153, 90, 89, 91, 28, 24, 154, 95, 31, 65, 34, 36, 37, 155, 127, 72, 156, 157, 158, 159, 160, 143, 161, 142, 76, 145, 107, 162, 44, 163, 80, 110, 164, 46, 47, 165, 166, 167, 148, 112, 168, 169, 170, 171, 151, 116, 172, 83	recall 9, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 13
College Freshman	173, 137, 174, 121, 120, 92, 27, 122, 154, 95, 31, 175, 176, 37, 127, 38, 39, 177, 178, 73, 132, 179, 180, 181, 75, 182, 105, 183, 184, 145, 77, 185, 186, 109, 81, 80, 46, 187, 82, 188, 148, 113, 168, 170, 189, 49, 190, 191, 192, 193	recall 9, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 13
College Sophomore	173, 7, 92, 20, 63, 24, 30, 31, 95, 66, 37, 126, 38, 194, 178, 73, 195, 132, 42, 196, 197, 143, 198, 106, 199, 107, 162, 44, 108, 200, 201, 80, 202, 203, 204, 165, 205, 148, 206, 207, 208, 209, 210, 168, 171, 211, 212, 152, 83, 213	recall 6, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 16
College Junior	214, 117, 92, 120, 94, 63, 124, 176, 175, 38, 39, 127, 158, 103, 73, 215, 42, 216, 105, 161, 133, 145, 77, 134, 44, 78, 162, 79, 147, 80, 217, 81, 202, 48, 82, 218, 165, 166, 148, 205, 112, 219, 208, 220, 209, 114, 221, 190, 191, 172	recall 6, inference 9, analysis 18, synthesis 17
College Senior	214, 92, 27, 31, 175, 176, 37, 38, 127, 39, 101, 222, 132, 223, 224, 160, 225, 197, 182, 142, 198, 226, 227, 228, 229, 184, 230, 199, 77, 162, 231, 200, 232, 186, 233, 79, 81, 203, 187, 48, 82, 234, 218, 148, 210, 235, 236, 191, 116, 50	recall 3, inference 10, analysis 25, synthesis 12
Graduate / PhD	214, 63, 65, 34, 175, 126, 127, 39, 132, 103, 159, 215, 223, 180, 237, 160, 75, 142, 105, 106, 43, 227, 229, 145, 238, 107, 162, 163, 45, 108, 239, 240, 200, 201, 241, 242, 109, 80, 202, 47, 48, 218, 243, 167, 244, 206, 219, 210, 236, 191	recall 2, inference 8, analysis 30, synthesis 10

Final paper

Hamlet: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Hamlet and argue how its meaning changes over the play and why that change matters to action and delay.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Hamlet. Argue whether the play judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Hamlet finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of appearance and reality. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 6 quotations from at least three sections, from the beginning, middle and end. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the act, scene and line (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.
Organization	15					

		Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. The text makes this visible when it says “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae). He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Critical voice: “But what Hamlet wanted was not a private revenge, to be followed by his own imprisonment or execution; it was public justice.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III, section on the "external difficulties" theory*; public domain). Careful attribution: Bradley is summarizing a view he goes on to reject (Hamlet's obstacles were external). Students who use it must say so, then decide: does V.ii give us private revenge or public justice? *Objective:* Final paper Prompt 1: trace revenge and justice and argue what the ending suggests. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.2, W.11-12.1, W.11-12.9

Critical voice: “And, in the third place, there is a trait about which doubt is impossible,--a sense in Hamlet that he is in the hands of Providence.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture IV, Lecture IV, on Hamlet after the voyage (Act V)*; public domain). Ending lens: is "There's a divinity that shapes our ends" (V.ii) faith or fatalism? Bradley goes on to call it the latter; students argue for or against. *Objective:* Final paper Prompts 1 and 3: judge Hamlet's final choices and the play's ending. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, W.11-12.9

Essay assignments

Essay: Revenge and justice

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about revenge and justice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and justice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and justice in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and justice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of revenge and justice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Action and delay

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about action and delay. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops action and delay in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops action and delay across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of action and delay. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of action and delay in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of action and delay, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of action and delay in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about action and delay in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on action and delay in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Appearance and reality

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about appearance and reality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of appearance and reality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of appearance and reality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of appearance and reality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of appearance and reality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Death and mortality

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about death and mortality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of death and mortality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of death and mortality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of death and mortality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of death and mortality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Corruption and the state

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about corruption and the state. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of corruption and the state. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of corruption and the state in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of corruption and the state, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of corruption and the state in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on corruption and the state in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on corruption and the state in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about corruption and the state in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on corruption and the state in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified: short origin notes in our own words, with the facts (language, form, meaning) checked against the Online Etymology Dictionary or Wiktionary; no dictionary text is reproduced, and unverified ones are left out. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.

Built from curriculum-v5.9.2 (c0d0b68d).